

PATHWAY TO FREEDOM

TRIMESTER SIX

Resilient: Forging Faith That Endures till the End

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CORRECTED TEXT EDITION

All typesetting errors and trimester number references corrected

CORRECTIONS APPLIED

Trimester Number (Multiple pages)

"Trimester Four" / "fourth trimester" → "Trimester Six" / "sixth trimester" throughout

Conclusion — Next Book Reference (p. 325)

"Trimester Five: Breaking the Addiction to Distraction" → "Trimester Seven"

Typesetting Split Word (p. 9)

"eac h" → "each"

Typesetting Split Word (p. 21)

"Ch rist" → "Christ"

Typesetting Split Word (p. 265)

"Th is" → "This"

Note — Copyright Page (p. 2)

Incomplete sentence ending with a comma needs restoration in source file

Note — Endnote Citation (p. 327)

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Note: Two corrections (copyright page incomplete sentence, stale citation date) require restoration of original source content and are noted above but not applied in this text edition.

Week 1

The Basis of Your Faith

Day 1

Are You Resilient?

I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me.

Philippians 4:13 nkjv

What do we do as followers of Christ when our circumstances careen out of control and we no longer understand what is going on? As believers, how do we react when the confidence we have in our faith is shaken? What happens when our theology and what we believe about God are called into question? How do we deal with situations that are so uncomfortable we can barely make sense of them? How can we possibly prepare ourselves for these moments? How do we develop the backbone of steel needed to take us through them? All too often, when these things happen, people slide off the road of faith and back into the world's ways. They get mad at God and give up on him. Their anger turns into resentment and even full-blown rebellion. What started as misunderstanding and deep hurt leads to many unanswered questions. The difficult situation becomes the reason they turn to atheism or some other spiritual belief down the road.

But there is another path we can take: resilience. Resilient

people bounce back from horrible experiences. They have the grace to remain strong after going through something that almost breaks them.

How do we find that resilience? How can we prepare to be resilient before life's unexpected setbacks hit us in the face? That is what this trimester is about. Together, we are about to explore the underpinnings of faith that lead us in one of two major directions: to give up or to be resilient.

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So many people falter in their faith, barely hanging on and eventually abandoning all they said they would die for. It happens because the foundation they had was not stable in the first place. We must understand the culture surrounding us and the exact message we hear when we come to faith in Christ. Without the proper foundation, there is no chance a building will be stable. In the same way, it is imperative that we build the foundation of our lives on the right belief system before life hits us in the face. Then, when things don't go according to our plans or theology, we have a bedrock of trust in our heavenly Father. In Texas, where we live, much of the ground is constantly shifting, which creates cracks in the walls and foundations of houses and other buildings. Many companies offer to drill deeply below structures to install concrete and steel piers—structural supports—for foundations to rest on. Unless this work is done, the home will eventually crack.

Many Christians' faith looks like the shifting ground I just described. We cannot possibly be resilient without establishing the

proper foundation for our beliefs—both personally and culturally. So we'll start by examining the foundation on which much of Western Christianity has been built. Then we will build piers for our faith so that when the ground shifts, our faith will not crack. As we embark on this journey through this trimester, my prayer is that we will be strengthened and prepared for whatever the Enemy, the world, or life's circumstances might bring our way. Here's my other prayer: that the words of this verse will be for us not just a nice message on a plaque but the screaming anthem of our lives. "I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me" (Philippians 4:13 NKJV). In other words, through Christ, you are resilient.

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Action Steps

Take a moment to memorize and write out Philippians 4:13 here.

Have you or someone you know ever gone through something so difficult that it shook their faith? Describe what happened.

Have you or someone you know ever become stronger because of a tragedy or a crisis of faith? What do you think is the difference between them and someone else who had their faith shaken?

Take a moment right now to pray and ask the Lord to teach you to have a firm foundation for your faith and the kind of resilience that will cause you to never give up.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 1–3

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 2

Living in a Feel-Good World

We live by faith, not by sight.

2 Corinthians 5:7

To build the resilience that will allow us to bounce back (by the grace of God) no matter what hits us, we need to understand the cultural reality we face: we live in a feel-good world.

You could say that the American dream has its own soundtrack made of popular songs that champion our feelings.

For the most part, in our culture, we don't do the right thing; we do what we feel like doing. We don't do the wise thing; we do what we feel like doing. We don't even do what we committed to doing; we do what we feel like doing.

Imagine that you are in the mall and see a new outfit. You know you can't afford it, but you try it on anyway. You feel so good wearing it that you buy it on credit and figure you'll find some way to pay for the credit card bill later. Or maybe you see the brand-new video game that everyone has been talking about. You can't afford it, but it would feel so good to get it before all your friends, and it would be so fun to play. So you go ahead and buy it anyway.

Our culture is driven by feelings. This is one of the reasons why people have to give their word in written contracts.

Usually, most of the contract's text is about what happens if either party breaks their word. Contracts are written that way because people often do what they feel like doing rather than what they committed to doing.

On their wedding day, couples stand before God and everybody else, committing to stay together “till death do us part.” They pledge their lives, their love, and their earthly

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wealth to each other for “as long as we both shall live.” But a few years later, they’ve lost that loving feeling. They can’t explain why, but perhaps now they have feelings for someone else.

When we live by feelings, it’s like living on a roller coaster.

Feelings change daily, sometimes even hourly! God wants us to be steady in our faith no matter if we’re feeling blue or on top of a mountain. No matter if we’re going through the hardest possible circumstances or through a season filled with joy, he wants us to trust him and know that he is faithful.

Second Corinthians 5:7 gives us God’s idea of how we can live. We should not live by what we see, feel, hear, or perceive through any of our five physical senses, but we should live by faith—a knowing in our spirits that he is God. That kind of faith will keep us steady through the storms when all visibility is blurred.

Action Steps

How has our feel-good culture impacted your faith? Are you ever tempted to go with the cultural flow?

What do you fear might happen if you swim against the current?

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Are you living by faith and not by sight? Give an example of when you’ve lived by faith through tough circumstances.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 4–6

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 3

Be True to Yourself?

“The rain came down, the streams rose, and the winds blew and beat against that house; yet it did not fall, because it had its foundation on the rock.”

Matthew 7:25

The logic in our culture has become so convoluted that some people believe they are not being true to themselves if they stay with the person they chose to marry when they no longer have the goose bumps they felt when they first met. They might say, “My feelings for my spouse aren’t there anymore. I would be living a lie. I need to be with this other person whom I now have feelings for.” They don’t care what wreckage their decision to leave their spouse might cause. If they’re parents, they may try to deny how deeply their children’s lives will be affected. If they’re Christians in leadership roles, they may discount the pain those observing the destruction of the marriage will feel. Somehow our culture has managed to convince us that our emotions are the real us. We are told that if we don’t follow our feelings, we are not being authentic, that if we do what is right instead of what we feel like doing, we are being phony. So in a world in which emotions were meant to enhance our lives, we have allowed them to dominate our lives. God gave us emotions

so our lives would be richer and fuller. But we have allowed emotions to enslave us.

In a feel-good culture, it is only natural that some people would surrender to feel-good faith. We make declarations to the Lord: I'll do anything for you, Lord. I'll go to the ends of the earth for you. I'll even die for you. Then when we stayed out too late the night before, we don't go to church because we're too

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tired and want to stay in bed. We make vows to the Lord that we are quick to break the moment our feelings change.

This world has placed a high value on being true to yourself, which really means being true to your own feelings. And we've all seen how that works out. As long as the feelings are good, life is good. When the feelings sour, life and relationships take a turn for the worse. When we're true to our feelings, it's like trying to balance a valuable pearl on the top of a wave. Our lives are like that valuable pearl, and the waves are like our feelings. When we trust in our feelings, our lives get washed into the waves of emotions.

That's why God wants us to be true to him and his Word.

He knows that if we stay focused on him and choose to live by his ways, our lives will be built on a solid rock. The rains can come, the floods may happen, but our lives will stay firmly grounded in him.

Action Steps

You may have been a victim of someone else's feel-good faith.

Perhaps they made decisions based on emotions and not from a

commitment to do what is right and biblical, and you got hurt in the process. You cannot change the person or the situation that you may find yourself in, but you can decide for yourself what kind of person you want to be and what kind of life you want to have. You can make decisions now concerning your faith that will affect you and the people around you for the rest of your life. We can't change other people, but we can change ourselves. Name some ways you want to be rock-solid in your faith no matter what people around you are doing.

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In your own words, describe the world's view of being true to yourself.

How does that compare or contrast with godly authenticity?

How does knowing the difference affect how you will make choices in life?

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 7–8

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 4

Feel-Good Faith

Jesus said to his disciples, “Whoever wants to be my disciple must deny themselves and take up their cross and follow me.

For whoever wants to save their life will lose it, but whoever loses their life for me will find it.”

Matthew 16:24–25

Giving in to temptation and sin is a choice as old as

humankind, and this has affected the fundamental foundation of our belief system. In a culture that has taught us to do what we feel because “it can’t be wrong if it feels so right,” the biggest casualty is our Christianity. Because if our feelings govern our faith, we have a feel-good Christianity—a faith in which we only follow the Lord, obey his commands, and read his Word when we feel like it.

It is no wonder that some Christians find it so hard to have a strong backbone during hard times. If we are quick to break every other commitment when we feel like it, why would we treat our commitment to Christ any differently? Our cultural norms have settled into what we now deem to be “normal” Christianity. We would never overtly say that we follow Jesus only when we feel like it, but for the most part, we Christians have succumbed to a faith that only engages when we are “feelin’ it.”

Here’s a real-life story of someone who developed a resilient faith:

“God, have you forsaken me?” Tamirat was sharing a 13×13-foot cell with forty other inmates. The stench was incredible. Bodies were everywhere. Inmates had to take turns just to lie down. Yet Tamirat never felt so alone.

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Falsely accused by friends for offending the Muslim faith, Tamirat was arrested and tricked into signing a confession. Sentenced to three years in prison, he endured severe beatings from inmates and separation from his wife and children. Isolated and seemingly forgotten, Tamirat

endured. Sixteen months into his prison term, charges against him were reduced. Released shortly afterward, Tamirat said, “May all glory be unto Him who has sustained and kept me through the dark hours. He has made me stronger and has built my faith.”¹

Christ did not die so we could have feel-good faith. He died so our faith could be resilient. Our culture is driven by feelings, but our faith cannot be. Emotions are not reality; they are momentary, temporary. If we allow our feelings to dominate our lives, they will enslave us.

Don’t let feel-good faith leave you blindsided by life’s unexpected challenges. Decide now that your feelings will not rule your faith. Commit to following the Lord no matter how you feel. That’s the first step in building resilient faith.

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Action Steps

When you first came to Christ, what plan did you sign up for?

Are you going to serve him only when you feel like it? Or will you deny yourself, take up your cross, and follow him?

How does your resilience look in your current circumstances?

Pray this prayer: Lord, I refuse to fall into the trap of feel-good faith. I will not abandon my commitment to you when life gets uncomfortable. I repent of all the times I have allowed my feelings to govern my faith. I choose to follow you no matter what. In Jesus’ name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 9

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

Is God's Wonderful Plan Easy?

"The one who stands firm to the end will be saved."

Matthew 24:13

Over the years, some pastors have preached that God is mad at Christians and all humanity. Other preachers have tried to counter this idea with much happier terms: "God loves you and has a wonderful plan for your life."

Of course, going to heaven is wonderful. Of course, having our sin forgiven is wonderful too. And, of course, living with the love of God overwhelming our souls is totally wonderful. No doubt, God's plan for your life is way more wonderful than the world's plan or the Enemy's plan. When we follow Christ, our lives will include more joy and more fulfillment than we ever dreamed possible. But God's plan does not exclude difficulties. To summarize the conversation by simply saying, "God loves you and has a wonderful plan for your life," has implications that in the long run can cause many to grow weary in their faith when bad times come.

If our chief motivation for coming to God is the implied promise that everything will be wonderful, then we will expect everything to be wonderful the moment we pray that prayer of salvation. "After all," we say, "I've given him my heart, and he has a wonderful plan for my life. I want the wonderful plan."

Even though many pastors and preachers will add the caveat

that giving your life to the Lord doesn't mean all your problems will go away, it's easy to overlook that fact and focus only on God's wonderful blessings.

The word wonderful in its most literal sense means "full of wonder." So part of his "wonderful plan" would include being

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awestruck by his presence, stunned by how he wants to use us, astonished by how he delivers us, and shocked by how he continually provides for us. In this sense, wonderful might be the appropriate word to use.

But another connotation of the word wonderful hints that everything will be pleasant and fun and that we will tiptoe through tulips for the rest of our lives. Yet this isn't what the lives of Jesus' followers are like. We still live in a world full of sin, struggle, and challenges. Even though we experience hardship, the good news is that because we have committed our lives to the Lord, we don't ever have to face these things alone. And that is wonderful!

But if we come to faith and follow Christ believing that everything will be easy, as soon as something that's not wonderful comes our way, we will quietly reason, That's not in my contract. That's not what I signed up for. I signed up for the wonderful plan. I signed up for daisies and sunshine and to have ooey-gooey feelings for the rest of my life, not dark clouds and storms. If we really and truly understand that Jesus asked us to take up our cross and follow him and if we accept his statement about enduring to the end (Matthew 16:24; 24:13), we cannot

miss the implication that we will endure difficult situations.

Challenges will come, but we have a powerful God who will walk through every storm with us.

Action Steps

In your walk with the Lord so far, have you been disillusioned in your faith by some hard times? Describe that here.

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How did you get through those hard times, and how did they affect your faith?

What does the word endure mean to you?

Ask the Lord for enduring faith today, no matter what the day brings.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 10–12

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 6

Having Nothing yet

Possessing Everything

As servants of God we commend ourselves in every way:... sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; poor, yet making many rich; having nothing, and yet possessing everything.

2 Corinthians 6:4, 10

Think about the earliest followers of Christ. Almost all Jesus' disciples were martyred in some way for their faith. They also suffered in life. Look at Paul and Silas, who were jailed and whipped again and again. Paul described the challenges they

faced in 2 Corinthians 6:3–10:

We put no stumbling block in anyone's path, so that our ministry will not be discredited. Rather, as servants of God we commend ourselves in every way: in great endurance; in troubles, hardships and distresses; in beatings, imprisonments and riots; in hard work, sleepless nights and hunger; in purity, understanding, patience and kindness; in the Holy Spirit and in sincere love; in truthful speech and in the power of God; with weapons of righteousness in the right hand and in the left; through glory and dishonor, bad report and good report; genuine, yet regarded as impostors; known, yet regarded as unknown; dying, and yet we live on; beaten, and yet not killed; sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; poor, yet making many rich; having nothing, and yet possessing everything.

Paul endured all these hardships for the sake of the gospel.

It would be hard to hear his testimony and say, "He signed up for the wonderful-life plan."

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Even in our day, it might be more appropriate to say that God loves us and has an adventurous plan for our lives or a dangerous plan for our lives or a fantastically unpredictable plan for our lives. But always wonderful? Not so much.

When challenges hit us (and hit us they will) or when bad things come our way, what will we do? If our expectations are completely and totally based on the idea that everything will be great once we ask for salvation, that same expectation will shape

our entire perspective of what it means to be a follower of Christ—and we will be sorely disappointed, as many people are.

Action Steps

Take a minute to list every hard thing that the disciples went through in our Scripture passage today.

What do you think they believed about Jesus that caused them to endure such things?

What do you think the phrase “having nothing, and yet possessing everything” means?

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What hard things have you gone through because of your faith in Christ?

What do you believe about him that helped you get through these tough times?

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 13–15

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 7

What Did You Commit To?

“Whoever does not take up their cross and follow me is not worthy of me. Whoever finds their life will lose it, and whoever loses their life for my sake will find it.”

Matthew 10:38–39

Many people who have prayed for salvation have since found out that not everything about following Christ is rosy. Because they believed this to be true at the beginning, they may feel that

the preacher or God lied to them. They might end up saying, “How can I follow a preacher or a God who lies to me? How can I trust anyone who promises me a wonderful life but doesn’t give me one?”

Here is the point: the way in which we understand the gospel dictates how we will live. Our understanding of what we are committing to and what we are receiving when we decide to follow Christ is of the highest importance.

Could it be that the current landslide of young people turning away from the church and their faith is a result of a faulty foundation? Perhaps our interpretation of the gospel is so shrouded by the feel-good culture that we can come up with all kinds of “reasonable” ways to back out of embracing our faith if things don’t feel good anymore.

If we are to be resilient, lifelong followers of Christ, something has to change. Many Christians and preachers have been overpromising and underdelivering. We promise people that everything is going to be wonderful after they give their heart to Christ and either fail to define what that means or expect people to define it on their own. As a result, we end up with spiritual carnage—pseudo-followers of Christ who are

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disillusioned with their faith. Then those who say, “Yeah, I tried that Christianity thing, and it didn’t work,” dissuade others from embracing the hope and freedom available in Christ. Yes, God loves you and has a wonderful plan for your life, but that doesn’t mean life will always be easy and wonderful.

Jesus called us to take up our cross and follow him. That implies that challenges will come. When those trials hit, we are not alone. God is with us. But the Christian life is not about avoiding pain; it is about following Christ no matter what. Our faith cannot be built on how we feel in any given situation. Our Christian life must be built on a foundation of unwavering faith.

Action Steps

Did you ever think your new life in Christ was supposed to be easy? If so, what was your reaction when it wasn't?

When you don't understand what is happening or why it is happening, which trusted truths help sustain you? How?

How has the gospel presentation that you first heard supported your walk with Jesus? Or how has it fostered disillusion?

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In prayer, ask the Lord to reveal any misunderstandings of Christianity that have bred unrealistic expectations and disillusion in your life. Write down your thoughts.

Pray this prayer: Lord, guard my heart from becoming disillusioned when challenges come my way. Forgive me for those times when I rebelled because I thought my life in Christ was supposed to be easy. I choose to follow you not so my life will be wonderful but because you are the only one who deserves my devotion. Because you died, I have life, and I give my life back to you. Whatever comes my way, good or bad, I trust you. I will not back down from standing in faith. In Jesus' name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 16–17

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Discuss the expectations you had of how your life would be when you first came to Christ. Also discuss how the Lord has helped you through difficult times so far. Talk about the most resilient Christ followers you know and what makes them so resilient. How do you think the gospel needs to be presented so that it can better prepare others to commit their whole life to Christ and follow him even through the hard times?

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Week 2

What Does It Mean to Follow?

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Day 1

Following with Resilience

He called the crowd to him along with his disciples and said: “Whoever wants to be my disciple must deny themselves and take up their cross and follow me. For whoever wants to save their life will lose it, but whoever loses their life for me and for the gospel will save it.”

Mark 8:34–35

Whether times are good or bad, sweet or bitter, what we believe colors our perspective and determines what our faith produces. Resilient faith will sustain us for a lifetime. It is a faith that does not change with the weather or weaken when times get hard.

Resilient faith holds up when hit by life's setbacks and curveballs. Resilient believers choose to follow the Savior no matter what.

However, it's not enough simply to talk about what resilient faith is. We need to look at what produces resilient faith in our lives. What are the first steps to building that kind of faith? Because it doesn't happen overnight. And when you find that you actually have resilient faith, you don't have it by accident. It all starts with the foundation.

We've talked a bit about how many in the Western church have faulty foundations. So what is the right foundation? What does Jesus really expect us to do? How does he want us to connect with him?

A simple sentence explains a deep idea: "Follow me." That is what Jesus said again and again. He chose the verb follow to describe how we start a life with him. These words are among the ones he repeated most often throughout the Gospels: Matthew,

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Mark, Luke, and John. He was not being redundant. If this is one of the phrases Jesus repeated most, there must be a reason.

Jesus told Peter and Andrew, "Come, follow me,...and I will send you out to fish for people" (Matthew 4:19). The brothers dropped their nets and followed him. When another man wanted to bury his father and connect with Jesus afterward, the Master said, "Follow me, and let the dead bury their own dead" (8:22). When Jesus told Matthew, the tax collector, "Follow me" (9:9), Matthew dropped everything and

followed Jesus, just as Peter and Andrew had done. On another occasion, Jesus told his disciples, “Whoever wants to be my disciple must deny themselves and take up their cross and follow me” (16:24).

Jesus called his disciples by saying, “Follow me,” because this following Jesus is the foundation of faith and the first step in building a resilient faith. How resilient is your faith?

Action Steps

Describe what you do when you follow a person, a band, a friend, or a celebrity. What does it mean to follow someone?

Take a moment to write out and memorize Mark 8:34–35.

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Now write out what this passage means in your own words.

How can you apply this to your life right now?

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 18:1–32

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 2

What Following Christ Is Not

“I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will never walk in darkness, but will have the light of life.”

John 8:12

I can’t tell you how frustrated I was after I finally committed my life to Jesus at sixteen. I had been raised in the church—several dead, dry, and boring churches where people found it hard to stay awake during the sermons. Even though I sensed God

speaking to me and wooing me at times, not once did my faith ever come alive during those first sixteen years.

At the age of twelve, I went forward to the altar because I felt the Lord wanted me to do so. No one else went forward that day—just me. I didn’t know what “going forward” meant and what I should do while I was up there. As the choir sang the closing hymn, the pastor leaned over to me, waiting for me to say something. But I had no idea what to say. Finally, I said, “I felt like the Lord wanted me to come up here. He’s been speaking to me for two weeks.”

The pastor replied, “Praise the Lord, brother! Why don’t you go talk to this lady right here.” As I sat down on the front pew, the lady began filling out a card. “What’s your name?” she asked. “What’s your address? Would you like to be baptized?”

The pastor introduced me as a new member of the church and people lined up to shake my hand. Some of them were crying. I honestly didn’t know what happened.

After church that day, my mom said, “So you became a Christian today.” I thought, Really? Is that what I did? No one told me anything about what being a Christian meant when I went to speak with the pastor. If someone had made clear what

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I was doing at the front of the church—if someone had explained that my decision was a fork in the road of my life—I might have been spared a lot of pain and confusion through my teenage years. But no one told me anything.

Coming to Christ is a big deal, and how we come to Christ

is just as important. In the Western world over the past fifty years, many gospel presentations have produced a passive mental assent to the faith rather than a real heart change. As we will soon see, some “gospel messages” that you may have heard don’t always give people a strong foundation for their faith but rather lead to a very passive faith. If we have to beg people to come to Christ, then we will have to beg them to read their Bibles, beg them to attend church, and beg them to live holy lives and keep loving God.

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Here are some ways people talk about getting connected to God:

“Would You Accept Christ?”

“Accepting Christ” is a theological phrase we often use in the church. It means that we accept the sacrifice that Jesus made on the cross for us. But it doesn’t really make sense to an unbeliever. The implication is that because we accept Christ, we’re doing him a favor. “Yes,” we say, “I’ll accept you, Lord. You need a place to stay? A heart to come live in? You can use mine.” But God doesn’t need anything from us.

Also, the word accept is an extremely passive concept. Just because we accept a gift doesn’t mean we do anything with it.

In reality, if we really saw Jesus in person, there would be nothing casual or passive about our response. We’d be on our face, worshipping him in all his glory, grateful for the incredible mercy and forgiveness he has given us.

“If You Died Right Now, Do You Know

Where You Would Go?”

This motivation to follow Christ is easily one of the most common. People try to motivate others to pray for salvation so that they don't go to hell forever. But if the fear of hell is what motivates them to come to Christ, will they be running from hell or running to Jesus? If they're running from hell, they'll be motivated by fear and judgment all their lives—trying to avoid all the bad things they shouldn't do. This could easily lead to a “do-good list” where they think, As long as I do all these things, I won't end up in hell. Thinking you can earn your way to heaven is a dangerous belief.

The truth is that Jesus' message was never “If you don't follow me, you'll go to hell.” He wanted to turn people's attention to his Father by saying, “I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me”

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(John 14:6). Jesus constantly stirred people's curiosity about the kingdom of God. He urged them to imagine what it would be like to connect with the king of the universe and to have him rule over their lives. If we were to present Jesus, even just a glimpse of him, in all his beauty and splendor, perhaps people's hearts would be so captured by the wonder of Christ that they would fall in love with who he is and follow him because he is what they've always been searching for.

“All You Have to Do Is...”

Of all the gospel presentations I have heard, this one riles me the most. I understand that when people use this phrase,

they're not intentionally soft selling the gospel, but for all practical purposes, they really are. What they mean is "You don't have to do rules. You don't have to do regulations. You don't have to whip yourself the way some religions require or beat yourself to please God." They are trying to say, "He has paid the price for you; therefore, you don't have to pay it." And while these statements are all true, they aren't the full picture of what it means to follow Christ.

Consider what Jesus said: "Take up [your] cross and follow me" (Matthew 16:24). He means that we should prepare to die to ourselves when we follow him. We are going in one direction, but he wants us to stop, turn around, and go completely in the other direction. He sees us going down paths that lead to destruction—paths of selfishness, me-centeredness, popularity, culture, and cliques—and says, "I want you to stop and head in the other direction." That is all you have to do: give complete control of your life to Jesus' lordship.

God wants us to trust him but not in a passive way. He wants us to trust his Word and his character, even when we don't understand what's going on. He wants us to trust his opinion over our own opinions and feelings. He wants us to actively stake our lives on him.

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Action Steps

How did you come to Christ? What did you expect? An easy life? Blessings? Happiness? A get-out-of-hell card? Describe that here.

You may have come to Christ in a passive way, not really understanding what following Jesus was all about. That's okay. But understand now that he wants us to pursue and love him with our whole hearts. Then everything else follows. Today, make a fresh commitment to follow him with all your heart and soul. Pray this prayer: Lord, forgive me if I have allowed my faith to become little more than a passive mental assent. I choose to grab hold of you and never let go. You gave me my life, and I give it back to you because you deserve it. May my heart be captured all over again by who you are. I give you complete control. I've counted the cost, and I choose to follow you. In Jesus' name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 18:33–50; 19

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 3

A Brand-New Path

Jesus replied, “Very truly I tell you, no one can see the kingdom of God unless they are born again.”

John 3:3

Jesus spelled out his requirements clearly: if we want to engage with him and be his disciples, we have to follow him. So what does this “following” mean? We say it all the time, but how do we actually follow him?

In John 3, Jesus said we must be born again. Being born again is what happens when you choose to follow Christ. You've already been born physically, but when you're born

again, you become a new person in him spiritually. Following him is not simply choosing to obey a bunch of rules; it is also submitting yourself to his authority by following his teachings and lifestyle. It means saying, “I subject my mind, will, and emotions to Christ. I turn over my heart to him. I give him my past, present, and future. I want to bring all of myself under submission. I choose to deny myself.” In other words, “I am going to follow Jesus—period.”

In coming to Christ, we come to a fork in the road. We can choose to follow ourselves, our flesh, our friends, the culture, whatever is popular and convenient, or whatever lifestyle we already live. Or, when we are confronted with the opportunity to have a brand-new life in Jesus, we can begin following him and live the life we were designed to live.

It all begins with a first step and a choice to walk in the right direction. When we pray to commit ourselves to Christ, that first prayer is the beginning of a new path. We choose to walk it because we choose to follow him. The miracle that God

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does in our lives is barely describable with words! The moment we decide to follow Christ is the moment we quit fighting God. We stop saying, “I’m going to live my own life. I’m going to be a self-made person. I’m going to do things my own way.” Instead, we choose his way. And it is just the beginning.

Action Steps

If you’ve gotten this far in the Pathway to Freedom series, you have probably already chosen to follow Jesus. But surrendering

everything to him is a process. In what areas of your life do you think you're still doing things your own way by following culture, your friends, or your flesh?

Take a moment to ask the Lord if there's an area of your life that he wants you to give him authority over. Write down your thoughts.

Now commit that area of your life to the Lord. Ask him how he wants you to begin thinking about that area and write down what he tells you here.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalms 20–21

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 4

Come Near to God

Come near to God and he will come near to you.

James 4:8

A relationship requires interaction. We don't want to be like a husband who, five years into his marriage, hears his wife say, "Honey, you never say you love me anymore." Ten years later, she says, "Honey, you never say you love me anymore." In twenty years, nothing has changed, and she says the same thing, "Honey, you never say you love me anymore." Finally, the husband has had it. He says, "I told you the day we married that I love you! If I change my mind, I'll let you know."

It seems that too many Christians are saying, "I prayed the

prayer; leave me alone! I want to live my own life. I've signed on the dotted line, and I'm going to heaven. Get off my case!"

That is not the kind of relationship Jesus desires. He wants us to engage with him every day—not because he needs anything from us but because we need his presence as much as we need air to breathe and water to drink. He is our life and sustenance. He wants us to have a daily, ongoing relationship where we consciously follow him moment by moment.

James 4:8 says, "Come near to God and he will come near to you." He never forces himself on us. He wants us to initiate the relationship—to pursue him, to seek him, to depend on him, to come near to him. Then he promises to come near to us.

That first step in the right direction is great, but it is only the first step. We must also take another step the next day and another one the day after that. Next week and next month, we have to take another step. The adventure Christ has for us

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unfolds day by day, step by step. We must always keep walking with Christ and living for him.

Action Steps

How have your interactions been with Jesus lately? Do you act like that husband in the opening story? Or have you really been connecting with the Lord every day?

If you were to describe how your life with Jesus has been so far, what would you say he has done to change you? List some ways he has transformed your thoughts, your heart, and your actions.

Connecting with Jesus is not just a one-way conversation.

How do you know when Jesus is speaking to you?

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Ask the Lord to give you a glimpse of the adventure he wants to have with you and write down what he speaks to you.

Take a moment to thank him for all the good things in your life that he has given you.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 22–23

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 5

Following the Invisible for Real

“You are looking for Jesus the Nazarene, who was crucified.

He has risen! He is not here.”

Mark 16:6

Some would ask, “How do you follow someone who’s dead?”

This is the wrong question. Jesus is not dead. He’s alive! He has risen! The living God calls you to follow him. When you choose to follow Jesus, he comes to live inside you. When he does, you will know just how alive he is.

A better question might be this: “How do you follow someone who is invisible?” You cannot see Jesus with your eyes. He is invisible. But he is still real. Love is invisible, but it’s real. The human conscience is invisible, but it’s real. Jesus is not visible right now, but one day, you will see him face-to-face and touch his scars, as Thomas did (John 20:27–28). You might

even give him a high five. And he will give you a bear hug!

Jesus really is the Son of God, and he has a real body. For now, we cannot see it, but we can still believe and follow him.

When Thomas touched Jesus' wounds and said, "My Lord and my God," Jesus replied, "Because you have seen me, you have believed; blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed" (John 20:28–29). That means us—we are the blessed!

We choose to follow Christ even though we can't see him.

This is not as strange as it sounds. Do you follow any bands that you have never seen in person? Sure. You listen to their music. You learn about them on the internet. You might even memorize the lyrics to their songs. When someone says, "I love this band," you perk up and ask, "What do you think of this song?" If the band is known for the song you name, you expect a person who loves the band to know it. If not, you suspect that

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he or she is a pretender and not a real follower. A follower would know the band's hit song.

The same is true of those who follow Christ. They get to know his Word (his "lyrics"). Ardent followers read Jesus' words and become familiar enough with them to share them with others. When someone is hurting or asks a question, the serious follower can say, "Here is what Jesus says about that." They know Jesus' teachings because that's what followers do—they know the One they follow.

What if we were such serious followers of Christ that we knew his opinions on just about any subject that might come

up in the course of a day? What if we knew Jesus' "lyrics" better than we know all other lyrics? You may be thinking, That's a lot of lyrics! But chances are you know more songs than you can name off the top of your head because you follow the artists. You want to know their songs, and you want to talk to them face-to-face.

Is that how you follow Christ? Do you have the same passion for him and his Word?

Too often, we Christians are like the pretender who claims to follow a band but does not even know the band's most popular song. We say, "I love Jesus." We may know John 3:16 by heart because we learned it when we were five years old. But we have not learned much Scripture since then. We claim to follow the Lord, but we take his "lyrics" for granted. Be a follower who truly knows what's in the heart of the God you are following.

Action Steps

According to today's devotion, what proves that you are a serious follower of someone?

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In what ways have you tried to get to know Jesus and his thoughts?

If you wanted to be even more serious about following Jesus, what could you start doing?

Meet up with your accountability friend. If you don't have one yet, pray about this and find a person you can trust who wants to know Jesus the way you do. This person is someone you can pray with, and you can share with them the ways that

you want to grow in God. You make a pact to hold one another accountable for ways you want to change. You can encourage each other in how you want to grow and talk about ways you could both be more serious followers of Jesus.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 24–25

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 6

The Ultimate Kind of Following

“My sheep listen to my voice; I know them, and they follow me.”

John 10:27

Really and truly, followers follow. They get to know the One they follow. They learn about his life. They become familiar with his teaching. They emulate his ways. They seek his heart and learn how he wants them to live.

Many people have a favorite college or professional sports team. They cheer for them at games. They know the players’ stats and how many times the team has been to the playoffs. They follow the team. They follow every game. This is what followers do—they know about the ones they follow even if they’ve never seen them face-to-face.

Jesus is looking for a new generation of followers who don’t just scream loudly at Christian events or speak perfect Christianese. It is fine to say, “Praise the Lord. Glory to God. Hallelujah. Amen.” But Jesus is looking for something deeper. He is looking for people who actually know the words of the

Son of God they say they follow.

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For too long, faith in the church has grown weaker because we follow our favorite bands, sports teams, styles, or celebrities more passionately than we follow the Savior of the world. We search the internet to know the latest celebrity gossip. We memorize songs and rattle off our teams' stats. We follow schedules and show up for events. Yet when it comes to Jesus, sometimes we barely make time to hear his voice.

What if we know more about Jesus and his Word than we do about anyone or anything else? That is what true Christ followers do. They follow him closely and take him seriously. They don't need to be pumped or hyped up. They simply follow. They say, "I follow because I am a disciple. I am a learner; I am hungry to know the One I follow."

Here is how Jesus described it: "My sheep listen to my voice; I know them, and they follow me" (John 10:27). In other words, those who follow Jesus become familiar with his voice.

They get to know his words, and they do what he says.

Jesus made it clear that following is not a menu option but a requirement for those who call him Savior. Jesus said, "If you love me, keep my commands" (14:15). As far as Jesus is concerned, we cannot love him and serve him without following his ways and his teachings.

The ultimate goal is to follow Christ so closely that people mistake us for him. That's why the believers were first called Christians in Antioch (Acts 11:26). They didn't call themselves

Christians; the secular people did. Those believers following “the Way” looked and acted so much like Christ that outsiders named them Christians, “little Christs.”

Someone would ask, “Is that Jesus?”

“No, that’s Peter,” someone answered.

“Wait—is that Jesus?”

“No, that’s Mark,” someone replied.

“Is that Jesus over there?”

“No, that’s Mary, but she looks and acts just like Jesus.”

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Whether male or female, these believers were so closely aligned with Jesus that they were mistaken for him. No wonder the name Christian stuck.

Today people call themselves Christians even when they don’t live anything like Christ. What would happen if there were no difference between who we claim to be and how we live? What if people again mistook us for Christ? Imagine if our lives caused them to say, “I’ve never met Christ personally, but I’ll bet that is how he acts.”

That is the true goal of a follower.

Action Steps

Who would you honestly say you’re following the most passionately? Who’s getting the most of your mind and heart?

A sports team? A band? A certain celebrity? Jesus?

Sometimes our life with God can seem dry and boring.

This often means that we’re just following the rules. We may not be taking the time to hear his voice each day. Listening to

what he's speaking specifically to us, whether it's from his Word or to our hearts, is what keeps our love for him and faith alive. On a scale of one to ten (one being dry and boring and ten being vibrant and hearing God's voice), how would you describe your relationship with Jesus? Explain.

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What can you do to make your relationship with Jesus more alive and vibrant?

Take some time to write out, meditate on, and memorize

John 10:27.

Now spend some more time listening to what he is speaking to your heart today. Write out what you hear.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 26–27

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 7

More than Just Words

If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.

Romans 10:9 esv

Jesus never asked anybody to become a Christian. For years now, I have not either. I don't ask people to "become Christians" because I believe the goal is for people to become followers of Christ who act like him. When people see others acting like Jesus, they will want to know him. They will get their first glimpse of him in us.

You already know that how we lead people to Christ is important because the way they understand the gospel affects how they walk out their faith. A lot of people use a method called the “Romans Road” to explain the gospel and how we become Christians by taking people through a series of verses in Romans: “‘The word is near you, in your mouth and in your heart’ (that is, the word of faith that we proclaim); because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved. For with the heart one believes and is justified, and with the mouth one confesses and is saved” (Romans 10:8–10 ESV). Many people use this passage to explain how we become Christians because it talks about declaring, or confessing, Jesus as Lord so that we can be saved. We need to understand this in the larger context of Jesus’ repeated command: “Follow me.” Confessing, or saying out loud, “Jesus is Lord” is more than just saying the words. Jesus himself said, “Not everyone who says to me [or calls me], ‘Lord, Lord,’ will enter the kingdom of heaven” (Matthew 7:21).

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Christianity is not magic. We don’t become followers of Christ by merely reciting certain words. Imagine if your faith were tested in a courtroom. The bailiff would put you under oath, and the prosecutor would interrogate you. If they examined your lifestyle, would there be enough evidence that Jesus is your Lord to actually convict you? Would your actions, attitudes, and lifestyle reveal that he is in charge of your life?

Of course, only God can judge the heart, but let this illustration paint a picture in your mind. I pray that as the prosecutor pressures you, asking, “Are you a follower of Christ? Is he in charge of your life? Is he your Lord?” you would cry out, “Yes! You got me—I confess! He is my Lord. He is in charge of my life. I follow him with everything that I am. I obey his Word, I listen to his teachings, and I do everything I can to submit to him. You’re right. He is my Lord!”

This is what Romans 10 is really telling us to do. Confessing that Jesus is Lord is more than what we say with our words. It’s proclaiming that he really is the one who’s in charge of our life.

Romans 10:8–10 also tells us that we must believe that God

raised Christ from the dead. This conviction comes from the Holy Spirit. He prompts us to believe. He encourages us to

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believe. He opens our eyes so we see the truth. Because the Holy Spirit woos us, we say, “I believe!”

By faith (because we didn’t see it ourselves), we believe that Jesus died on the cross, that he rose again, and that he is alive today. We embrace the truth that he is the Savior of the world.

With our mouth, we confess unto salvation. In other words, because we confessed, because we said out loud, because we admitted, “Yes, he is my Savior! Yes, he is my boss! Yes, I am a follower of Christ,” we are saved. When you believe that, he makes you righteous. He gives you a new heart and takes away the iniquity and shame and breathes in new life.

When you admit aloud that Jesus is your boss, he is in

charge of your life, and you are his follower, you are saved and set free. Then, you live it. You don't merely chant certain words; your life must reflect the valuable meaning of those words.

Action Steps

What does the phrase Jesus is Lord mean to you?

How does knowing that Jesus is Lord change your day-to-day actions?

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What if you really were persecuted for your faith? What evidence would there be in your life that would prove you are a Jesus follower?

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 28–30

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

What did you learn this week about the difference between saying you're a Christian and being a follower of Christ?

Discuss some of the passive ways people come to Christ and why those produce a faulty foundation for faith. Share with the group your own experience of making Jesus the Lord of your life and how he has made a difference in the way you live. Pray for each other's areas of struggle.

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Week 3

Living Fully Alive

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Day 1

God's Dysfunctional Children

“Truly I tell you, unless you change and become like little children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven.

Therefore, whoever takes the lowly position of this child is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven.”

Matthew 18:3–4

It seems as if these days everyone is talking about how dysfunctional their families are. Maybe every family has some degree of dysfunction. Even in the family of God, many have a broken relationship with their Father. This dysfunction started way back in the beginning, the moment Adam and Eve, the first children in the family God created, attempted to live without him.

Having the right understanding of our intended relationship to God is fundamental if we are to be resilient no matter what comes our way. The foundation of our faith is this: Christianity is not something we strive for; it is a gift. We can never earn God's love and forgiveness, but he forgives us anyway! God sent his Son to die for us, and by grace we are saved, not by our own works (Ephesians 2:8–9).

If we are to live whole and healthy lives as children of God, we need to understand how much we need him, should trust him, and should rely on him for our life and very existence.

Jesus said in Matthew 18:3–4, “Truly I tell you, unless you change and become like little children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven. Therefore, whoever takes the lowly position of this child is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven.”

What is the difference between childlike and childish faith?

Think about the attitude babies have toward their parents. They are completely, utterly, and totally dependent on their parents

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for food, for clothing, for everything. Jesus had something to say about that attitude. He said those who are humble like children are the greatest in the kingdom (Matthew 18:4).

Children know they need their parents for food and housing.

They recognize the authority of their parents. They have a natural desire to please their parents. They admire and respect their parents as heroes. And that is how we should approach our belief in Christ: with childlike faith.

But something happens when children become toddlers:

they think they can fend for themselves. They try to act independently, even though there is no possible way they can survive without their parents' help and provision. Interestingly enough, we believers can have some of the same childish habits.

After we have been in Christ for a while, we think we can do things on our own. We drift from the fully dependent, childlike attitude we had when we first came to Christ.

One of a child's foundational needs is love. An unloved child will never reach their full potential. This craving for love is common among all humans on the planet. The most popular tales and dramas for thousands of years have been love stories. The most popular country, rap, and pop songs are all about love. We cannot live without love any more than a fish can live outside water.

Isn't it interesting that God made us so that our greatest need (love) is the very thing he is made of? Scripture says, "God is love" (1 John 4:8). I wonder if that explains why we are so intrigued with love stories. A human cannot live—really live—without love, just like we cannot live without God.

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Action Steps

On a scale of one to ten (one being the least dependent and ten being the most), how dependent on the Lord would you say you've been lately? Explain.

Describe the childlike faith you had when you first started trusting Jesus.

In what areas of your life have you relied on yourself too much, and in what areas do you need to depend on God more?

Take a moment to receive the Lord's unconditional love and grace for you. Pray and ask him to renew your "first love," the kind of love you had when you first came to him. Ask him to give you a humble and childlike faith.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 31

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 2

Symptoms of Life without Love

I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor demons, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will

be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord.

Romans 8:38–39

It does not matter how many times our hearts have been broken; we always seek new love or more love. It's something that seems to elude us, a craving that is deep inside our souls.

We want to have love, be loved, and love others. Love is the foundation for our lives, and until we experience true love, we won't have the capacity to really love anyone else.

We have a whole world full of humans who, for the most part, don't know that the God of the universe loves them.

Without the knowledge of God's love, it's no wonder that we have a world full of wars, hatred, divorce, fighting, and hunger for power. These are all symptoms of an unfulfilled craving for our Creator's love, and those symptoms can have serious results.

Let's look at some specific outcomes:

Failure to Thrive Syndrome

Failure to thrive syndrome can be caused by many factors, but common reasons are neglect and emotional deprivation.² This syndrome happens most often in homes where there are more babies than the workers can care for. The workers don't have time to pick up, hold, and love the babies. After months of not being touched regularly, these children stop eating, stop growing, and stop smiling. They weigh less than normal and

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have trouble performing simple physical and mental tasks.

Imagine that—a baby suffering long-term from a lack of love.

Many Christians are like this; they are failing to thrive. They do not know how much God loves them. They are trying to earn his love and provision. They are not growing; they are not smiling; they are not full of joy; they are not eating spiritually. They become listless and eventually dry up on the inside—just like an unloved baby.

Insecurity

Often children who don't know they are loved grow up to be very insecure. They may fish for compliments, asking questions such as, "How did I do? How do I look? How does my hair look? How are my clothes?" On the one hand, in their lack of confidence, insecure children may constantly be looking for approval. Others, however, overcompensate with a false confidence. They may express their insecurity through arrogance, acting overconfident in themselves because they don't want others to see their insecurity. Their cockiness is a symptom of not knowing they are fully known and fully loved.

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Attention-Seeking Behaviors

Some children develop attention-seeking behaviors when they feel unloved. They often have negative attitudes, issues with drugs or rebellion, outbursts of anger, and bitterness. Many get piercings or tattoos or go from one boyfriend or girlfriend to another just to disobey their parents and get their attention, even if it's negative attention. Of course, adults have their own attention-seeking behaviors. The point is that when someone lacks the security of knowing they are loved no matter what,

they may unconsciously adopt behaviors they know will cause them to be noticed.

People-Pleasing

People who do not know they are loved may try hard to earn the approval of others. Some do it by getting good grades.

Others strive to excel in sports. But no matter how successful they are, some never feel they are good enough. They become legalistic about rules and regulations: If I just do this or do that, my parents will approve of me more. My friends will love me more. They are trying to earn, earn, earn, but they feel they never measure up.

The biggest problem for people in this world is not knowing they are loved by the creator of the universe. And we as believers have the very same problem! But we have the truth of God's Word, which can transform our thinking and chase away every lie. When we can experience and receive the love of God every single day, it will banish every insecure thought that tries to put fear in us and hold us back. Nothing in the universe can separate us from the power of God's love.

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Action Steps

Which symptoms listed in today's message do you struggle with, and why?

Take a few minutes to write out and memorize Romans 8:35–39.

What is God saying to you personally through this passage?

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 32–33

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 3

Learning to Thrive in

God's Kingdom

We know and rely on the love God has for us. God is love.

Whoever lives in love lives in God, and God in them.

1 John 4:16

If the biggest problem in the world is not knowing how much we are loved by God, how do we fix that problem? Simply put, we must live in God's love like a fish lives in water. Since fish are always immersed in water, they have no idea what it feels like to live outside it. The idea of a fish living out of water is unimaginable. Its gills are designed to take oxygen from the water. If we take a fish out of the water, it flops around, gasping for air.

When my children were growing up, I would take them fishing. Sometimes we would catch fish, let them flop while we took them off the hook, and then throw them back in the water. Those flopping fish remind me of people living outside God's love. Just like fish are designed to breathe in water, we are designed to breathe in God's life. God's dysfunctional children are God's love-starved children. When we are starved for love, we may do all kinds of unwise things, and all kinds of sin overtake our lives. When we do not live in God's love, we flop around gasping for air and choking the whole time. The oxygen

we long for is in the ocean of God's love.

Too often as new followers of Christ, we jump into the ocean of God's love excited that we have been born again. We have brand-new hearts. We have been forgiven. We swim

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around and have a great time because we realize that we are “fish” after all. We breathe in God's love.

But then we look to the people on the shore, laughing and smiling and partying and acting like everything is great, and suddenly, being a Christian seems like a lot of work. We start getting jealous, so we jump back onto the land. We try to smoke and party and drink and sleep around or do whatever everyone else is doing and realize after a while that we are gasping for air. We wonder why, but the reason is simple: we have jumped out of the living water we were meant to stay submerged in. People on the shore look like they are having fun, but they are all gasping too.

Then, when we are just about dead, we jump back in the water and repent: Jesus, forgive me! Fill me with your life. Fill me up with your love again. Then we say, “It is so beautiful; he has forgiven me.” But after a while, we forget about the misery out on the bank, and we long for it again. So we jump back out of the water, thinking we'll have fun for a while—until we find ourselves gasping for air again and jumping back into the water. Our whole life is spent jumping in the water and out of the water over and over. It really doesn't make sense! A beached whale is unnatural, and so is a follower of Christ trying to live

according to the world's rules. That is why it is time to jump into the deep and never come up.

This is what God requires. The most natural way for us to live is to dive into the deep things of God, realize that is where we were born to live, inhale his presence and his love, and learn to thrive in his kingdom with him at the center of all that we do. We were created to operate on a whole different system from the world because we are not of the world. We just happen to live in it for now.

Many times, people give their hearts to Christ but still want to live on land. But we have to learn to live in the kingdom of God, submerged in his love. Living in his kingdom is different from just living on planet Earth. We do not obey God's Word and live the way it says simply to fulfill an obligation. God doesn't want us to complain and argue anytime he asks us to do something. We don't live in the ocean of God's love so we can merely exist. Living by God's ways allows us to thrive! And not only that but there are exploits to be accomplished and great adventures to experience. Following Christ is not just about surviving.

Once we understand that, as humans, we are designed to live in the ocean of God's love and his ways, we understand that there are also constraints in those waters to protect us. They are not hard, however. Jesus said, "My yoke is easy and my burden is light" (Matthew 11:30). His yoke is not heavy, but it is still a yoke. Our "burden" is to stay submerged in God's love, which really isn't a burden at all. When we come to faith, there is a

new king to whom we belong. There are new ways to live and relate to others (including parents, friends, and authorities). We now live in a completely new world, and we must learn a new lifestyle—the lifestyle of the King. This means staying in his love and doing what pleases him. This is what it means to be a follower of Christ.

Learning to thrive submerged in God's love is the key to being resilient.

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Action Steps

How would you describe how you've been living lately? Are you submerged and thriving in God's love or flopping around on land, gasping for breath? Explain.

Take a minute to say Romans 8:35–39 out loud from memory and meditate on God's amazing love for you.

If you haven't been thriving lately, what can you do to jump back into the deep with the Lord?

Pray this prayer and then spend some time in God's amazing presence:

Lord, I am so grateful to be your child, totally dependent on you like a fish depends on water to survive. Thank you for loving me the way you do! Forgive me for all the ways I've tried to live apart from you or tried to be like the world.

Show me the depths of your love. Help me see not only that I am loved but also how much I am loved. I choose to immerse myself in the ocean of your love and to stay there. Fill me so full of your presence that love spills over onto everyone I meet

so that they know you love them too. In Jesus' name. Amen.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalms 34; 35:1–5

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 4

Are You Fully Alive?

In him was life, and that life was the light of all mankind.

John 1:4

Sometimes it can be hard to tell the difference between a real follower of Christ and a fake one because on the outside they may look very similar. It's a lot like plants in a person's home. Some look real and alive, but they're just potted plastic, and some really are alive. The question is this: How can you tell when something or someone is fully alive?

In 2013, a thirteen-year-old girl in California went to have her tonsils removed. Tragically, she came out of this simple operation brain-dead. Her mother refused to take her off life support but instead went to court to transfer her daughter to another hospital. The argument in the press was whether she was alive or not. Does being brain-dead mean she's really dead?

Just as this case made people think about what it means to be physically alive, every follower of Christ ought to think carefully about what it means to be spiritually alive. We should ask ourselves, Am I alive, or am I just pretending that I'm alive in Christ? Am I doing the things that a truly alive person would

do? Is my heart exploding with the life of God, or am I like a plastic replica of something alive?

Jesus brought this question to life in Matthew's gospel:

A man came up to Jesus and asked, "Teacher, what good thing must I do to get eternal life?"

"Why do you ask me about what is good?" Jesus replied. "There is only One who is good. If you want to enter life, keep the commandments."

"Which ones?" he inquired.

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Jesus replied, "'You shall not murder, you shall not commit adultery, you shall not steal, you shall not give false testimony, honor your father and mother,' and 'love your neighbor as yourself.'"

"All these I have kept," the young man said. "What do I still lack?"

Jesus answered, "If you want to be perfect, go, sell your possessions and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven. Then come, follow me."

When the young man heard this, he went away sad, because he had great wealth. (19:16–22)

Be careful when you ask Jesus a question because many times, he responds with the answer to a different question and makes you think about something you were not expecting. This man was asking the questions that many people argue about today in Christianity and in other religions: How do I get to heaven? How do I have eternal life?

Jesus reframed the question by saying, “If you want to enter life.” He essentially was asking, “Why are you only thinking about what happens after you die? Why are you waiting until your death to find eternal life? Don’t you want to enter a life worth living now?” He forced the man to reckon with whether he was really alive or just existing.

Just because you exist on the planet doesn’t mean you’re fully alive as God intended. Jesus’ answer caused this man to look inside himself and wonder, I know I’m here, but am I alive? Have I really entered life?

Many people talk about how to get to heaven. They make the whole Christian movement about what happens when you die. Jesus is concerned about our becoming alive right now, which is the best proof of eternal life.

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Action Steps

Is your heart exploding with the life of God, or are you like a plastic replica of something alive?

What do you think it means to be fully alive?

What are some things in your life that keep you partially dead inside?

Ask the Lord what he wants you to do about those things and write it down.

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John 1:4 says that Jesus’ life is “the light of all mankind.” As you spend time with him and ask him to fill you with his life in your areas of darkness, you will begin to see life more clearly,

just like when you turn on a light in a dark room. Jesus' life inside you will become a light to all those around you. Spend some time with Jesus, asking him to infuse his life into those areas and show you how he thinks about them.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 35:6–28; 36

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 5

Making Dead People Alive

As in Adam all die, so in Christ all will be made alive.

1 Corinthians 15:22

Too often we talk about all the bad things we do and about how we can be forgiven. All that is important. However, Jesus didn't come to make bad people good; he came to make dead people alive.

Since Genesis 2, all humanity has been born spiritually dead. God said to Adam and Eve, "In the day that you eat of [this tree] you shall surely die" (Genesis 2:17 NKJV). You might think, Well, Adam and Eve didn't die right after they disobeyed God. But if you were to look into the reality of the situation, you would see that they died spiritually the moment they were separated from God. They existed physically after that, but they weren't fully alive as God intended.

When you are separated from God, you have the illusion of life without the experience of being fully alive. Just because you're breathing doesn't mean you're alive. It's amazing to think

that you could have a pulse and still be dead, but that is what happened after the fall. Adam and Eve died the very moment they ate of the wrong tree and chose their own way over God's. The evidence of their death did not appear right away. They continued existing. They were like the plastic plant that looks alive but is actually dead.

Almost immediately after they sinned, Adam and Eve covered themselves with fig leaves. They knew something was wrong. Each of them thought, I need to cover my shame. I need to do something to distract me from my deadness. They experienced separation from God right away.

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When we live without God, we often try to pretend there is nothing wrong. We jazz up our plastic lives to make them look as good as we possibly can. After all, if we're going to live the imitation life, let's imitate as well as we possibly can, right? So we listen to the world's advice and hope it will fulfill us. The world tells us to eat this for comfort. Watch this and be entertained. Smoke this and get high. Drink this to take the edge off. Snort this, sleep with him, sleep with her. Over and over, the world promises that these things will give us life. But always, they give us death.

It's like we're eating poisoned candy. We keep trying new versions of the candy, but each has its own poison; each has a different way of distracting us from the fact that we are dead. This death entered the world when Adam and Eve first sinned. It is still a bit of a mystery—being spiritually dead when our

bodies are very much alive. We may think we're alive, but we are on the same quest Adam and Eve were, trying every which way to experience life at its fullest. We might try adventure or thrill seeking or the pursuit of money or a variety of romantic relationships, but none of those things can make us fully alive. The psalmist said that we're all born into iniquity and sin.

We were "sinful at birth" (Psalm 51:5). This word iniquity speaks of a twisted craving for evil and sin. Iniquity worms its way inside us and causes us to crave harmful things. Iniquity makes us think we are alive and having a great time, all while it's killing us.

All the things the flesh craves are ploys that distract us from the fact that death is lurking inside us. The distractions promise life, but they bring death. When we stop listening to all these distractions and face up to the fact that without God, we have nothing, we can begin to really live.

Jesus came as our answer, conquering death, hell, and the grave (Hosea 13:14). He didn't just come to conquer physical death; he came to conquer the death we are carrying around in

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us, this thing called iniquity that lurks within. He came to give us life and life abundantly, as John 10:10 tells us.

Jesus came to make dead people alive.

Action Steps

What's the difference between the idea of God making bad people good versus making dead people alive?

What is some evidence of death that you see in people

around you or even in your own life?

How can you connect deeper with the Lord and see more life in your own heart?

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Remember, we are bearers of the good news. It's not good news to tell everybody they are dead. The good news is that Jesus wants to give them life and life to the full.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 37

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 6

Dead Men Walking

“Your kingdom come,
your will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.”

Matthew 6:10

Most people are walking around dead, like prisoners on death row. When a person is sentenced to death, a day comes when he or she heads for the death chamber. Prior to the 1960s, as the prisoner walked down the hall, the guards would shout, “Dead man walking!” Unfortunately, that’s what most of humanity is—dead people walking. They are trying to find an imitation of life to distract them from the reality that they are dead. God is trying to keep us from living as zombies on the earth. We are most fully alive when we are in communion with him. We are most alive when we submit to, depend on, and

connect to God. This is why God doesn't want us to sin. Jesus taught us to pray, "Your kingdom come, your will be done," because when our lives are free from sin and entanglement, we're most fully alive.

When we commit our lives to Christ, he breathes life into our dead hearts. Then, in a world full of walking dead people, we become fully alive. As followers of Christ, we ought to be so alive that our friends, neighbors, and classmates notice the difference. When we walk into a room it should be as if life just burst forth. Why? Because we were dead, but now we're alive! We were lost, but now we are found.

Paul explained the problem of death in Romans 8:13: "If you live according to the flesh, you will die." He was saying that

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when you let your flesh take over and you participate in sin, the death you've been trying to outrun overtakes you, and you begin to just exist.

It seems this is the problem with too many who call themselves followers of Christ. They have had genuine encounters with Christ in which their hearts came fully alive. But then they start tasting a bit of sin here and a bit there, and after a while, some of their light goes out.

When we sin, we become like light bulbs without electricity. We look the same, but there's no light coming through. We keep propping ourselves up saying, "I'm still a bulb; I'm still a bulb!" But there's no light shining. This is why so many Christians who say they are alive still feel dead. They

go to church. They go through the motions. At one time, they were fully alive, but now they sense deadness or a lack of an authentic and honest relationship with Jesus.

Jesus said to pray every day, “Your kingdom come, your will be done.” In other words, we are saying, I don’t want iniquity to reign in me. I don’t want to live like the world. I want your kingdom and your lordship to reign in me instead. I want to stay fully submitted to, dependent on, and connected to you. Maturity, then, is staying fully alive for longer and longer periods of time without iniquity dominating us.

Action Steps

Complete this sentence with four things mentioned in today’s devotion: “We are most fully alive when...”

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What does God’s kingdom coming to earth mean to you?

Describe some ways his kingdom has come into your life.

Write down some areas that your King needs to rule in your life and pray over those areas.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 38–39

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 7

Bruised for Your Iniquity

He was wounded for our transgressions,

He was bruised for our iniquities.

Isaiah 53:5 nkjv

This mystery of iniquity still lurks within us. Jesus came to deal with our twisted craving for sin. In fact, Isaiah 53 says he was wounded for our transgressions and bruised for our iniquities. When we think about how Jesus was brutally beaten, whipped, and tortured, we realize that he endured all of it and shed his physical blood so that we might be forgiven of our transgressions, our sins, the things we do outwardly.

But Jesus didn't come just to forgive us of the things we do. He came to deal with the root cause. The root cause is what leads us to want to do bad things in the first place. The root cause is what provokes us to think evil thoughts. The root cause is iniquity.

Isaiah's prophecy says that Jesus was bruised for our iniquity. When you get a bruise, the area often swells up. It may start out red and then turn purple because, essentially, a bruise is internal bleeding. Jesus was beaten externally and bled externally to forgive us of our external sins. But he was bruised internally and bled internally to deal with our internal human nature, the inner ways that need to be redeemed.

When the Romans whipped Jesus, they used what was called a scourge. This was a type of whip that had lead balls and shards of metal and bone embedded in it. So with every blow from the whip, pieces of metal and bone ripped away his skin, and lead balls bruised his torso, arms, and legs again and again. He suffered this to deal with our iniquity and to free us from

the death lurking inside us. He did it so we could be fully

alive—not just forgiven for what we did but also freed from the root that causes us to crave the sin in the first place.

Jesus wasn't just beaten, bludgeoned, and tortured. Many have endured that for all kinds of reasons. Jesus hung on the cross for six hours, and in the middle of all he suffered as part of his death sentence, Isaiah said, "The Lord has laid on him the iniquity of us all" (Isaiah 53:6). God laid on Jesus the iniquity of every human. This includes the evil thoughts that we are so ashamed of and would never tell anybody about. It includes the sins of Hitler and Stalin, who killed millions of people. It includes the sins of drug lords today who sell drugs to children, kidnap people, and sell others into prostitution. It includes every sin you have committed and every sin you will commit. God laid on Jesus all our iniquity. In that moment, he experienced something that you and I have experienced but Jesus had never before experienced—separation from God. Even though we know God already knows about our sin, we are sometimes too ashamed to talk to him about it. This puts a wall between us and God.

Jesus experienced that wall for the very first time when God laid iniquity on him, and he cried out, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Matthew 27:46; Psalm 22:1). He experienced death at that moment, separation from God on our behalf.

As we remember what Jesus went through for us and daily surrender our hearts, our lives, and our natural cravings for iniquity that we've been redeemed from, then and only then

will we live a life that is fully alive in Christ.

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Action Steps

Imagine what it must have been like for Jesus when he was whipped, beaten, and bruised. This was the highest price he could pay for our freedom. Take a moment to thank him for giving his life for you so that you could be free and live close to him.

Now think about areas of your life where you have not allowed him to reign. Ask the Holy Spirit to show you where he wants to work in your life and write it down.

Take these areas to the Lord and surrender them to him.

Allow him to speak to you about what he wants to do in you and how he wants to reign in those areas. Write what he reveals here.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 40–41

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Connect Group Discussion

Discuss what makes Christians dysfunctional and what makes us thrive in God's kingdom. Describe some people you know who are fully alive and what makes them that way. Why is our message as believers how Jesus makes dead people alive and not how he makes bad people good? How has he made you more alive this week? Get in groups of three and pray for your biggest needs.

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Week 4

Only-If versus Even-If Faith

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Day 1

Where's Your Confidence?

Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego replied to him, "King Nebuchadnezzar, we do not need to defend ourselves before you in this matter. If we are thrown into the blazing furnace, the God we serve is able to deliver us from it, and he will deliver us from Your Majesty's hand. But even if he does not, we want you to know, Your Majesty, that we will not serve your gods or worship the image of gold you have set up."

Daniel 3:16-18

There are two kinds of faith: only-if faith and even-if faith. We'll be talking about both this week. The faith that Jesus calls us to is much deeper than the easy belief system that says, "I'll believe in Jesus," but doesn't truly follow him or says, "I believe in Jesus as long as things go my way."

The faith Jesus invites us to live is more than believing in mystical formulas that satisfy our every whim and smooth over every rough patch. He invites us on a journey that includes rough patches and difficult choices, but he himself is right there with us in the middle of it all.

This kind of faith is recorded in Daniel 3, where we find the famous story of three young men: Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. Although they lived in pagan Babylon, a nation that worshiped multiple gods, these Hebrew guys loved the living

God and refused to compromise their faith in him. The king of Babylon, Nebuchadnezzar, had built a golden statue and ordered everyone to bow down and pay homage to it when certain music played. Of course, Shadrach, Meshach, and

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Abednego refused to honor an idol representing any god or man, no matter the consequences.

And the consequences were great. The guys were brought before Nebuchadnezzar, who offered them one last chance to bow down when the music played. When they refused, he ordered his men to heat a furnace seven times hotter than usual and have Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego thrown into it.

At this point you might think Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego would have been intimidated. But despite the king's threat, they stood firm. Their response should cause even the faintest of heart to rise up with courage: "If we are thrown into the blazing furnace, the God we serve is able to deliver us from it, and he will deliver us from Your Majesty's hand. But even if he does not, we want you to know, Your Majesty, that we will not serve your gods or worship the image of gold you have set up" (vv. 17–18).

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego had confidence in God and were absolutely determined. They knew that God was able and willing to deliver them. So often when Christians pray, they waver between opposing beliefs. They may think the following:

- Well, I know that God can heal me, but I'm not sure he wants to.

- God is able to put my marriage back together, but I'm not sure he wants to.

- I know God can reach my kids, but I'm not sure he wants to.

The Hebrew men had no such doubts. They essentially said, "God is able, and he will deliver us. But if he does not, we will not quit serving him."

They spoke with their shoulders back and their chins held high, fully confident that God was on their side. This is the kind of faith we ought to have, the kind that says, "God can and he will deliver me, no matter what the outcome is." When we go to

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God in prayer for a financial need, an illness, a relational issue, or our country and world, we ought to pray and ask without doubting God's goodness. "Since we know he hears us when we make our requests, we also know that he will give us what we ask for" (1 John 5:15 NLT).

Action Steps

How do you find yourself praying most of the time? Do you pray, Lord, I know you want to do this because this is your character and your nature, or are you just begging the Lord for things, not having any clue what his will is in the situation?

We can have the confidence and the faith to know how to pray by knowing what the Word says about God's character and nature. He loves us, so we can trust that he has our best interest in mind always. He wants to restore relationships, so we pray for restoration. He wants to save and draw people close to him, so we can pray in faith for that to happen.

Are you praying for something right now? Find a verse or two on God's nature and character concerning the thing you're praying for and write down what you learn.

Now meditate on God's character and then pray, building your confidence in who God is rather than how good or bad you think your prayers are.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalms 42–43

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 2

Believing Only If

I was young and now I am old,
yet I have never seen the righteous forsaken.

Psalm 37:25

Sometimes we think our faith is pretty strong. We do believe in God. We know who he is. We know what his Word says. We know that he wants to heal, save, and deliver. The challenge comes when things in our life start going south.

If we're not careful, Satan can whisper something sinister in the back of our minds—a thought we'd probably never say out loud, even though we live it out. This whisper sounds something like this: "God can and will answer my prayer. And as long as he does, I will continue following him."

Again, we would likely never say this out loud, but our actions reflect this mentality. We pray for something, fully

expecting it to happen. But if the prayer is not answered in the way we wanted it to be or when we wanted it to be, we become victims of a feel-good faith. Our resilience caves in. The life is sucked out of us.

What we thought was strength and confidence was actually a conditional faith. Whether consciously or not, we tell God, I will follow you, but only if certain conditions are met.

- Only if my prayers are answered.
- Only if I feel good.
- Only if I don't face too many challenges.
- Only if everything is wonderful.

It's as if we're telling God, I'll keep acting like a Christian should as long as you keep me feeling good.

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Jesus encountered many people with this attitude. One said, "I will follow you, Lord; but first let me go back and say goodbye to my family" (Luke 9:61). "Another disciple said to him, 'Lord, first let me go and bury my father'" (Matthew 8:21). These sound like reasonable requests. Why wouldn't Jesus let a person say goodbye to loved ones or bury his father?

Jesus was not being coldhearted. He was trying to communicate that if you are wrestling with whether to follow Jesus or if you're finding "good reasons" for having second thoughts, you are not ready to come. If you think there is any good reason not to give everything and follow Jesus with all your heart, then you don't understand who has invited you to follow.

Action Steps

Is there a condition you've placed on the Lord? Perhaps you think, I'll keep trusting you, Lord, but only if you do this or that for me. If so, what is the condition?

We all go through times in our lives when our faith is tested. When that happens, we have to lean in more to the Lord instead of pulling away in hurt or disillusion. We have to remind ourselves of the faithfulness of God by choosing to remember all he has already done for us and that he has a bigger picture in mind that we don't yet see.

If it's not good, then God's not done yet.

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Write out your own prayer to the Lord. Pour out your heart honestly before him. Then reaffirm your trust and faith in him, no matter what. Write down some of the things he's done for you.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 44

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 3

Santa Claus Faith

In him all things were created: things in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or powers or rulers or authorities; all things have been created through him and for him.

Colossians 1:16

Too often, we turn our faith in God's provision into a weird Santa Claus story. We become like the child who sits on Santa's lap and begs for certain toys but is disappointed when, on

Christmas morning, they don't get everything they want.

Whether we do it subtly or overtly, it's common for us to strike bargains with God. Perhaps we pray, Lord, if you get me out of this ticket, I will become a missionary in Africa. Or, Lord, if you heal Aunt Suzie, I will go into the ministry and follow you with all my heart. Then when we get out of the ticket or Aunt Suzie is healed, we go on with life and forget our promise.

These types of prayers put conditions on our following Christ, but when he doesn't answer when and how we want him to, our passion wanes. We become less fervent in our pursuit of him.

Little by little, we drift, and resilience fades.

Following Jesus cannot be conditional. If following him is based on our conditions, what will we do when we face a real crisis? What happens when our prayer isn't answered right away?

But what if we started with a different premise? What if the premise of our faith were that God is the rightful owner of the universe and the rightful owner of our lives? With that kind of foundation in place, we could pray with confidence, knowing that he is a good God and only wants the best for us—that he is our healer, our deliverer, our waymaker. We would be satisfied

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to know that when and how he answers our prayers is up to him and not us. Our faith would be focused not on what we want but on his faithfulness and character and on his kingdom coming in the situation. With this premise, we can stand up with faith whatever the challenge.

Action Steps

Take a few minutes to memorize and write out Colossians 1:16.

What do you think the phrase “God is the rightful owner of the universe and the rightful owner of my life” means?

If God owns everything, including our lives, what right do we have to tell him what to do? Explain.

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How does this knowledge change your attitude toward God, any conditions you might place on him, and your prayer life?

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 45–47

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 4

Following Even If

Now we see only a reflection as in a mirror; then we shall see face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known.

1 Corinthians 13:12

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego from Daniel 3 made a remarkable statement during their trial. They said, “[God] will deliver us from Your Majesty’s hand. But even if he does not, we want you to know, Your Majesty, that we will not serve your gods or worship the image of gold you have set up” (vv. 17–18).

What happened here is amazing. They walked through the fire with “even-if faith”—even if everything came apart at the seams, even if they ended up in the fiery furnace, and even if

they didn't understand, they would not bow down.

Some might say that the young men doubted God because in one breath they said, "God will deliver us," and in the next they said, "Even if he does not." I disagree. Their words did not reveal doubt. Their faith allowed for the mystery of God. They knew no human could understand everything about God, yet they were confident that God could deliver them. No matter what he chose to do, their faith in him would not waver. They must have thought, If for some reason we end up dying in the furnace and going to heaven, it won't be such a bad deal.

This even-if faith is courageous. It has been the legacy of Christ followers from the beginning. Even-if faith allows us to admit that we don't know (and don't have to know) everything. We sure would like to have a formula for everything that happens in life. We would like every circumstance to come with an explanation, but those are conditions. Even-if faith takes all

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the conditions off. It says, "I'm going to follow God no matter what. Even if that person I'm praying for doesn't get healed instantly or at all, I will follow God. Even if something tragic happens that messes with my theology, I will follow God."

First Corinthians 13:12 says, "Now we see only a reflection as in a mirror; then we shall see face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known." In other words, we understand many things, but they're not completely clear. We know a lot about the Lord, but we don't know

everything. We might like to demystify the God whom we follow, but we cannot. He is the God of the universe, the creator of all that is good; he made the heavens and earth and rescued us by sending his Son. We might like to know everything that is in his heart and mind, but we simply can't. He is God, after all, and we are not.

Only-if faith is the opposite of even-if faith. Even-if faith has absolutely no conditions. Even-if faith says, "Even if there are circumstances I don't like, I am going to follow. Even if someone I deeply admire lets me down, I'm going to follow. Even if a pastor or leader does something horrible, I'm going to follow God. Even if the person who led me to the Lord turns away from Christ, I'll keep following Jesus. Even if the loved one I'm praying for doesn't get healed, God has already been so good to me, so I'm still going to follow. Even if I never receive another answer to prayer for the rest of my life, I will follow the God who has already answered so many of my prayers. I'm still on the receiving end of this relationship, and I'm still going to follow him."

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Action Steps

What made Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego be able to essentially say, "Even if he doesn't deliver us, we will not bow to your idol"? What must they have believed about God?

Define even-if faith in your own words.

Do you have a situation you've been praying for in which it seems like God is not responding? Spend a few minutes with

the Lord and ask him to give you even-if faith.

Pray this: Lord, I trust you no matter what, whether I understand or not. I know I won't know everything about you, but I know you are good! You only have good plans for me, and you are with me through this. Help my unbelief. Help me to do the right thing, to follow you no matter what, and to trust you completely. In Jesus' name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 48–49

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 5

Who Was the Fourth Man?

“Look! I see four men walking around in the fire, unbound and unharmed, and the fourth looks like a son of the gods.”

Daniel 3:25

Take a moment to read Daniel 3:19–25 and, if you're really adventurous, read this whole chapter in Daniel—it's a pretty remarkable story!

Nebuchadnezzar was furious with Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego, and his attitude toward them changed. He ordered the furnace heated seven times hotter than usual and commanded some of the strongest soldiers in his army to tie up Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego and throw them into the blazing furnace. So these men, wearing their robes, trousers, turbans and other clothes, were bound and thrown into the blazing furnace. The king's command was

so urgent and the furnace so hot that the flames of the fire killed the soldiers who took up Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego, and these three men, firmly tied, fell into the blazing furnace.

Then King Nebuchadnezzar leaped to his feet in amazement and asked his advisers, “Weren’t there three men that we tied up and threw into the fire?”

They replied, “Certainly, Your Majesty.”

He said, “Look! I see four men walking around in the fire, unbound and unharmed, and the fourth looks like a son of the gods.”

When Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego decided to defy Nebuchadnezzar’s edict, he was beyond furious. He ordered that

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the fire be turned up seven times hotter. Then he had the young men bound and thrown into the fire. The flames were so hot that they immediately consumed the soldiers who threw the Hebrew men in. But what happened next completely blew the king’s mind. When he looked into the furnace, he saw a sight he would never forget. All three men were unbound, unharmed, unburned, and walking around...with a fourth man!

Who was the fourth man in the fire? King Nebuchadnezzar said he looked like “a son of the gods.” Can you guess who it was? Many theologians believe he was the Son of God—the only true and living God. The fourth man was Jesus himself, who saw the faith of three courageous young men, maybe just teenagers like yourself (although the Bible does not specify

their age in Daniel 3), who refused to bow to any other gods. They didn't blindly follow culture and what everyone else was doing. They refused to let the fear of others rule them. They chose God's way over everything else, even their very own lives. When we make those kinds of decisions in our lives, the Son of God himself shows up in amazing ways.

Jesus has invited you to follow him with all your heart, soul, mind, and strength. He asks you to trust him even when you don't understand. He urges you to have so much confidence in him that even when life seems to spin out of control—even if you end up in a furnace seven times hotter than anything ever experienced—you will not bow down. You will not change your behavior. You will not stop following the only one who is worthy of all you have and all you are. By his grace, you can choose even-if faith, and he'll be right there with you in the fire.

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Action Steps

Have you ever felt you were being thrown into the fire? Maybe the pressure or circumstances of your life felt so hot and extreme that you didn't know what to do. If that has happened to you, describe it here.

If you've never experienced the fire, don't worry; you will.

It just happens when we live on planet Earth. The good news is that when we as followers of Christ get thrown into fiery circumstances, we can know that "the fourth man" is right there in the fire with us. His name is Jesus, and he will never leave us

nor forsake us.

Spend a few minutes worshiping the only true, living God,
who stands with you when you trust him, no matter what.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 50–51

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 6

The Fire of Persecution

Be strong in the Lord and in his mighty power. Put on the full armor of God, so that you can take your stand against the devil's schemes. For our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the powers of this dark world and against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly realms.

Ephesians 6:10–12

Sometimes when you choose the road less traveled, the narrow path that leads to life, like Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego did, you may face persecution for your decisions. For instance, if some members of your family are not followers of Christ, they won't understand the choices you're making, and they may not like them. There have been many believers who have been misunderstood, ridiculed, or ostracized by their families or friends for choosing to follow Jesus.

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When you start following Christ and quit following the crowd, the crowd doesn't like it either. They'll make fun of you,

gossip about you, or lie about you. Why? Because our Enemy, the devil, is angry for losing one more person whom he had in his slimy grip. He uses people to do his will and tries to pull you back to where you were before.

When you get thrown in the fire and suffer any kind of persecution for standing for Jesus, don't get mad at the person. Realize your battle is not against the people who are angry with you. Your battle is with your spiritual enemy. Ephesians 6:12 says, "Our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the powers of this dark world and against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly realms."

When your struggle gets fierce, be strong. Jesus has already won the battle. Use the weapons God detailed for you in his Word: the belt of truth, the breastplate of righteousness, the gospel of peace, the shield of faith, the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit.

Put on the full armor of God, so that when the day of evil comes, you may be able to stand your ground, and after you have done everything, to stand. Stand firm then, with the belt of truth buckled around your waist, with the breastplate of righteousness in place, and with your feet fitted with the readiness that comes from the gospel of peace. In addition to all this, take up the shield of faith, with which you can extinguish all the flaming arrows of the evil one. Take the helmet of salvation and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God. (vv. 13–17)

Here's a real-life story of how believers stayed resilient even in persecution.

When authorities raided a young adult Bible study in Shandong, China, believers were taken into custody, and many of their families paid to have them released. The authorities

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banned the church's activities, but the pastor, Zhou Liang, reported that the restrictions had the opposite effect: believers continued to gather, and new believers joined their ranks.

Zhou was quoted as saying, "Do they think the church is banned just because they say they ban it?...Who can fight the will of God? They did say they banned the church, but they couldn't do it. Now, we have more people than before."⁴

These believers would not be stopped. They chose to worship the creator of the universe even if the massive power of the Chinese government was against them.

Action Steps

Have you experienced persecution in your walk with the Lord? Explain.

Sometimes when people we love are against us because of our faith in Christ, we don't recognize it as persecution, and we feel hurt and betrayed. If that's the case for you, take a moment to pray and pour out your heart to the Lord. Tell him your feelings and ask him to heal your heart. You don't want to walk around with bitterness and hurt day after day. Ask God to help you forgive the people who have hurt you.

Now recognize that those people are not your enemies.

Your battle is not with them. The devil is the one who is trying to destroy you—he is your archenemy. Spend some time meditating on Ephesians 6:10–17.

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Write out your weapons here and describe what each of them are.

Now use each of them against the rulers and authorities of this world in prayer. Be strong in the Lord!

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 52–54

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 7

When You Don't Have Answers

Though the fig tree does not bud and there are no grapes on the vines, though the olive crop fails and the fields produce no food, though there are no sheep in the pen and no cattle in the stalls, yet I will rejoice in the Lord, I will be joyful in God my Savior. The Sovereign Lord is my strength.

Habakkuk 3:17–19

I remember visiting with Oral Roberts, a popular televangelist, at his home in California before he went to be with Jesus. As we discussed this topic of faith, I was initially shocked when he held up his right hand and said, “Ron, I’ve prayed for millions of people with this hand. In those prayer lines, in those tents, literally millions of people I laid hands on—many of them were healed, but there were many more who weren’t healed. We

would see dramatic healings—people whose legs didn't work at all, and they stood up and walked. But there were many more who didn't seem to have any manifestation of healing at all.”

Oral continued, “Ron, I don't know why. I still had the same feeling of faith, the tingling in my hand, the same confidence as I prayed over these people. I don't understand why. But it didn't mean I would stop praying for the sick because I know that God wants to heal the sick. So I just kept laying my hands on others.”

As I listened to him, I thought, This is the kind of confidence we must have in our God.

Like Oral Roberts, we know what God's will is, so we pray accordingly, not letting the results affect us. We can't let how God answers prayers determine whether we keep going because, if we did, we would be putting conditions on our God.

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Even-if faith is the faith Jesus intended for us from the very beginning. It is the only kind of faith that bears up under our struggles. When we have even-if faith, we are strong because we choose to put confidence in the character of God even when we don't understand our circumstances. We can then say, “I know he is good even when things don't feel good.”

Struggles will come. Everyone knows somebody who has died prematurely. Too many people have been in horrible accidents that left them maimed for life. When things like this happen, we ask the almost inevitable question: Why?

When you find yourself in the middle of a tragedy, you may

not be able to answer the why question. That's when you must choose to focus on what you know instead of what you do not or cannot know. You know that Jesus loves you. You know that he came and gave his life for you. You know that he rose again. You know that he will come back for you, and you know you will be with him forever and ever.

Instead of focusing on the questions we cannot answer or on explaining the unexplainable, we can focus on the goodness of God. All the rest we leave in his hands. We may understand the whys of our situation in the future, but we need to decide now that we are okay with not having all the answers.

Action Steps

Only-if faith is conditional. It says, "God can and will answer my prayer. And as long as he does, I will continue following him." Even-if faith says, "Even if I don't understand or there are circumstances I don't like, I'm going to follow God." God wants us to place our confidence in his character even when we don't understand our circumstances. He wants us to follow him no matter what.

Are you willing to follow him whether or not your situation makes sense? Commit now to standing in even-if faith because

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it is the only faith that will bear up in the face of life's challenges. Make your commitment to the Lord in prayer:
Lord, I repent for any ways I have put conditions on my faith in you. I put my confidence in your character, and I will trust you whether or not my circumstances make sense to me. I

will not follow you only when things are wonderful or if you respond to my prayers the way I want. But like Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, I choose to walk in even-if faith. Whether I feel good or not, I will not stop following you. I will remain steadfast because you've been so good to me. You deserve my complete devotion. In Jesus' name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 55–56

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Share some experiences you've had that have challenged your faith and how you got through them. Discuss why having even-if faith is so critical to remaining true to God your whole life. Pray for people in your group who are going through challenging times right now and encourage one another.

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Week 5

A New Kind of Relationship

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Day 1

Convenient Relationships

Walk with the wise and become wise,
for a companion of fools suffers harm.

Proverbs 13:20

We usually don't think very much or very deeply about the kinds of relationships we have with people. If we hope to be

resilient in times of trouble and grow in our walk with God, we need to know that the relationship God wants to have with us is fundamentally different from any we could possibly conceive without him.

With God, relationships are about covenant. A covenant is a binding agreement between two people, like a marriage. But because the word covenant is so rarely used and is often misunderstood in our culture, we must learn more until we understand the kind of relationship he desires and how different it is from all other relationships. Knowing these things will set the foundation in our lives for long-term strength in Christ.

We have all kinds of relationships in our lives, but they boil down to a handful of types. Let's look at what they are and how they work.

Many modern relationships are born out of convenience.

They often involve people in proximity to us—someone who sits next to us in math class or works in the next cubicle or shares the pew with us at church. We go to lunch with certain people over and over and sit in meetings with them day after day. Convenient relationships aren't ones we seek out; they are more accidental. Although some great friendships can start this way, we are not always proactive in finding the right kinds of friends. We end up with "convenient friends" who are living

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foolishly and cannot really help us to grow in our faith or in godly character.

But worse than convenient friendships are convenient

romances. These are romantic relationships where each person only thinks about how the relationship can make their life easier. Perhaps they move in together and continue the relationship only because it costs less to have a roommate than to live alone. Little thought is put into these relationships. People tend to think only about how easy it is to function in them.

Scripture promises in Proverbs 13:20 that if we walk with fools, they will affect us, pull us down, and harm us. Whether when dealing with a convenient friend or a convenient romance, we need to realize that relationships with foolish people are costly to our life with God.

Sometimes our relationship with God becomes a convenient relationship. We might get into trouble and pray an emergency prayer. Or we might get pulled over and pray that God will get us out of a ticket. Maybe we have trouble with a friend or some other situation, and God is the convenient place to turn for help.

God never intended for our relationship with him to be one of convenience, one we turn to only when we get in trouble. He wants something so much deeper than that. He wants to be the “friend who sticks closer than a brother” (Proverbs 18:24).

Action Steps

Take a few minutes to memorize and write out Proverbs 13:20.

Do you recognize any convenient friendships that may be harmful in your life?

How have these relationships affected your devotion to the Lord?

Take some time to pray over your closest friends. Ask the Lord to give you wisdom this week to continue to build friendships in which you can really help each other to grow strong spiritually.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 57–58

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 2

Consumer Relationships

“Love your enemies, do good to those who hate you, bless those who curse you, pray for those who mistreat you....Then your reward will be great, and you will be children of the Most High, because he is kind to the ungrateful and wicked. Be merciful, just as your Father is merciful.”

Luke 6:27–28, 35–36

Consumer relationships are transactional in nature. If you give me what I want, I'll give you something in return. When I drive to the gas station to buy some fuel and a Diet Coke, I have no deep, abiding commitment to the person at the checkout. I simply go wherever I can get the best deal or wherever is closest. When I order a latte at Starbucks, it's not because I feel committed to a particular Starbucks store. I might go to a different location next time. Because the relationship is transactional, I feel under no obligation to keep going back

either. If I find another deal somewhere else, then I'll go there.

When I'm in a consumer relationship, I shop around for the offer that benefits me most.

Our lives are full of consumer relationships. The challenge comes when we allow consumer relationships to bleed into other more important relationships. For instance, if a romantic or marital relationship is based on consumerism (as so many are), each person stays in the relationship only as long as they feel they are getting something out of it. When the perceived benefit ends, they go somewhere else and feel justified doing it! They might tell their partner, "You are not giving me what I need." That is a consumer mindset.

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Too many people have what we could call "consumer sex."

They say, "I'll have sex with you as long as I get my emotional needs met. But as soon as you stop meeting them, I'll shop around and find someone who makes me feel better about myself."

Sometimes our relationship with God can become like a consumer relationship. This happens when we only come to him to get whatever we need. When we stop getting what we want, we quit coming to him. We might not say it, but our attitude says, "When God stops meeting my emotional and physical needs, I'll go somewhere else. I'll serve God only if he gives me this or that in my life." This is another example of only-if faith. God absolutely wants to meet our needs, but he is looking for much more than a consumer relationship.

As followers of Christ, Jesus is our example of love and relationship. He sacrificed himself for us before we ever gave anything back to him. He gave when we didn't deserve it. Similarly, there will be times when we are called to love people whom we think don't deserve it. It may be a friend who's going through a rough patch and is hard to be around. It may be a family member who doesn't understand our commitment to Christ. They can see his love through our unconditional love for them. It might even be an "enemy" who hates us, curses us, and mistreats us. Jesus told us to love people like that. This is the polar opposite of a consumer relationship.

By loving people who give nothing to us and may actually take from us, we are being like our Father, who loved us first before we ever loved him. God promises to reward us because we are acting like his children, being like he who is "kind to the ungrateful and wicked."

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Action Steps

Write out today's verses and take a few minutes to meditate on them.

Does anyone who needs unconditional love rather than a consumer relationship come to your mind? What can you do this week to love those who may not deserve it?

Think about your relationship with the Lord. Are there ways you have put conditions on serving him, praying, If you do this for me, I'll do this for you?

Take a moment to pray and remind yourself that Jesus is

the king of your life and that he deserves your full devotion, no matter what. Thank him for loving you when you didn't deserve it.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalms 59–60

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 3

Contractual Relationships

“All you need to say is simply ‘Yes’ or ‘No’; anything beyond this comes from the evil one.”

Matthew 5:37

How important is your word? In days gone by, people could shake hands on a deal. Their word was as good as a contract. But for too many people, honesty and integrity are not important values. As humans, we are sinful and cannot always be trusted to keep our word. Contracts are necessary for almost every business relationship to ensure honesty. Even some marriages begin with prenuptial agreements.

Most contracts are written to explain what happens when something goes wrong in a deal, like one party failing to keep their word. Contracts essentially say, “I’ll do this for you as long as you do that for me.” Contractual relationships are a lot like consumer relationships, but they have a written promise or contract to make sure the other person follows through, which makes the agreement more binding.

In Matthew 5:33–37, Jesus explained how he wants his followers to interact when it comes to agreements:

You have heard that it was said to the people long ago, “Do not break your oath, but fulfill to the Lord the vows you have made.” But I tell you, do not swear an oath at all: either by heaven, for it is God’s throne; or by the earth, for it is his footstool; or by Jerusalem, for it is the city of the Great King. And do not swear by your head, for you cannot make even one hair white or black. All you need to say is simply “Yes” or “No”; anything beyond this comes from the evil one.

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So instead of saying, “I swear I will do this or that,” Jesus told us that our word should be enough. We don’t have to swear it, and we don’t have to make an oath; our yes means yes, and our no means no.

Jesus always keeps his word, and we’re his followers, so we should always keep our word. If you say you’ll do something, then do it. If you know you can’t keep a promise, then don’t tell people you will. Be a person of your word, and then people will respect you and count on you because of your character.

Although we don’t sign an official contract with God, the same principle can apply with keeping our word to him in prayer. Does our yes to him really mean yes, or do we make promises that we’ll never keep? God always keeps his promises.

His commitment to us goes much deeper than any contractual relationship, which we’ll discover in the next few days.

Action Steps

Describe a person in your life who always keeps their word and whom you can count on. You can trust and rely on this person.

We need more of these people in the world!

How are you doing at keeping your word?

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Take a moment to write out and memorize Matthew 5:37.

Think about a situation where you can practice letting your yes be yes and your no be no. Write down what you will do in that situation and then share it with your accountability partner.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 61–63

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 4

Covenant Relationships

As a father shows compassion to his children,
so the Lord shows compassion to those who fear him.

Psalm 103:13 esv

Covenant relationships are completely different from convenient, consumer, or contractual relationships. A covenant binds the strength of the law with a very intimate and personal love relationship. It's more personal than a legally contractual relationship and more binding than the simple feelings of love for another person. The heart of a covenant relationship says, "I'll do this for you, even if you don't do something for me."

We see covenant relationships between a good parent and

their children, for example. Every parent knows what it's like to have kids who sometimes misbehave. But even when they misbehave, the commitment remains: "I'm still your parent, no matter what you do or say."

If teenagers rebel, a good parent still has inexplicable love for them—even when in-your-face rebellion comes from the ones they coddled and nurtured and heard take their first breath. The parent's heart says, It doesn't matter what you do to me or what you give back to me. I'm still yours.

From their earliest years, children really can't give anything back to their parents. They can't pay rent. They can't mow the lawn. They can't do the dishes. They can't do anything beneficial for their parents except smile and giggle. But that doesn't diminish the parents' commitment or love because they have a covenant relationship: "This is my little one whom I brought into the world."

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I think God gave us the parent-child relationship to show us what his unconditional, covenantal love is in human form. It's hard to grasp a God who loves us through all our sin and defiance. But he does, just like a good parent continues to love a child through all their tantrums, rebellion, and difficulties. Incidentally, covenant relationship is the only kind God ever mentioned having with a human. There was the covenant with Abraham (Genesis 12:1–3; 15:5) and the covenants with Isaac and Jacob (Genesis 26:2–5; 28:20–22). There was also the Mosaic covenant (Exodus 19:5–6) and the Davidic covenant (2

Samuel 7:12–16). Even though God knew what was in the

hearts of humans and that we could never keep all our promises, he chose to enter a covenant relationship with us anyway. He loves us so much that he wanted to be sure we knew that he would never break his promises to us. He is always faithful.

Action Steps

Describe what a covenant relationship is.

Where have you seen covenant relationships lived out?

Name the people involved and what aspect of their relationship is covenantal.

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Spend some time with the Lord and ask him to deepen your love for the people around you and to help you understand his covenantal love for you.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 64–65

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 5

A Covenant Marriage

in the Middle East

The Lord said to him, “Bring me a heifer, a goat and a ram, each three years old, along with a dove and a young pigeon.”

Abram brought all these to him, cut them in two and arranged the halves opposite each other; the birds, however, he did not cut in half.

Genesis 15:9–10

Let's look at God's covenant with Abraham. The story is found in Genesis 15. You can read the whole chapter if you'd like.

The Lord said to him, "Bring me a heifer, a goat and a ram, each three years old, along with a dove and a young pigeon."

Abram brought all these to him, cut them in two and arranged the halves opposite each other; the birds, however, he did not cut in half....

When the sun had set and darkness had fallen, a smoking firepot with a blazing torch appeared and passed between the pieces. On that day the Lord made a covenant with Abram and said, "To your descendants I give this land, from the Wadi of Egypt to the great river, the Euphrates—the land of the Kenites, Kenizzites, Kadmonites, Hittites, Perizzites, Rephaites, Amorites, Canaanites, Girgashites and Jebusites." (Genesis 15:9–10, 17–21)

This ritual sounds very strange to us today, but to Abraham, it would have sounded normal. Covenant relationships were the cultural norm. So when God laid out the plan for this covenant ritual, Abraham would have been familiar with it.

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Even today in Middle Eastern countries, covenant relationships in marriage are common. During the marriage ceremony, certain Bedouin tribes do something that is deeply meaningful to them but could seem barbaric from the outside. At some point in the ceremony, an animal, such as a sheep or a

goat, is cut completely in half and laid wide open. The blood from the animal runs to either side. On one side, the bride's father stands with his toes in the blood, and on the other side, the groom's father stands with his toes in the blood.

As the father of the groom stands in the blood, he promises that if his son does not keep his word to be faithful to the bride, the bride's family may do to him what was done to the animal. Then the father of the bride promises that if his daughter does not remain faithful to this covenant and her commitment, the groom's family may do to him what was done to the animal.⁵

This was how the marriage covenant was formed. It was far more binding than the words "till death do us part" from our modern ceremonies. In some ceremonies today, there is no such commitment at all. Instead of vowing "till death do us part," the bride and groom commit to being together as long as their love shall last or as long as they both are happy.

Unfortunately, this is how too many Christians perceive their commitment to Christ: "As long as my love shall last or as long as I'm feeling something good." That's a far cry from a covenant.

Action Steps

What have you learned so far about how Jesus makes the difference in our relationships and commitments?

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Take a moment to pray and ask the Lord if there's a relationship in your life where you've adopted a more worldly attitude and only consider what you get out of the bargain.

What can you do to work on having a more Christlike

commitment toward others?

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 66–67

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 6

The Making of Abraham's Covenant

When the sun had set and darkness had fallen, a smoking firepot with a blazing torch appeared and passed between the pieces. On that day the Lord made a covenant with Abram.

Genesis 15:17–18

In the story from Genesis we discussed yesterday, God made a covenant with Abraham. But a surprising thing took place that we will discover today.

After Abraham cut the animal, he waited for the covenant to be finalized. Typically, when a lesser servant made a covenant with the owner of the land, the lesser servant was asked to walk through the remains of the hewn animal, saying, “If I don’t keep my word to you, may I be like this animal.” This is similar to the Bedouins we talked about yesterday. In that way, the owner of the land heard the person’s pledge to pay their debt or do whatever the commitment required.

So as Abraham cut the animal open and sat waiting until dark, he listened for the next instruction. He assumed that he was going to have to pass through the animal carcasses because he was the lesser party between God and himself. Of course, the entire ritual was based on his question to God: “Sovereign

Lord, how can I know that I will gain possession of [the land you promised]?” (v. 8).

God responded, “Bring me a heifer, a goat and a ram, each three years old, along with a dove and a young pigeon” (v. 9).

Abraham cut all except the birds. He had to pledge something to God. Yet as he waited and waited, he got a surprise: God showed up with a flame of fire, and God passed through the pieces of the slain animals. This must have shocked

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Abraham. Essentially God was saying, “If I don’t keep my part of this covenant to bless you, then may I die and be cut into pieces and be slain.” God was promising to be torn into pieces if he did not do his part to bless Abraham.

Abraham must also have been shocked by the fact that he himself was not required to pass through the animals and their blood. As we noted yesterday, a Bedouin bride and groom would pass through to signify an equal commitment. But God was not willing to ask Abraham to make a covenant that he knew Abraham could not keep. It is as though God was willing to pass through for the both of them. What he was essentially saying was this: “Not only will I be torn to pieces if I don’t keep my word, but I will also be torn to pieces and killed if you don’t keep your side of the covenant.”

Action Steps

Have you ever not kept your side of the bargain with God?

Explain.

How has God been committed to you throughout your life

so far? List all the major times he has kept his side of the bargain when you haven't.

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Take some time to praise him for all the times he has been so faithful to you.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 68

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 7

The New Covenant

Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us, for it is written: "Cursed is everyone who is hung on a pole." He redeemed us in order that the blessing given to Abraham might come to the Gentiles through Christ Jesus, so that by faith we might receive the promise of the Spirit.

Galatians 3:13–14

When God passed through the pieces of the slain animals, he was sending all of us a message. "Not only will I be torn to pieces if I don't keep my word, but I will also be torn to pieces and killed if you don't keep your side of the covenant."

Hundreds of years later, Jesus, God in the flesh, was nailed to the cross. He was beaten, bloodied, and crucified because Abraham and all of us failed to keep our part.

On the cross, Jesus fulfilled the curse of the covenant that should have come to all of us. That is what Galatians 3:13–14 means when it says that Jesus became a curse for us so that we

might receive the blessing promised to Abraham and so that
“by faith we might receive the promise of the Spirit.”

Since we as humans could never keep a covenant relationship with God without his help, he made sure the covenant would still be kept. Jesus became the sacrifice required. His own body was torn apart, ripped open, beaten, and bruised all because of God’s love for us. Jesus redeemed us (brought us back in right relationship with the Father) and gave us the promise of his presence (his Spirit) so we could be his forever.

When we really understand what it means to be in covenant with God, our lives change forever. God does not engage with us through human models of relationships:

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convenient, consumer, or contractual relationships. He embraces us through a type of relationship that he designed: a covenant relationship where he himself takes all the risk. God knows that we humans will fail. And when we do, we can find our way back to God because “there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1). This keeps us from trying to be good enough for God. We don’t have to earn his love; we already have it. He’s proven that to us repeatedly and abundantly. But we also cannot take advantage of it—not after what Jesus has gone through for us.

At the Last Supper, Jesus introduced to his disciples the new covenant, which he would complete through his death on the cross: “When he had given thanks, he broke [the bread] and

said, ‘This is my body, which is for you; do this in remembrance of me.’ In the same way, after supper he took the cup, saying, ‘This cup is the new covenant in my blood; do this, whenever you drink it, in remembrance of me’” (1 Corinthians 11:24–25).

Our relationship with God has always been about a covenant relationship unlike any other relationship that a human being can have with anyone else in life. My hope is that each time we take communion from now on, we take that bread in our mouths and remember that Jesus’ body really was broken. And each time we take the cup, I pray we would realize that his blood was literally shed for us.

He paid the price because we couldn’t keep our side of the covenant.

Each time we take communion, may we feel the binding nature of the love of God drawing us closer—and in that reality, may we find the strength to be resilient.

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Action Steps

What were the aha moments you had from today’s devotion?

Describe how you see the covenant relationship that God has with you.

How does understanding this covenant keep you from trying to earn your salvation?

Take some time now to really thank God for what he has done to get you back and make you his.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 69

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Describe the different types of relationships: convenient, consumer, contractual, covenant. Why do the first three types of relationships fail within friendships, families, and marriages? Spend some time talking about what you learned about God's covenant with us by studying God's covenant with Abraham. How did Jesus fulfill the requirements of this covenant? Take some time together to praise and worship God for all he has done for you on the cross and is doing in your lives now.

Week 6

When You Don't Understand

Day 1

What Are You Really Seeking?

Jesus replied, "Let me make this very clear, you came looking for me because I fed you by a miracle, not because you believe in me. Why would you strive for food that is perishable and not be passionate to seek the food of eternal life, which never spoils? I, the Son of Man, am ready to give you what matters most, for God the Father has destined me for this purpose."

John 6:26–27 tpt

A lot of people look for God, pray to God, or even become Christians only because of what they can get. When they face

hard times, they don't get what they really want, or something happens in their lives that they don't understand, they can become disillusioned and maybe even lose their faith. How do we keep our faith strong even when everything doesn't make sense? We're going to take this week to look at the story of Jesus in John 6 where he multiplied five barley loaves and two tiny fish to feed a massive number of people. The crowd who followed Jesus had all kinds of reactions to the miracle, and we can learn a lot about what to do when we don't understand. Whether we're confused by a Scripture passage or something happening in our life, what do we do?

Take a few minutes to read John 6, preferably in The Passion Translation. We're going to dive in and see how we can gain such a rock-solid faith that it doesn't matter if we don't understand sometimes. We are followers of Jesus for life. Jesus drew many crowds during his three-and-a-half years of earthly ministry. Often he shared parables that seemed entertaining but carried powerful messages. Jesus was always trying to teach people about the nature of his Father and reveal

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the kind of relationship he wanted with his followers. Some understood, and some did not. The ones who were really hungry for the truth followed Jesus and became his disciples for life. The ones who were not became disillusioned with Jesus. Just like in the church today, some people listened to Jesus because they valued the entertainment of the parables more than the meaning. Others came to him to experience the shock

of seeing the blind healed and the lame walk. It seems humanity has always been attracted to the spectacular and supernatural.

But miracles don't always produce faith. One of the most spectacular miracles Jesus ever did was feed the five thousand in John 6. After performing this miracle, Jesus said something a little confusing. Having crossed the Sea of Galilee to Capernaum, he found more crowds waiting for him. When he saw them, he said, "You came looking for me because I fed you by a miracle, not because you believe in me. Why would you strive for food that is perishable and not be passionate to seek the food of eternal life, which never spoils?" (vv. 26–27 TPT). In other words, he was saying, "You look for me because of what you can get. Something supernatural is going on here, and you're not interested in what you witnessed—a miraculous invasion of God in human affairs. All you really want is more free food."

These people came out to see what Jesus would do. They witnessed an incredible supernatural event. And yet their hearts were hardened. They may have gotten a free meal miraculously, but they didn't receive what they could have from Jesus. Why?

Jesus said it was because they weren't seeking what mattered most: "the food of eternal life." They weren't seeking what Jesus really wanted to give them—truth that would change their thinking. He wanted to introduce them to a whole new life that they had never experienced.

When we seek the wrong things, we miss the right things. If we're seeking what we can get from God instead of what he really wants to give us, a taste of himself, then we'll miss out entirely. May you have such rock-solid faith that it doesn't matter when there are things you don't understand along the way because you are seeking what Jesus said to seek: "the food of eternal life."

Action Steps

When we passionately seek after what matters most, Jesus himself is ready to give it to us because that is what he desires. What would you say that you've been striving for or seeking most lately? More earthly things? Or more spiritual or eternal things?

What does the phrase "When we seek the wrong things, we miss the right things" mean to you?

Are there any "right things" you're missing because of what you've been busy seeking?

Read today's verses again carefully. Can you hear Jesus' passionate plea to us? What do you think he really wants?

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 70–71

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

God's Work

They replied, “So what should we do if we want to do God’s work?” Jesus answered, “The work you can do for God starts with believing in the One he has sent.” They replied, “Show us a miracle so we can see it, and then we’ll believe in you.”

John 6:28–31 tpt

After Jesus fed the five thousand, the crowd asked a series of questions, which were followed by rebukes from Jesus. The crowd asked Jesus a good question at first, one which many religions ask: “So what should we do if we want to do God’s work?” In other words, “What rules should we keep? How should we live? How can we please God?”

Jesus answered with this amazing reply: “The work you can do for God starts with believing in the One he has sent.” Jesus was giving us the key to where everything starts with God...

Jesus. Jesus is the One the Father has sent. No matter what we understand or don’t understand, it all starts with believing in Jesus and believing that God sent Jesus to save us. He is who he says he is, and if we follow him, we will be doing God’s work.

But after Jesus said this, the people didn’t say, “Oh Jesus, we do believe in you! We believe you are from God, the One he sent, and we want to follow you!” No, instead they said, “Show us a miracle so we can see it, and then we’ll believe in you.”

What in the world? These were the same people who had just eaten the bread that Jesus had multiplied. How could they say, “Show us a miracle”?

It seems unbelievable that anyone would ask such a thing after seeing a huge miracle like Jesus multiplying the fish and

loaves. But crowds can be cynical. They were just looking for a

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handout. Or entertainment. Or the spectacular. But not the truth. Because of their hard hearts, they were blinded to the miracles God was already doing. They couldn't even see them! How do we see what God is doing? Jesus said that he is "the door" (John 10:7 ESV). The work of God starts when we open the door. As soon as we believe that Jesus is who he says he is, we walk through the door and begin a whole new life in God. If we believe in him enough to leave everything else behind and follow after him, we'll not only be doing God's work, but our eyes will be opened to what he is doing all around us. We'll be connected to him and start on a path that will change our lives forever.

Action Steps

Describe in your own words what you think Jesus meant when he said, "The work you can do for God starts with believing in the One he has sent."

What does God do in your heart once you start really believing and following Jesus?

How is that different from following a bunch of religious rules to become holy?

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What do you think it really means to believe?

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 72

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 3

The Bread of God

They replied, “Show us a miracle so we can see it, and then we’ll believe in you. Moses took care of our ancestors who were fed by the miracle of manna every day in the desert, just like the Scripture says, ‘He fed them with bread from heaven.’ What sign will you perform for us?” “The truth is,” Jesus said, “Moses didn’t give you the bread of heaven. It’s my Father who offers bread that comes as a dramatic sign from heaven. The bread of God is the One who came out of heaven to give his life to feed the world.”

John 6:30–33 tpt

Have you ever heard a person say, “A miracle settles the issue”? This idea assumes that if God performs a miracle, people will be persuaded to believe. That is fundamentally untrue. Miracles cause some people to believe, but usually those people would have believed anyway, even without the miracle. In John 6, the people had seen miracles yet still didn’t believe. Many people today also see miracles and still do not believe.

What we believe influences how we perceive things. If a person thinks there is no way God sent his Son to die for humanity or that there is no living God who performs miracles today, it doesn’t matter how many miracles they see. They will find some way to excuse any miracle away.

So look what happened. Jesus performed an amazing miracle for these people, almost like what happened in Moses’ time when God fed the people with manna (Exodus 16). Jesus fed them with bread and fish. But they didn’t see the miracle.

Then they reminded Jesus of the miracle Moses did in the desert. Jesus basically replied, “It wasn’t Moses who did that

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miracle. God did it. And he’s providing an even more dramatic miracle right now by giving you the bread of God.”

Jesus, the one who multiplied the bread, was also the Bread of Life. He slept in a manger, a food trough for animals. He “came out of heaven to give his life to feed the world.” He said that if we eat this bread, we will never die.

Action Steps

How is it possible that miracles can be all around us, yet we can’t see them?

What does it mean that Jesus is “the bread of God,” and how does he feed us?

Jesus has given his life for you to feed you. Name some ways you’ve eaten the Bread of Life.

Ask the Lord to open your eyes to the miracles he’s doing all around you.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalm 73

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 4

You Will Never Be Hungry

“The bread of God is the One who came out of heaven to give his life to feed the world.” “Then please, sir, give us this bread

every day,” they replied. Jesus said to them, “I am the Bread of Life. Come every day to me and you will never be hungry. Believe in me and you will never be thirsty. Yet I’ve told you that even though you’ve seen me, you still don’t believe in me.”

John 6:33–36 tpt

What if there were a kind of bread that if you ate it, you’d never be hungry again? This seems so impossible, but it’s exactly what Jesus is offering us. He said he is the “Bread of Life,” a special kind of bread that will always satisfy us if we only come to him and eat of it every day. If we truly believe in him, we’ll never be hungry for all the world has to offer.

Jesus offered himself to the crowd, yet they just wouldn’t believe him. They saw the miracles, but they excused them away. Jesus was not about to do more miracles to convince these cynics to believe. When they rambled on about how their ancestors ate manna in the wilderness, Jesus was on to them. He knew that they were just looking for an excuse not to believe. He turned their rant around to explain that he was indeed the “bread of God” and the “Bread of Life” (John 6:33, 35 TPT). They replied, “Give us this bread every day” (v. 34 TPT). But again, they still wanted proof.

Jesus rebuked them, saying, “I’ve told you that even though you’ve seen me, you still don’t believe in me” (v. 36 TPT). So, what you believe interprets what you see. Whatever you believe can even prevent you from seeing something that happens right before your eyes.

Years ago, I visited the synagogue ruins in Capernaum where Jesus preached this very sermon. I imagined all the people crammed into the beautiful, ornate structure with its pillars and carvings as they listened to the Messiah and became offended by his claims: “When the Jews who were hostile to Jesus heard him say, ‘I am the Bread that came down from heaven,’ they immediately began to complain, ‘How can he say these things about himself? We know him, and we know his parents. How dare he say, “I have come down from heaven”?’” (vv. 41–42 TPT).

Jesus began his message by saying, “I am the Bread that came down from heaven,” and immediately they started grumbling. “Wait a minute,” they protested. “We know him. Who does he think he is?”

You may hear this kind of complaining when people encounter teachings or circumstances that don’t fit what they already believe. Jesus knew that the problem was their lack of understanding. He responded to this by saying, “Stop your grumbling! The only way people come to me is by the Father who sent me—he pulls on their hearts to embrace me. And those who are drawn to me, I will certainly raise them up in the last day” (vv. 43–44 TPT). Jesus is leaning in a little bit harder to help them see the supernatural connection. The Father would have to draw them in fully. Only he could illuminate their hearts.

Action Steps

Jesus offered the crowd the greatest thing they could ever hope

for. He gave them a chance to be filled with life, something they could never find anywhere else even if they searched the world over. But their way of viewing reality and their beliefs wouldn't allow them to see what was right in front of them.

Jesus offers us the same. But we must come daily. Just like we need breath daily, food daily, and drink daily, we need to

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come to Jesus and get everything he wants to give us each day.

This experience is different for each person. It will be personal and real for you.

What does Jesus want to “feed” you of himself today? Ask him and then write it down.

Ask Jesus to remove any unbelief or false realities in your thinking that keep you from seeing the truth.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 74–75

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 5

No Room for Soft Messages

“Your ancestors ate manna in the desert and died. But standing here before you is the true Bread that comes out of heaven, and when you eat this Bread you will never die. I alone am this living Bread that has come to you from heaven. Eat this Bread and you will live forever. The living Bread I give you is my body, which I will offer as a sacrifice so that all may live.”

John 6:49–51 tpt

Jesus wasn't a people pleaser trying to make everyone happy. He did not soften his message so people would have an easier time believing it. He simply told the truth: they could not understand what he was saying unless God drew them to himself.

Many times, I have stood before thousands of young people and asked God to draw their hearts toward him. It is so tempting as a pastor or a preacher to soften the message in the hopes that people will come forward. It is daunting to know that people's whole spiritual futures can be affected by their response to the words you speak and by whether they believe and act on the message you share.

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But I would rather have one person fully surrender his or her life to Christ than have a thousand people rave about a nice spiritual moment and a few goose bumps if that thousand does not completely give themselves to God. Based on Scripture, I believe Jesus felt the same way. When we read further in John 6, he said something that seemed designed to push people over the edge: "I alone am this living Bread that has come to you from heaven. Eat this Bread and you will live forever. The living Bread I give you is my body, which I will offer as a sacrifice so that all may live" (v. 51 TPT).

The statement was so raw and provoking that many people apparently reached their limit. They'd had too much. "These words of Jesus sparked an angry outburst among the Jews. They protested, saying, 'Does this man expect us to eat his body?'" (v. 52 TPT). Essentially they were saying, "Does this man expect us

to be cannibals? Does he really expect us to eat his flesh? How can he possibly think we would consider doing that?”

Jesus did not reach out and say, “No, listen, that was just a metaphor. Let me explain what I really meant.” Instead, he just revealed truth, even though many continued down the path of skepticism: “Eternal life comes to the one who eats my body and drinks my blood, and I will raise him up in the last day. For my body is real food for your spirit and my blood is real drink. The one who eats my body and drinks my blood lives in me and I live in him” (vv. 54–56 TPT).

Jesus never adjusts to what we want him to be; we must adjust to him. He’s the Lord.

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Action Steps

What do you think Jesus meant when he told his disciples to eat his body and drink his blood?

These things Jesus said caused a lot of tension. But he was never afraid of tension. Why do you think Jesus would say these kinds of things instead of softening his message?

What has he said to you that was at first hard to swallow or understand but then turned out to be the thing you needed to hear?

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 76–77

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 6

The Only Altar Call to Leave

Jesus said to his twelve,

“And you—do you also want to leave?”

John 6:67 tpt

As you’re beginning to see, Jesus never altered his message to get more followers. He purposely challenged his listeners.

“When many of Jesus’ followers heard these things, it caused a stir. ‘That’s disgusting!’ they said. ‘How could anybody accept it?’” (John 6:60 TPT). They tried to wrap their minds around what he said.

Jesus knew that even his followers were complaining. He asked, “Are you offended over my teaching? What will you do when you see the Son of Man ascending into the realm from where he came?” (vv. 61–62 TPT). We might paraphrase Jesus’ response this way: “You’re upset because you don’t understand this? How about if I fly up to heaven now? Will you believe then? Will that lend more authority to my words? You just came out for more free food, but I am giving you something better—some real truth. You don’t want to hear that. You want the spectacular. You want me to somehow prove that I am who I say I am.”

At this point, Jesus reminded them that no one could come to him unless the Father enabled them (v. 65). That was when “many of the disciples turned their backs on Jesus and refused to be associated with him” (v. 66 TPT).

It is so curious that after Jesus gave this very intense message that was very difficult to understand, he did nothing to

change the minds of those who were turned off by it. He stopped no one from turning away from him. Most preachers

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today, myself included, would say, “No, wait! Don’t leave. Let me explain this. I can make you understand it. It’s not as radical as you think.” But Jesus did not do that. In fact, he turned to the Twelve and asked, “Do you also want to leave?” (v. 67 TPT).

Jesus is the only person I know who ever gave an altar call for people to leave him. Can you picture it? The venue is packed, the invitation is given, and people respond by filing out. As they do, the preacher says, “I see that hand. You want to leave too? Just walk out that door.”

Jesus will never beg us to follow him. He never apologizes for the truth or waters it down because he knows that the truth sets us free. “If you hold to my teaching, you are really my disciples. Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free” (John 8:31–32). Grab hold of his teaching and don’t let go. It’s the only way to be a true follower.

Action Steps

What do you think it means that Jesus never adjusts to who we want him to be but that we must adjust to him?

What was it that convinced you to start following Jesus in the first place?

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When we get a revelation that God is real and we really need him, then everything changes. But if we think that we humans are going to understand everything about God, then

we are lowering him to our level. We need to remember that we are made in his image, not the other way around.

Even when there are things you don't understand, it's good to remind yourself of the changes God has made in your life and the good things he has done for you since you've given your heart to him. Write those down here.

Now take some time to thank him for these blessings.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 78:1–31

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 7

Believers Believe

I received from the Lord that which I also delivered to you: that the Lord Jesus on the same night in which He was betrayed took bread; and when He had given thanks, He broke it and said, “Take, eat; this is My body which is broken for you; do this in remembrance of Me.” In the same manner He also took the cup after supper, saying, “This cup is the new covenant in My blood. This do, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of Me.”

1 Corinthians 11:23–25 nkjv

After people walked away from Jesus, Jesus asked the Twelve whether they were ready to hit the road too. Simon Peter replied, “Lord, where would we go? No one but you gives us the revelation of eternal life” (John 6:68 TPT).

I wonder what was going through Peter's mind as Jesus said these controversial things. I have to believe that Peter was just

as confused as anyone else. He had to be thinking, Eat your flesh and drink your blood? What is that about? Yet at the same time, Peter's heart had been filled with life from the words of Christ, so his only response was "Where else can we go? You have the words of life. We have to follow you."

Scripture does not elaborate, but it is easy to imagine how Peter would have expressed his confusion and his faith in our modern lingo: "Jesus, I don't understand this teaching, and I don't really like it. It doesn't make a lot of sense, and it even freaks me out. But what your words have done inside my heart is so much bigger than the fact that I don't understand this particular teaching. One teaching that I can't grasp is not enough to chase me away from you. You have a hold on my heart. You

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filled it full of life. How could I leave you? So I am going to follow you even though I don't understand you at this moment."

I wonder if this was Jesus' point all along—to search out the ones who believed no matter what. Certainly, the disciples learned more about the blood and the body later, at the Last Supper, when Jesus said, "This is My body which is broken for you....This cup is the new covenant in My blood" (1

Corinthians 11:24–25 NKJV).

They later understood Jesus' message in John 6 because they stuck around long enough to hear more. If the others had stayed, they would have understood it as well. Sometimes we don't understand while we're going through something, but if we stick with Jesus, we'll understand in time.

Jesus is still looking for committed people who say to him,

- I will follow you even when I don't understand your words.
- I will follow you even when I don't understand my circumstances.
- I will follow you even when everything seems to be falling apart.
- I will follow you even when nothing really makes sense anymore.

So if you hear a sermon or read something in the Bible that you don't understand or if something happens that doesn't line up with your theology, you will not stop following the Son of God, who gave his life for you. Your faith is bigger than any logic, circumstance, or understanding. Only God has the words of life that have captured your heart.

This is the foundation on which we build a vibrant relationship with Christ. Even when we don't understand, we follow the rightful owner of our lives, and in him, we can develop a strong, resilient faith.

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Action Steps

The disciples heard a message about communion that they didn't understand, so many left. But some stayed because they knew that Jesus had the words of life.

What things that you haven't understood have challenged your faith?

What have you learned this week about following Jesus when you don't understand?

How can you believe no matter what and still keep your faith strong in Jesus?

If you've had a hard time following Jesus because something in your life doesn't make sense or line up with what you think it should be, I challenge you to give that to the Lord now. You can

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pray along these lines: Lord, there are things I don't understand, but I choose to trust you anyway. I repent for allowing my faith to be shaken when circumstances didn't make sense to me. Open my heart to you, Lord. Show me your truth. I surrender my logic and my understanding. I choose to put my confidence in your character, knowing you will reveal your mysteries in your time. Even when I don't understand, I won't stop following you because you gave me life. Thank you, Lord, for always being faithful. In Jesus' name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 78:32–72

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Discuss why miracles don't always cause people to become followers of Jesus. How can we make sure we see miracles all around us? Discuss what Jesus meant when he said, "The work you can do for God starts with believing in the One he has sent" (John 6:29 TPT). Share what you learned this week about what to do when you don't understand Scripture, difficult circumstances, or what God is doing in your life. Take some time to pray for and encourage each other.

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Week 7

Keeping in Step

with the Holy Spirit

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Day 1

Spiritual Endurance Training

We also, since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us lay aside every weight, and the sin which so easily ensnares us, and let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking unto Jesus, the author and finisher of our faith, who for the joy that was set before Him endured the cross, despising the shame, and has sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.

Hebrews 12:1–2 nkjv

With a solid understanding of resilient faith, you will still have to put in the time to develop it, which means you have to train. Like a marathon runner who sets their sights on competing in a certain race, you can only finish yours by first preparing for it. You cannot just buy the right shoes and think you are all set. Nor can you stretch your leg muscles and think you are ready to roll. You must prepare your whole body to run, from head to heart to toe. It's the same way in life. We need the kind of training that builds endurance so that when the storms come—and they will—we'll be ready. That is the only way we will actually finish

our race.

I always hated running. After two miles, I would be in so much agony that I'd want to stop. Then my daughters, Hannah and Charity, asked me to run a half-marathon with them, and I agreed to do it. I endured hours of agonizing pain, and after it was all over, I decided I would never run again (except to the kitchen to get something out of the refrigerator). A few years later, Charity, my younger daughter, was preparing to run a full marathon. She inspired me so much that I decided to get back in the game and sign up for a marathon that was several months away.

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Because I had heard about people who actually died while running marathons, I read up on how to train properly. The whole thing scared me a little. It is not that I didn't look forward to dying and being with Jesus someday; I was just not ready to die right then, especially not after four hours of pain (before the pain, maybe, but not after).

So in desperation, I devoured every morsel of information I could find and prepared for the run of my life. One of the terms that kept coming up in the articles I found was endurance training. This topic seemed to be brought up by writers who wanted to emphasize the difference among endurance, speed,

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and strength training. They are all related, but endurance training is different from the other two. To finish a marathon, you have to endure, and to endure, you have to train.

The Bible talks about endurance too. It is essential when

running the race called life. Resilient people have learned to endure. The writer of the book of Hebrews addressed this important subject. In fact, he made a very strong case for spiritual endurance training. The training he described was all about following Christ's example. Please reread today's Scripture passage in Hebrews 12:1–2.

The passage commands us to run the race with endurance. It says we cannot finish the race without it. In other words, endurance is what makes us resilient. The apostle Paul wrote in

Acts 20:24, “My only aim is to finish the race.” He was

determined to endure because he knew that our Christian life is a race to a finish line we must reach.

Action Steps

Memorize and write out today's Scripture passage from

Hebrews 12:1–2.

What are the three points that the author told us to do in this passage?

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What are some things that are ensnaring and hindering you from running your race with endurance? How can you “lay aside” these things today?

Describe in your own words what it means to “run with endurance” the race marked out for you.

Pray this: Lord, I am determined to finish the race set before me, and I will finish strong. As the writer of Hebrews said, let me run with endurance the race set before me, fixing my eyes on you, the author and finisher of my faith. Give me the stamina and

diligence to commit to the discipline of training so that I endure to the end for your glory. In Jesus' name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 79–80

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 2

Sticking with It

Blessed is the one who perseveres under trial because, having stood the test, that person will receive the crown of life that the Lord has promised to those who love him.

James 1:12

We hear a lot about being strong in the Lord, but even in the natural world, physical strength doesn't equal endurance. We can press a lot of iron but lack the stamina to stay in the race. What do we do in times when we falter and lack the strength to keep going? James 1:12 says we are blessed when we persevere under trial. When it comes to being resilient, stamina is the operative word.

Stamina means “the energy and strength to continue to do something over a long period of time.” We need the ability to bounce back and sustain our strength. We need to keep going and going like the Energizer Bunny. And we need the strength the Holy Spirit provides for the stamina to persevere. To finish the race, we have to keep pressing forward no matter what comes against us.

Successful runners must learn to hang in there. So when I

decided to run the marathon, I made it my business to study endurance and develop it in myself. I was struck by the fact that no one finishes a marathon by accident. Runners have trained. They've focused. They've developed. Everyone who crosses the finish line first submits to rigorous training. They push their bodies and focus their minds—and they stick with it! So many Christians start off with excitement, passion, hope, and zeal. They say, “I hope I stay on fire. I hope I make it to the end. I hope I finish my race. I hope I hear the words

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‘Well done, good and faithful servant’” (Matthew 25:21). That sounds like a lot of hope but not much confidence. People who sign up for marathons don't hope to finish. They are determined to finish. They put their minds to doing whatever is necessary and say, “I will run the course and finish it.” They train. They prepare themselves physically and otherwise. They figure out what it will take for them to cross the finish line. It takes determination to succeed in every sport. If athletes can make that commitment, so must we for a much greater cause. A lot of parallels exist between training for a marathon and training to finish our spiritual race. Yet we are not always as serious about our training as marathon runners are. We need to be. And training to endure should be at the top of our list.

Action Steps

We've been talking about endurance, perseverance, and stamina. In what areas of your life and spiritual growth do you need these virtues the most? Where do you need more strength

to stick to it no matter the opposition?

Commit these areas to the Lord and ask for the Holy Spirit's help for each one. He is always with you and will be your helper (John 14:16).

Pray James 1:12 over yourself, asking God to empower you to persevere under trial and stand the test. He promises that you will receive the crown of life!

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Daily Bible reading: Psalms 81–83

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 3

Building Spiritual Muscle

I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race,
I have kept the faith.

2 Timothy 4:7

Resilience in life doesn't happen by accident, just as no one finishes a marathon by accident. We have to prepare. We all have a race to run, and we have to prepare to finish it no matter what comes our way.

When I ran a marathon, I was not committed to winning the marathon; I just wanted to finish it. That was my part—to finish. It's important for us to remember that we're not called to win the race; we're called to finish it.

Paul did not claim to win his race. He just said, "I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the

faith” (2 Timothy 4:7). That is our assignment: to cross the finish line.

When I began training for my marathon, I learned a number of things a runner must do to finish the race. The first order of business was to train my muscles to endure because the condition of my muscles could either make me or break me. To persevere, I had to get my muscles in shape. If I did not, I risked pulling them in the heat of the race. If that were to happen, I could forget about running; I would barely be able to walk. The idea of limping through the race didn’t appeal to me, so I decided to train my muscles properly to avoid severely injuring myself.

Part of muscle training is stretching. Runners have to do extensive stretching before and after each run. Skipping this step can cause serious injury. Just like runners need to stretch

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their physical muscles, we need to stretch our spiritual muscles, and life often stretches them for us. Our patience is stretched; our kindness is stretched; our love is stretched to the limit. All of it prepares us to finish our race.

Besides stretching, runners have to roll out their muscles.

The process is fairly painful; athletes use a Styrofoam roller to give themselves an intense massage. Perhaps you’ve had a massage that was so deep it was actually painful. That is what runners are encouraged to do. Rolling out your muscles creates deep pressure that hurts, but it helps your muscles heal and strengthen.

Runners also are encouraged to take ice baths after a long run to help repair their muscles. Ice baths cause the capillaries to constrict and release toxins. The next day, the pain in your legs isn't as intense.

Whether running a physical or spiritual race, training is a process. I learned that after a very long run, I needed not to run the next day. I paced myself, doing long runs once a week. I started off with eight miles and increased the length incrementally. All the while, I worked on conditioning so my muscles could handle longer and longer distances.

As you're training for "the race marked out for you" in life, remember that training is a process. It takes time and practice. You won't become an expert Christian keeping in step with the Holy Spirit overnight. You have to train yourself to hear his voice, overcome sin, and react to people in love. Day after day, you pray while reading, studying, and meditating on God's Word, and as you do, the Lord begins to transform you to be more like him. It doesn't happen instantly; it's a process.

But when you stick with it, you'll be surprised when you realize that you're not the same person you were when you began. You'll see supernatural changes that are astounding to you and the people around you because you'll become stronger and more resilient by the day.

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Action Steps

How has life stretched your spiritual muscles lately? Maybe your patience, kindness, or love has been stretched. Describe

how God has tested you.

What areas have you noticed that are stronger spiritually than they were when you started this journey with Jesus?

What areas have you jumped into and realized your spiritual muscles weren't strong enough to handle yet?

How can you strengthen those spiritual muscles so that you'll be strong enough the next time you are in the same kind of situation?

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Daily Bible reading: Psalms 84–85

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 4

Are You Watching or Working?

Physical training is of some value, but godliness has value for all things, holding promise for both the present life and the life to come.

1 Timothy 4:8

We all know we need to be more godly, but how do we get there? First Timothy 4:8 says that godliness is valuable for every part of our present lives and for all eternity. So how do we train ourselves to become more godly? Even with physical training, if our muscles are really strong, they can fail in the long race if they are not trained to endure. It's not just about how solid your legs are but whether they are trained to keep going until the race is finished.

We are naturally good at short-term goals. Think of them like sprinting. Each January, every gym on the planet recruits new members by offering discounts. Owners know that people make New Year's resolutions to lose weight and improve fitness. People flock to the gym, saying, "This is the year I will get in shape!" Gym owners know that if they get these people committed to annual memberships, the automatic monthly bank deductions will roll in. Although people will pay for the year, few will use their memberships to their full advantage. Some will quit going after a couple of months. Others will show up but do more watching than working.

Imagine if someone went to the gym and just watched people work out and then blamed the gym for their poor results: "That gym membership is not helping me a bit! People are sweating and working hard when I get there, and I'm watching them and trying to get in to it. But when I leave,

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not any stronger at all. It's a stupid gym! I'm not going back!" It seems obvious: it doesn't matter if you join the gym; you have to use it to see results. Unless you lift the weights yourself and train your muscles yourself, you will not get stronger or better. You certainly won't gain strength by spectating.

This is exactly what too many people do on Sunday mornings and Wednesday nights. They go to church and watch other people work out. They watch their pastor, their youth pastor, and the worship leader work out—pumping iron, as it

were—by talking about their faith and what God has been speaking to them, but then they don't do any work of their own. They may shout amen, but after two, three, or four months—or even two, three, or four years—at the same church, they'll complain that they're not growing. They'll say, "I don't know about that church. It just doesn't help me."

It doesn't do you much good to just watch other people work out their spiritual muscles. You must work out yourself. Think about it like this: If you get serious about fitness and hire a personal trainer, you do not pay someone to work out for you. You are paying a professional to get in the gym with you and push you. Your trainer might scream, yell, motivate, and encourage you, but he or she cannot exercise for you. You have to do your own push-ups, pull-ups, and bench presses.

It would be crazy to suppose that you could become fit by watching someone else do the work. Yet some Christians think, "If my pastor or my parents or somebody else were stronger in the Lord, I would be stronger. No one can do your spiritual workout for you—you have to do it on your own."

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Action Steps

First Timothy 4:8 says that physical training is "of some value," but the real value lies in spiritual training. Have you been spending more energy on physical training or other kinds of training than spiritual training in your life? What kind of training is most of your energy focused on?

Are you busy watching other people do the hard work of

training themselves in the Lord? Explain how.

If you are doing more watching than working on your own growth, how can you become a participant rather than a spectator in the things of God?

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 86–87

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 5

Working the Disciplines

Train yourselves to be godly.

1 Timothy 4:7

If you want your spiritual muscles to become strong and resilient, you have to be the one who works out. How do you work your spiritual muscles? Is it possible to do physical things that achieve spiritual results? It is! In fact, from the very beginning, early church fathers such as Augustine taught us spiritual disciplines. These activities engage the body and mind to strengthen our spiritual muscles.

A word of caution: all too often, spiritual disciplines are turned into to-do lists designed to make God love us more. The concept could not be further from the truth. The disciplines we are about to explore are designed to open up our minds and hearts so we can hear from God more clearly. We are not trying to earn anything. We are simply trying to get our muscles in shape so we can receive from the Lord. Then, as we receive, we become stronger and full of life.

Some of these disciplines will be more familiar to you than others. As you read, think about how they can help you to build spiritual muscle:

- The Discipline of Prayer: This is a regular, consecrated quiet time focused on engaging with God. Prayer is an honest conversation with him, not just a time to ask him for things or to dream about all the things you want to see happen. That being said, it is a perfectly good time to express your concerns to the Father, who loves you.

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- The Discipline of Worship: Humans were created to worship. If we don't worship the Lord, we'll worship another person or object. That's called an idol. The discipline of worshiping God means stopping the busyness of life and taking time to revere, honor, and treasure the Lord above everything else. You could thank him for the good things he's bringing about in your life. You could praise him for who he is to you. If you have a hard time getting started, turn on some worship music and sing to him while you're singing about him. Lift your hands as a sign of surrender. As you worship from your heart, he will fill you afresh with his presence.

- The Discipline of Bible Reading: This is the daily reading of Scripture. Whether you read one chapter or ten per day, whether you read the entire Bible in a year or two or more, reading it is a discipline. That means you do it when you feel like it and when you don't. Just as your body needs

bread, your spirit needs the Bread of Life to survive.

- The Discipline of Silence: Many early church fathers practiced silence. Some do the same today, whether for a day, a week, or some other increment of time. It is a powerful practice because our world is full of noise. Decide to be silent and find out what the Lord might speak to you.

- The Discipline of Service: This is about serving others instead of yourself. Whatever you do—scrubbing, building, helping, encouraging, or comforting—you will sense God pouring his life into you as you pour your life out to others.

- The Discipline of Observing the Sabbath: Observance of the Sabbath is one of the Ten Commandments. The point is to consistently set the day aside because it is the Lord's Day. Cease your regular work so that you can fellowship, be filled with God, and draw closer to him.

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- The Discipline of Fasting: Fasting is abstinence from physical food so that you can focus on spiritual food. It is a time for devouring Scripture and quieting your heart to hear God. Notice that when the Pharisees turned fasting into a ritual, Jesus rebuked them, but he still encouraged his disciples to fast. Fasting has many benefits. Over the years I have fasted in a variety of ways. I might abstain for three days at a time or for ten or more. Often I take only water, but I have done broader liquid fasts for up to

forty days. Either way, I don't just fast from food—I also feast on him. (You can fast from things you love—sugar, social media, or TV. This type of fasting demonstrates self-control.)

- The Discipline of Solitude: This means spending time away from people so you can be with God only. It is another way of intentionally drawing closer to him.
- The Discipline of Reflection: This is about taking time to find a place to think. Sneak away from your fast-paced world on a regular basis and simply reflect. You can reflect on Scripture or on the times God has done something amazing in your life. You can journal what comes to you in your reflection time. You will be surprised by what you learn.
- The Discipline of Scripture Memorization: Memorizing passages of Scripture is a powerful way to renew your mind. You could memorize a chapter or even a book of the Bible. I can almost hear you say, “I can't even memorize the things I need to know for school or work.” Don't let your past experiences stop you. You can do this! As you practice this discipline, it becomes easier and easier.

God doesn't just automatically transform us because we want him to. First Timothy 4:7 says we have to train ourselves in godliness. Our spiritual fathers taught us how to do this using spiritual disciplines. When you are disciplined, you don't hope to

meet a challenge or finish a race; you prepare to do so. When I

started that first full marathon, I knew I was going to finish because I had trained to endure; I worked on getting my muscles in shape. When you train yourself in the spiritual disciplines, there's no reason to worry about the outcome because you have already prepared yourself to cross the finish line.

Action Steps

Before you begin any spiritual disciplines, remember this truth:

“Before you do anything, put your trust totally in God and not in yourself. Then every plan you make will succeed” (Proverbs 16:3 TPT). Take a moment to write this verse down and memorize it.

Today you learned a lot of ideas for spiritual training. As you read over the spiritual disciplines, which ones caught your attention the most, and why?

You can incorporate into your daily life some of these disciplines, like prayer, worship, Bible reading, and memorization. Which ones would you like to do every day?

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Some of them you might practice once a week or even once a month. For instance, practicing the Sabbath would be once a week, but you could also engage in serving others once a week. Perhaps you could set aside some time once a month for fasting a meal or two, solitude, and reflection. Which ones can you begin to include in your life this way? Write the disciplines you'd like to start with and how often you'll do them.

As you practice training yourself in these disciplines, you will notice an incredible acceleration of spiritual growth in your life.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 88; 89:1–11

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 6

Cardio Conditioning

“Blessed are the pure in heart, for they will see God.”

Matthew 5:8

To endure a marathon and to be resilient, as in the race of life, you must make sure your heart is in great shape. I have learned a lot about what happens to your heart and your lungs as you get in good shape. The average body has about a million miles of arteries and capillaries. Capillaries are the tiniest blood vessels. They help carry oxygen to your extremities to nourish and strengthen the muscles.

As you exert yourself, more capillaries are created. This raises your oxygen capacity so that more oxygen is carried throughout the body, including to your lungs. If you run a ten-minute mile tomorrow, your heart rate will rise, and your breathing will become heavy. But if you run a ten-minute mile every day for a week, your breathing will gradually improve as your body grows more capillaries.

With a more efficient circulatory system, you don't need to breathe as heavily to keep your muscles nourished. At the same time, the more panting you do, the more waste you unload. All this increases endurance. As you exercise your cardiovascular system, you create the capacity for resilience.

So you might be asking, What does this have to do with my

spiritual life? The process of becoming spiritually resilient is similar. Spiritually speaking, the Holy Spirit is our oxygen. Just like your physical heart, your spiritual heart needs to be in great shape so that the Holy Spirit, the presence of God, can flow through your entire being. John 20:22 says that the resurrected Jesus breathed on his disciples and they received

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the Holy Spirit. To maintain our spiritual oxygen level, we must pace ourselves and keep our hearts pure.

Even if we attend the most on-fire church in the world, we still live in an impure world. Toxins are everywhere. We “inhale” the world’s toxins every day through media, music, the internet, and advertising. Like smog in a polluted city, they tend to leave their residue on us.

Jesus said, “Blessed are the pure in heart, for they will see God” (Matthew 5:8). Jesus was explaining how important it is to keep your heart in good shape and to eliminate the toxins that work to corrupt it. No matter how pure your heart is today, toxins can find their way in tomorrow. Don’t become like so many who have gone to church or faith-based youth events for years only to discover that they no longer sense God’s presence. They say, “I can’t feel him. I can’t hear what he’s saying. What’s wrong?”

Jesus said that if you are pure in heart, you will see God.

You will sense him. You will hear and understand his ways and his heart. You will see him in your life and the lives of others— if you keep your heart in good shape.

If you want to be in good physical shape, you need a cardio

workout at least several times a week. To be in good spiritual shape, you need your spiritual cardio workout every day. This means that you need to examine your heart and look for toxins to unload. We all need this! So pray as David did: “Search me, God, and know my heart; test me and know my anxious thoughts. See if there is any offensive way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting” (Psalm 139:23–24). When we pray this way, we’re saying, God, the residue of the world is in me. I want to exhale these toxins; I want to repent. Please purify my heart so I can inhale more of you.

This is part of what repentance is all about—getting the garbage out of our lives. Even when we follow Christ, the residue of the world tries to land on us. Every day we need to shower ourselves under the grace of God. Just as we must inhale oxygen to live, we must inhale the Lord’s presence. As we

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exhale the world and its attitudes, we increase our capacity for him. When we exhale the world and repent, saying, God, cleanse my heart, God breathes his life in us, filling our hearts to capacity.

Action Steps

How do you keep your spiritual heart in great shape?

What “toxins” have you inhaled lately that could keep your capacity for the Lord’s presence limited?

If you’ve been struggling to sense God’s presence, take a moment right now to stop and pray this prayer: Father, show me if there is any wicked way in me. Please give me a pure heart.

Get the toxins out of my system so I can see you, hear you, and sense your presence all day! In Jesus' name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 89:12–52

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 7

Spiritual Nutrition

Though by this time you ought to be teachers, you need someone to teach you the elementary truths of God's word all over again.

You need milk, not solid food! Anyone who lives on milk, being still an infant, is not acquainted with the teaching about righteousness. But solid food is for the mature, who by constant use have trained themselves to distinguish good from evil.

Hebrews 5:12–14

My wife is a health-food queen. I'm a junk-food king. If a dish has veggies in it, Katie loves it. I do not. She tried to get me to eat more healthily for years. Nothing worked. But when I started studying in earnest about how to train for a marathon so I wouldn't die trying to finish, I learned a lot about nutrition and how it enables runners to finish the race.

Marathon runners live with an ever-present fear of "hitting the wall." This tends to happen at around mile twenty or twenty-two of the race, when the runner's body is so depleted of energy that he or she collapses. Some runners feel a lot of physical pain. Some feel really tired, and others just give up. When you hit the wall, it is possible to push through to

finish the race, but it is excruciating on many levels. When I first learned about it, I assumed it was inevitable that every runner would hit the wall at some point. Then one day as I was devouring all the magazines and books I could get my hands on, I understood something that set me free: only ignorant and uninformed people hit the wall.

Whoa! I could hardly believe what I'd read. If only ignorant and uninformed people hit the wall, then I knew I could prevent myself from doing it. And if it was possible to keep

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from hitting the wall, then I decided I was not going to be ignorant and I was not going to be uninformed. I continued to devour every piece of information I could find to learn how to avoid hitting the wall.

This applies to Christianity too. Spiritually speaking, people hit the wall all the time. We all know someone about whom we can say, "So-and-so used to be so on fire. What happened? I haven't seen them in church in months or even years." Or "I heard so-and-so started hanging out with this crowd. They're mad at the church and don't want anything more to do with God."

When our Christian friends hit the wall, we may wonder, What happened to them? Why did they throw in the towel? What caused them to collapse? Instead of living in fear that the same thing might happen to us, we can make sure it doesn't. One of the best ways to avoid hitting the wall is to get excellent spiritual nutrition. The right "food" will help us be resilient to the very end.

Spiritual nutrition works a lot like physical nutrition does.

The right physical food gives you the right kind of energy. You have probably heard about good carbs and bad carbs. Your body converts everything you eat, whether carbs or protein, into energy, and that energy helps you keep going. The problem is that some things are harder to convert than others. Certain foods take a lot longer to break down. Some are too fatty to convert easily when you eat them. Others convert to instant energy.

In running, you need a nutritional strategy because what you eat needs to keep giving you energy. Without a strategy you will run out of energy and hit the wall. In training for a marathon, you need to eat not only the right carbs but the right number of carbs. Before your big run, you can “carb up” by eating lots of pasta in the days leading up to the race. Then during the run, you have to carry the right nutrition with you so you can keep yourself fueled. If you eat bad carbs or junk food, you won’t have enough energy to finish the race. So even though it tastes good, unhealthy food will suck the energy out of you.

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So where is your energy coming from regarding your spiritual nutrition? Are you living on fresh manna, or are you still munching on something you learned a year or two ago? Are you totally reliant on what your pastor preaches, or do you also forage for your own food outside of church?

What kind of “carbs” are you consuming? Are you concentrating on “bad carbs,” as it were—media, movies, news, and video games? Spiritual junk food? If that’s all you’re putting

inside yourself, it's no wonder you don't have any spiritual energy. It's no wonder you're not hungry for the Word or the things of God. You're full of junk food. If you stuff yourself with the wrong things, you won't have room for what's good for you.

Think back to a great Thanksgiving meal that you looked forward to. Perhaps your parents prepared the feast—turkey and all the fixings. You decided to starve yourself all day to have room for this great dinner, but by early afternoon you were so hungry that you ate some chips and soda to tide you over. Unfortunately, one chip turned into a whole bag. By the time dinner was served, you were no longer hungry. You were so bloated with junk that your appetite was spoiled. You had a fantastic meal in front of you, complete with homemade dessert, yet you no longer were interested in eating it.

I wonder if that's what happens to many Christians on Sunday mornings or during other times when they sit down for their quiet time with God. He has prepared a beautiful meal for them to consume, but they are so filled with the world's messages that their spiritual bellies are bloated and their appetites spoiled. They are so stuffed that the meal God is offering does not even look appealing.

Could it be that we need to cut back on the junk food of the world so that we are hungry for the nourishment we really need—the feast God offers us each and every day?

We need to ask ourselves, How much spiritual food am I eating? Do I eat only at church? What would you think if someone said, "I know you need food to survive, so I'm going

to feed you only on Sundays and Wednesdays”? We’d think that person was out of their mind! Nobody would agree to that. If we wouldn’t try to survive by eating physical food only on Sundays and Wednesdays, why would we do that with our spiritual nourishment?

Once you realize your need for physical food, the next question you must ask yourself is this: What kind of spiritual food am I eating? Are you eating spiritual junk food? Are you only listening to messages that make you laugh? I am not saying that humor is ungodly. What I am saying is that we cannot listen only to messages that make us feel good. Spiritual junk food is like physical junk food. If you eat chips and candy bars all the time, you’re going to get fat and bloated, and you won’t be prepared to endure to the end.

The writer of Hebrews warned about this. In essence, he said, “By now, you should be able to eat solid foods, but I have to give you milk. You should be eating red meat and vegetables, but I can only give you the milk of the Word” (Hebrews 5:12–14, author’s paraphrase).

It is like our parents told us: we have to eat our vegetables—or, in this case, our spiritual vegetables. We need to absorb the right nutrients and address any deficiencies. If we are serious about finishing the race and not hitting the wall, we have to make it a priority.

Action Steps

What kind of spiritual food are you eating? Spiritual junk food?

Or messages that challenge you? Explain.

Have you ever “hit a wall” spiritually? If so, what led up to it?

If you’ve been feeding your spirit with a lot of junk food

(i.e., too much social media, video games, worldly ideas), what

is your plan to get the junk food out of your life and fill yourself

up with solid spiritual nutrition?

Prepare a solid spiritual diet for yourself. Use the chart to

plan your menu by listing all seven days of the week and the

things you will read and listen to on each day. Include books,

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podcasts, and other resources that you know will challenge you.

Allow them to provoke you to repent where it is needed. Be

thankful when they reveal areas in which you are weak and

need to become strong. For instance, if you find it difficult to be

generous, seek out teachings and mentorship in the area of

generosity and giving. If you have trouble finding resources, ask

a leader to help you.

Pray for the Lord to guide you as you create this plan: Lord,

I don’t want to be like the people the writer of Hebrews talked

about who are still drinking the milk of your Word. I want to be

mature so that I can handle meat, the solid teachings of the

Word. Show me areas of weakness in my life and direct me to

resources that will help me address them. I want to be challenged

so I can be changed. Help me become strong so I can endure. In

Jesus’ name. Amen.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalm 90

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Discuss what you learned this week about the benefits of spiritual training and the spiritual disciplines. What's the difference between living by a set of religious rules to please God and training yourself in the spiritual disciplines? Share with each other the disciplines you put in place in your life this week and one of the benefits you've already experienced by practicing them. Take a moment to pray for one another for whatever needs you have.

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Week 8

Rotproof Roots

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Day 1

Remain in the Vine

“I am the vine; you are the branches. If you remain in me and I in you, you will bear much fruit; apart from me you can do nothing.”

John 15:4

If you've ever seen a beautiful garden, green and thriving and filled with fruit or flowers, it means that someone is very diligently caring for that garden. They are watching it every day, observing the growth and the health of all the plants. They are pulling weeds and killing off all the pests that would destroy the

leaves and fruit. They are cutting the dead branches off and pruning back even the fruitful parts of the plant so it can bear more fruit. Even though we may never see all the work that goes into keeping that well-kept garden, we get to enjoy the beauty and deliciousness of its nourishment. It is a delight to see and experience this kind of garden.

On the other hand, maybe you've also noticed when a yard or a garden is not well cared for. It is overgrown, weedy, and pest infested and bears little fruit, if any. It's not a place you want to go to have a picnic or sit on a bench and enjoy the view. When you see a place like that, you know that no one is watching it. It's just being ignored. No one is taking the time to tend it and bring it to its full potential.

In so many different places throughout the New Testament, metaphors are used to compare spiritual growth with plant life, like in this Scripture passage from John's gospel:

I am the true vine, and my Father is the gardener. He cuts off every branch in me that bears no fruit, while every branch that does bear fruit he prunes so that it will be even more fruitful. You are already clean because of the word I

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have spoken to you. Remain in me, as I also remain in you.

No branch can bear fruit by itself; it must remain in the vine. Neither can you bear fruit unless you remain in me.

I am the vine; you are the branches. If you remain in me and I in you, you will bear much fruit; apart from me you can do nothing. If you do not remain in me, you are

like a branch that is thrown away and withers; such branches are picked up, thrown into the fire and burned. If you remain in me and my words remain in you, ask whatever you wish, and it will be done for you. This is to my Father's glory, that you bear much fruit, showing yourselves to be my disciples. (John 15:1–8)

When we truly give our whole hearts to Jesus and let him be the king of our lives, we are essentially giving him permission to cut, prune, and shape us. When we go days without fellowshiping with him, we become like that overgrown, weed- and pest-infested garden. We grow careless with our actions and let whatever happens happen. Maybe people don't really want to be around us very much because we're not full of the fruit of the Spirit (love, joy, peace, patience, kindness). Before we know it, the fruit we once had begins to get choked out by all the weeds and pests. It's only when we remain in him, the Vine, that we have life and are fruitful. If we want the Father to be the gardener of our lives, we have to stay in Jesus, the Vine. Sometimes it seems painful. He has to cut off areas of our lives that are dead, do not produce any fruit, and have no life in them. An example could be a friendship that's really pulling us down. Maybe it's a habit or an activity we're involved in that holds us back from being on fire for God. But when we remain in Jesus and allow the Father to do what he wants to do to cut those areas off, then we grow to become like the beautiful, fruitful garden that feeds and nourishes many.

Action Steps

John 15:5 says, “I am the vine; you are the branches. If you remain in me and I in you, you will bear much fruit; apart from me you can do nothing.” What do you think God means by “apart from me you can do nothing”?

Take a moment to write out and memorize John 15:5.

Imagine if you were a garden. Describe what you would look like based on how much you’ve been allowing the Father to be your gardener lately.

Ask the Lord to show you what areas of your life are keeping you from your full potential and write them down.

Does something need to be completely cut off or pruned, or do pests have to be removed? Explain.

Take a moment to draw close to the Lord. Remain in him.

Pray over those areas and ask the Lord to begin “gardening” in places you may not have allowed him access to before.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 91

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

Why Does God Prune You?

“He cuts off every branch in me that bears no fruit, while every branch that does bear fruit he prunes so that it will be even more fruitful.”

John 15:2

Jesus taught every kind of person, from the very poor and uneducated beggar to the skeptical cynic. He confounded the Pharisees who thought they knew it all and mesmerized the bright-eyed, innocent little children. How did he explain hard-to-understand, deep spiritual truths to this diverse crowd? He used metaphors or examples of things they could see in everyday life; for example, he compared the way vines or trees grow to our relationship with God. The people could relate to these things, and if their hearts were searching for wisdom, they could understand him and apply the wisdom he taught to their lives.

Today, take a moment to carefully read John 15:1–8 again. This time, read it out loud. This is such a great passage, chock-full of insight, but today we want to focus on verse 2: “Every branch that does bear fruit he prunes so that it will be even more fruitful.”

It’s understandable why God would cut off dead things that were not producing any life or fruit in our lives, but why in the world would he prune back those areas that are already fruitful? If you’ve ever done any gardening, you may know that when you let plants grow wild and untamed, they definitely don’t look as good. They may have random, long, leggy branches growing out all over the place, and the energy of the plant is dispersed. But more importantly, they won’t produce as much fruit or as

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many flowers. When you cut back even the fruitful parts of the plant, it will begin producing much more fruit.

God gave us this metaphor in Scripture to help us understand why some things happen in our lives that are hard to understand. Maybe you thought you were doing really well with the Lord. You were being faithful, growing strong, meditating on Scripture, and spending time with godly friends. But suddenly, you're called to serve in a very obscure way that you don't think is important. You're getting less attention or accolades, and you think you deserve a more important place in God's kingdom. Perhaps the Lord is pruning you back to teach you even more humility and keep you from being self-serving or selfishly ambitious.

As you continue to "remain in the vine," seeking God with all your heart and keeping Scripture in your mind, you'll be more willing to allow your Father to prune you in whatever ways he wants to. You will also eventually see way more fruit as a result, guaranteed. You can trust your Father to prune you in every place that is most effective for your life and fruitfulness. And you can trust that he loves you and is an excellent gardener!

You will be able to look back on what was once a situation that baffled you and thank him for being the wise and careful gardener of your heart, bringing forth so much beauty, growth, and fruit.

Action Steps

Can you think of any ways you see the Father pruning back fruitful areas in your life?

What new fruit do you see growing? Maybe the fruit of the Spirit in Galatians 5:22–23: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Or maybe it's another kind of fruitfulness, such as more people seeing Jesus in you. Explain.

Take a minute to thank God for whatever difficult situation is going on in your life because even though he may not have caused it, you can trust him to bring forth more of his nature in you. Remain in Jesus and stay ever fruitful.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 92–93

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 3

The Constant Flow of the Holy Spirit

Blessed is the one who does not walk in step with the wicked or stand in the way that sinners take or sit in the company of mockers, but whose delight is in the law of the Lord, and who meditates on his law day and night. That person is like a tree planted by streams of water, which yields its fruit in season and whose leaf does not wither—whatever they do prospers.

Psalm 1:1–3

Psalm 1:3 says that we can be like trees planted by streams of

water. If you ask most Christians, “In your walk of faith, do you want to be as strong as the tree planted by the water?” they would say, “Yes, of course!”

The tree is a picture of resilience. Trees planted by streams

of water have a constant supply of life, even when there is drought. When other trees may be withering, trees planted by streams thrive, no matter what the conditions around them are, because their roots grow down deep into the constant nourishment of the water.

Jesus also spoke of water—living water. John 7:37–39 says, “‘Let anyone who is thirsty come to me and drink. Whoever believes in me, as Scripture has said, rivers of living water will flow from within them.’ By this he meant the Spirit, whom those who believed in him were later to receive.”

You may be asking, How can I get my life planted by streams of water and experience that constant flow of living water from the Holy Spirit? Psalm 1 tells you exactly how. In stead of doing the same things as the wicked, hanging out with those who love to sin, and sitting around with people who mock God and authority, spend time with the ones who are following Jesus.

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Delight in his law and meditate on his Word day and night.

Keep Scripture in your heart. Think about how you can live out his desires and ways each day.

If you are a believer and you decide to really live by Psalm 1:1–3, your whole life will change. The Bible says that you will have a constant flow of the Holy Spirit. You will continue to thrive no matter what is happening around you. Your life will yield fruit in its season. Your vitality will continue to be strong. You will prosper in all you do because you are constantly receiving the Holy Spirit.

Action Steps

Take a few moments to meditate on, memorize, and write out

Psalm 1:1–3.

According to this psalm, is there anything you are currently doing that would keep you from experiencing the constant flow of the Holy Spirit?

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If so, ask the Lord to forgive you and write out a new plan to ensure that nothing is blocking his living water from flowing through you.

Now pray Psalm 1:1–3 over yourself and personalize it like this: “Blessed is [your name], who does not walk in step with the wicked or stand in the way that sinners take or sit in the company of mockers, but [my] delight is in the law of the Lord, and [I meditate] on his law [Word] day and night. [I am] like a tree planted by streams of water, which yields [my] fruit in season and [my leaves do] not wither—whatever [I] do prospers.”

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 94–95

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 4

When Storms Come

“Everyone who hears these words of mine and puts them into practice is like a wise man who built his house on the rock. The rain came down, the streams rose, and the winds blew and beat against that house; yet it did not fall, because it had its

foundation on the rock.”

Matthew 7:24–25

It’s not uncommon for even massive trees to be blown over in big storms. In fact, I’ve seen giant oaks literally uproot and fall over while other trees stood strong right beside them.

Ask yourself, What will I look like after the storm? Storms will come, and when they come, will you be uprooted and snapped in two? Or have you learned how to stand strong? Do you try to get strong only when the wind comes and the storm begins? Or are you training for strength over time?

Why is it that some trees fall and others don’t? Why is it that some followers of Christ succumb to the storm while others don’t? The answers to these questions are key to understanding resilience.

In Matthew 7:24–25, Jesus answered these questions. He told us how to stand when the storms come. He said that if we not only hear his words but also put them into practice, our life will be like the house that’s built on the rock. Even when there’s a torrent around us, beating against the house of our lives, we will continue to stand.

There’s a big difference between knowing God’s Word and living his Word. Some people know all kinds of Scripture and can even quote it to you. They may have been Christians for a long time. But do they actually practice their faith?

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Jesus told us to put his words into practice. That means training over and over and over again. You might not get it

right the first or second or third time. But keep practicing. In the same way you'd hit the ball over and over in baseball or play the piano for thirty minutes a day to get good, you'll begin to get good at standing through storms with enough practice. As you put his powerful Word in your heart every day, reading it, meditating on it, memorizing it, and making plans to practice it, you'll find that your life becomes like a solid rock, and nothing can make you fall.

Action Steps

Describe a storm that you've experienced in your life.

How did you react? Did it pull you up by the roots, or did you stand? Why?

It's important that we stay in training by practicing God's Word every day so that when the storms come, we'll be ready.

Ask the Lord what area of your life he wants to strengthen.

Write it down and find a verse that you can begin practicing today to help you be strong in that area.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalms 96–97

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 5

What Kind of Tree Are You?

They will be called oaks of righteousness, a planting of the Lord for the display of his splendor.

Isaiah 61:3

Let's examine several different types of trees, assess their weaknesses, and see how they relate to different characteristics Christians can develop. See if you can relate to any of these weaknesses in your own life and write them down at the end of the lesson.

Softwood Trees

These are pine trees or balsas. They are generally large trees. They grow fast, but they don't have deep strength. Some Christians are like softwood. They've been around the church for a long time, but they're soft inside; they have no strength. You can't build a foundation with this type of faith.

Junk Trees

These are hackberry trees or other species that are actually overgrown weeds. They grow the quickest, but they have the shortest lifespan. The only things they are really good for are shade and appearance. That's what some Christians are like. They are only good for show. Their mouths are full of Christianese, but they don't get deep roots, and their spiritual legacy is short-lived.

Thorny Trees

These have sticky, nasty leaves like sweet gums. Some have thorns that stick and jab when you run through the woods.

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Others have spiky seedpods that fall and feel like broken glass when you step on them. Some Christians are like thorny trees. They have spikes in their character that hurt other people. They wound their friends with their words and actions. The fruit of

their lives is the pain they cause others. We should ask ourselves whether we hurt people with our words and actions.

Dead-Branch Trees

Some trees are full of dead branches. Soon after we moved to Texas, I woke up to find my car's back window bashed in by a big dead branch that had fallen from high up in a tree. Jesus mentioned that unfruitful branches need to be trimmed back (John 15:2), but many people carry dead branches around with them. There are areas where they're not bearing fruit or ugly areas and habits that are hurting other people. These fruitless deeds of the flesh are causing destruction to other people's lives. We need to look at ourselves and ask, Are there any dead branches that I need to break off my life?

On the other hand, do you have living branches that need pruning? Jesus said that even fruitful plants are trimmed to be more fruitful. It's true in almost every plant, including

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flowering plants and fruit trees. When you trim them, they sprout more. They bloom more. They bear more fruit. Just letting them grow whichever way they want is not helpful, but pruning them and guiding their growth are. God wants to prune your fruitful areas so they can be even more fruitful.

Baby Trees

When you first plant trees, it's smart to put two or three poles around them with guide wires to hold them up. That way, when storms come, the trees won't get blown over. Some people think they are going the extra mile by leaving the poles and guide wires

up for two to four years instead of just one. They believe they are helping their trees, but they are actually hurting them. After the supports are removed, trees that had them too long often get snapped in two or uprooted when the first storm comes.

There is something about the resistance of the wind and the storms that makes young trees strong. The wise cultivator takes the guide wires off after a year. Then as smaller storms come, the trees grow and build resistance in their root systems so they're not easily blown over. They also grow resilience in their trunks so they are not easily snapped. Many Christians are like baby trees. They are glad to have guide wires, but they've had supports for too long. They are afraid of storms. They try to duck around them. They've never learned to resist the winds of temptation when the Enemy comes. They've never had to develop a backbone. They get stuck with "spiritual crutches" for most of their lives.

It's time for all of us to grow up and remove our guide wires. It's time to let our root systems grow deep so that we can withstand the storms of life.

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Action Steps

What characteristics did you identify with from these different types of trees? Maybe you're too soft inside with no strength. Or you've grown really quickly, but your roots are not deep in God's Word. Do you have thorns in your character that hurt people and cause them pain? Or are there dead branches that need to be broken off? Have you been relying on supports too long and

needing to grow up so you can withstand the storms of life?

Write down the things you may have noticed about yourself.

What can you start doing to strengthen yourself in the Lord

so that you can withstand the storms of life?

Take a moment to write out and memorize Isaiah 61:3 and

make it a prayer and declaration over yourself: I will be called...

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Daily Bible reading: Psalms 98–100

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 6

Root Rot

[Jesus] told them many things in parables, saying: “A farmer went out to sow his seed. As he was scattering the seed, some fell along the path, and the birds came and ate it up. Some fell on rocky places, where it did not have much soil. It sprang up quickly, because the soil was shallow. But when the sun came up, the plants were scorched, and they withered because they had no root.”

Matthew 13:3–6

Trees need a good root system to grow and remain strong. If you want a healthy tree, you have to pay close attention to the root system. In Matthew 13:5–6, Jesus talked about plants that lack the right soil depth and proper roots. He went on to explain why his followers needed deep roots in his Word so they wouldn’t be easily distracted by the cares of this world

(Matthew 13:18–23).

Let's look at issues that hinder the growth of healthy root systems. Because many trees lack the right soil environment, they develop what's called root rot. There may be insufficient nutrition in the soil or too much iron. Sometimes the roots just don't grow down as deeply as they need to. They may have been overwatered after someone kept oversaturating the roots until they rotted. Maybe the roots never penetrated the ground. I've seen amazing pictures of trees literally growing into the sides of mountains and into rocks in the Grand Canyon and other places. What an awesome thing to see roots penetrating rock to get the nutrition they need!

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Are your roots deep in the rock of Christ? Do you have the right conditions in the soil around you so your root system can thrive and so you can grow as a strong tree in this world?

Galatians 5:22–23 says the fruit of the Spirit includes love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Fruit trees don't try to grow fruit. If they are planted in good soil, the fruit naturally grows. Followers of Christ are also meant to grow fruit. Yet too many of us Christians are forcing ourselves to be patient and kind instead of thinking deeply about where our roots are and what kind of nutrition we are soaking up. It's not about striving to grow, trying to bear fruit, or beating yourself up to be a good, faithful follower. It's about a

relationship with God: staying connected, listening to his voice, opening the Word, and asking him to teach you and prune you and transform you.

But our part is to make sure we have the right soil for our spiritual roots to grow down deep. How do we do that? We need to ask ourselves, What am I listening to? What am I watching? Whom am I hanging out with? How am I feeding my soul? What books am I reading? How am I spending my time? When you tend to these things properly, you become a tree planted by the living water.

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Action Steps

When you look at the spiritual fruit coming from your life, what would you say is the condition of your soil? Is your root system thriving, reaping an abundance of love, joy, and peace? Or is your root system lacking, creating a lot of stress, inner chaos, and strife? Explain.

Take a moment to assess the soil of your heart. What are you listening to?

What are you watching?

Whom are you hanging out with?

How are you feeding your soul?

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What books are you reading, including the Bible?

How are you spending your time?

Now what would you say is contributing the most to the healthy or unhealthy soil of your heart?

Get with your accountability partner and help each other come up with a plan for healthy soil so that your roots will grow down deep in Christ.

Pray this: Lord, I am sorry for not paying attention to where my roots are. I know that if they have the right conditions, I will produce fruit for you. Lord, help me prevent root rot by putting the right ingredients in my heart today. In Jesus' name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 101–102

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 7

Watch Out for Pests

“The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy;

I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full.”

John 10:10

Enemies or intruders can eat their way into root systems. These pests come in all shapes and sizes. Some are pine beetles, which can kill a whole forest of pine trees. The problem with pine beetles is that the affected trees take a long time to die. Though they may look strong on the outside, the trees' needles will turn brown and fall off after a few months. Then a storm comes, and they snap in an instant. Some die more gradually.

One of the biggest enemies of large trees is one of the smallest creatures: the carpenter ant. These ants can grow up to half an inch long. I've seen an army of them in my own yard.

They're not called carpenter ants because they have little

hammers and nails; their name came because they actually eat the insides of trees. They burrow their way under the ground, into the root system, and up the center core of the tree. An infestation can kill huge trees. When diseased trees are cut down, you can see where hundreds of thousands of ants have eaten away six-inch-wide tunnels. They can literally eat away the core of the tree.

Do you have any pine beetles or carpenter ants eating away at your core? Are there things you have done or attitudes you've had that you didn't think were a big deal until they began eating away at your strength?

Like infested trees, some Christians are gradually dying from what they have allowed to live inside them. Just as small ants can kill a big tree, the smallest of sins or habits can kill

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your spiritual life. Even though you may be getting stronger in the Lord, even though your roots might be strong, you still have to be on the lookout for the pests that the enemy of your soul sends to try to destroy you. Lies, deceptions, and sins are trying to lure you away.

Jesus said in John 10:10 that the thief, or the devil, is the one who comes to steal, kill, and destroy. He's out to steal what the Lord has done in your life. He wants to lie to you and tell you that you're not worthy of God's love or that you'll never be able to overcome the challenges in your life. He wants to kill your spiritual life by distracting you or enticing you with things of the world. But Jesus has come to give you abundant life.

When you stick with him, you'll see that his ways always work. Storms will come, but whether you stand depends on what you do to prepare when there is no storm. Ask yourself, Why do some people fall and others stand strong? Neither outcome is by accident. Those who stand are determined to get their roots down deep into God and diligently watch out for pests who come to steal, kill, and destroy. By the grace of God, we find his strength to fend off the enemies who seek to eat away at our core. You can be the Psalm 1 tree that is firmly planted by living water. You were created to be a strong tree with a healthy root system. You can withstand every storm and turn away every foe. You are resilient.

Action Steps

Do you see any evidence of pests in your life? Are there areas where the Enemy is trying to steal, kill, or destroy? Explain.

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How has this affected your relationship with Jesus and others in your life?

Take a moment to write out and memorize John 10:10.

Spend some time asking the Lord to forgive you for allowing these pests to ruin areas of your life. Ask the Lord what you need to do to rid yourself of them and write it down here.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 103; 104:1–18

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Connect Group Discussion

Discuss why Jesus used metaphors of vines and gardens to

explain deep spiritual truths. What do you think it means to “remain in the vine” (John 15:4)? Give examples from your own life of what happens when you live that out. How has God pruned you this week? Get in groups of three and share a storm that has happened in your life and how you stayed strong or didn’t stay very strong through it. Encourage each other with Scripture to help prepare yourselves for the next storm.

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Week 9

A Tale of Two Deserters

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Day 1

An Ancient Deserter

“There was a man who had two sons. The younger one said to his father, ‘Father, give me my share of the estate.’ So he divided his property between them. Not long after that, the younger son got together all he had, set off for a distant country and there squandered his wealth in wild living.”

Luke 15:11–13

Resilient people are constant. They do not fly the coop at the first sign of trouble or wander from the fold every time something rubs them the wrong way. Resilient people know how to endure over the long haul because they have trained themselves to do so.

This week I want to share two powerful stories of those

who were not resilient. These stories illustrate the deserting heart. One story is over two thousand years old. The other began in the twentieth century. Despite the millennia separating them, the stories are remarkably alike.

In Luke 15, Jesus tells the story of a famous deserter known as the Prodigal Son. The Prodigal Son deserted because of ungratefulness, impatience, and rebellion in his heart. He knew he would receive an inheritance when his father died, but he was not willing to wait that long. He was impatient not only to get the cash but also to spend it.

After he had spent everything, there was a severe famine in that whole country, and he began to be in need. So he went and hired himself out to a citizen of that country, who sent him to his fields to feed pigs. He longed to fill his stomach with the pods that the pigs were eating, but no one gave him anything.

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When he came to his senses, he said, “How many of my father’s hired servants have food to spare, and here I am starving to death! I will set out and go back to my father and say to him: Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son; make me like one of your hired servants.” (Luke 15:14–19)

This young man was unwilling to remain satisfied at home and equally unable to make it on his own. He’d planned on living it up (which he did), but he soon found himself in worse shape than pigs in a pen.

His life was an undeniable mess, but the mess is what finally forced him to examine his life and do the right thing. Filthy and starving, he humbled himself and returned home. He got up and went to his father.

But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and was filled with compassion for him; he ran to his son, threw his arms around him and kissed him.

The son said to him, “Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son.”

But the father said to his servants, “Quick! Bring the best robe and put it on him. Put a ring on his finger and sandals on his feet. Bring the fattened calf and kill it. Let’s have a feast and celebrate. For this son of mine was dead and is alive again; he was lost and is found.” So they began to celebrate. (Luke 15:20–24)

The Prodigal Son made the best possible choice in a very difficult situation. He admitted his failures and acknowledged his need. He humbled himself before his father, whom he had earlier treated with such arrogance. Despite the damage the son had caused, the father welcomed him home with open arms.

When we lack resilience and even when we fail miserably, we have a Father who loves us and longs to restore us. If we are humble, desertion is not the end.

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Action Steps

A deserter is someone who forsakes their cause or duty or

friends, like a soldier who leaves their post. Have you ever deserted a responsibility or something you knew you should do? Describe what happened.

After reading the parable of the prodigal son, what speaks to you most?

Take a moment to thank the Father for loving you so unconditionally and cherishing you as his son or daughter.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 104:19–35; 105:1–21

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 2

A Modern Deserter

“If you fail to do this, you will be sinning against the Lord; and you may be sure that your sin will find you out.”

Numbers 32:23

The parable of the prodigal son reminds me of another deserter I read about not long ago. In 1965, a twenty-four-year-old Army sergeant named Charles Robert Jenkins was stationed near the demilitarized zone between North and South Korea. Jenkins had served in the military for some time, but the dangers of patrolling the Korean border started to become more than he felt he could take. When he learned he would soon ship out to Vietnam, he felt he had to act quickly. One night after drinking ten cans of beer, Sergeant Jenkins decided to desert the US military. While out on a late-night patrol, he made his move. He told the troops with him to go on

ahead. As they did, he slipped away and passed into North Korean territory.

Sergeant Jenkins was immediately taken captive. He thought that the North Koreans would trade him to the Russians, who would then deport him to the United States in some kind of Cold War swap. That never happened. Instead, Jenkins remained a prisoner of the North Koreans for forty years.

Jenkins endured harsh physical treatment and was forced to become well-versed in his captors' communist propaganda. For seven years straight he had to study the writings of North Korea's dictator for eight hours a day, a task made much more difficult by the fact that it was written in a language he didn't understand. He never had enough food, and in North Korea's frigid temperatures, he constantly felt cold. He eventually married a Japanese woman whom the North Koreans had abducted.

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Through a long series of unexpected events and negotiations, Jenkins eventually had the opportunity to come home to the United States. In September 2004, after being allowed to go to Japan to be treated for an illness, he turned himself in at the American military base there. By the time of his surrender, he had suffered many ordeals and paid high costs for his decisions as a young man. His desertion had not worked out as he had planned. The damage of the choice he made in 1965 could not be undone. Things had gone too far, and there was no easy way out. Sergeant Jenkins, the deserter, still had to face military justice.⁶

When we desert the Lord, it may feel like a good idea at the time, but we will face heavy repercussions, whether on earth or in heaven. Numbers 32:23 says that when we sin against the Lord, we will always be found out. In other words, we won't get away with anything, especially because we belong to the Lord. The fact that God sees everything we do might sound scary to some, but it can actually comfort us because we know that God is always for us. He never wants anything, especially our sin, to destroy our lives. He exposes our sin only for us to deal with it and get free. We must stay true to the Lord even in the face of difficulties because he loves us and sacrificed everything for us.

Action Steps

You may have never experienced something quite as intense as what happened to Jenkins, but have you ever done something you knew was wrong and thought it would turn out well, but it didn't? Explain.

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Take a moment to ask the Lord if there's anything you're covering up, a lie you need to ask forgiveness for, or something else you need to make right so that you don't have to face harsher consequences by trying to get away with things. If so, write it down.

Ask the Lord to forgive you and make plans to correct the situation. What will you do to make it right?

Share this with your accountability partner or church leader so that you can have extra support.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 105:22–45; 106:1–9

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 3

The High Cost of Desertion

Do your best to come to me quickly, for Demas, because he loved this world, has deserted me and has gone to Thessalonica.

2 Timothy 4:9–10

Too many Christians are deserting their faith because they haven't found the backbone to be resilient.

Let's see what we can learn from the Prodigal Son and Sergeant Jenkins that will keep us from doing the same.

Both the Prodigal Son and Sergeant Jenkins created hardship for themselves and for others. The prodigal squandered a fortune, suffered humiliation, and created a rift in his family (Luke 15:25–32). Before his desertion, Charles Robert Jenkins had served long enough and with enough distinction to lead US reconnaissance missions. He wasn't a new recruit when he decided to desert. He had been elevated to the status of a sergeant and had soldiers under his influence and control. They looked to him for leadership and safety. Instead, he abandoned them.

Many times when people desert their faith, they think, It's only about me and my faith. My decisions won't hurt anybody. They don't think about the people around them who are watching them and being influenced by their decisions. They don't think of the destructive impact they may have on

someone else's faith.

Have you ever known someone who had been following Christ for years and then, for some reason, disappeared from the faith? Paul mentioned someone like this in one of his letters to his protégé, Timothy: "Demas , because he loved this world, has deserted me and has gone to Thessalonica" (2 Timothy

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4:10). Demas' decision no doubt affected others. The event was significant enough for Paul to mention it.

We, too, affect everyone we meet, whether for good or for bad. There are people all around us, unbelievers and Christians, young and old in the faith, watching how we'll handle adversity. We have the opportunity to bring courage and strength to people by the life that we live, even if we never say a word about Christ.

Action Steps

Take a minute to ask yourself some honest questions: What foundation have I built my faith on? Is it my parents' Christianity, or do I have a real connection with God that is my own? Explain.

Is my foundation as solid as I think it is? When there are storms, does my faith remain resilient, or do I lose perspective? Am I just going through the motions because of my family's faith, or is there a genuine love for Jesus burning inside me?

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If you deserted the faith, whom would it affect in your life?

Write out all the names here.

Pray this prayer: Oh Lord, take the areas of my life that are weak and let your strength be made perfect in me. I trust you always and lean into you more than ever so that I'll never be a deserter. May I never lead others astray because of my own foolishness. I want to be strong and follow you for the rest of my life. In Jesus' name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 106:10–48

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 4

Greener Grass Syndrome

The devil took him [Jesus] to a very high mountain and showed him all the kingdoms of the world and their splendor. “All this I will give you,” he said, “if you will bow down and worship me.”

Matthew 4:8–9

Both the Prodigal Son and Sergeant Jenkins thought the grass was greener on the other side of the fence. For the prodigal, the illusion of freedom and cash seemed inviting. Jenkins seemed to think even being in jail in the United States would be better than serving in the military. He likely thought, Anything has got to be better than what I am going through right now. All I really need is to get to the other side.

The grass on the other side always looks greener—until we get there. That is Satan's trick. He lures us into sin by convincing us that God is trying to keep good things from us.

This is what he did in the garden of Eden when he tempted

Adam and Eve with fruit from the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil (Genesis 3:1–6).

Centuries later, Satan tried tempting Jesus by taking him to the top of a mountain and showing him all the kingdoms of the world. He offered Jesus all of it if he'd just bow down and worship the devil.

Dealmaking is one of Satan's most productive methods to deceive us. He knows how to make himself and his offers very attractive, especially to those who are sitting on the fence or looking for a way out. Paul warned about Satan's ability to deceive, saying that "Satan himself masquerades as an angel of light" (2 Corinthians 11:14). People with deserting hearts are

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already preoccupied with a longing for the other side. They're thinking and dreaming all the time about jumping the fence. Even when the Prodigal Son lived in his father's household, he dreamed about the other side. This is how many who call themselves Christians are. They go to church. They may even read their Bibles and participate in Christian activities. But they're longing for the other side. They're wishing they could go to that party, wishing they could get drunk, wishing they could see that movie, wishing they could be in that relationship they know isn't good for them. They yearn for what's "out there" and act like they're enslaved to the faith, as though they were horses with bits in their mouths, forced to do the right thing. All the while they're thinking it would be better if they could get to the other side.

When the Prodigal Son had it good, he longed to leave. The

tragedy is that he wanted his father's inheritance without having a real relationship with his father. That's what too many so-called Christians want. They want love, forgiveness, and eternal life, but they don't want a relationship with God. As a result, they dream about the other side and believe that God is holding something back from them.

Jenkins's heart left long before he physically abandoned his post. The Prodigal Son's heart broke from his father long before he asked for his share of the inheritance. Neither man was resilient in the face of temptation.

If we long for the other side, we are in danger of leaving our faith unless we ask God for help. If our heart leaves, it is just a matter of time until the rest of us leaves to find the elusive greener pastures.

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Action Steps

If you find yourself longing for the other side, ask yourself, Do I feel my heart breaking away from my first love, from the way I loved the Lord when I first came to know him? If so, what is the Enemy using to lure your heart away?

How is that thing better than what God has to offer you?

You have the same power as Jesus to overcome the devil's temptations. Even though the devil tried to tempt Jesus with "all the kingdoms of the world," Jesus resisted him. Jesus was already the King of kings, and he didn't even need all the kingdoms of the world. Whatever the devil is trying to tempt you with, God has already given you everything you need.

Spend some time today renewing your mind by thinking about what the Lord has already done in your life. Thank him for all the blessings he's given you and all the ways he's changed you from the time you first came to know him. You're a different person from who you were. If you've found yourself longing for the things of the world, draw closer to the Father so he can satisfy your heart way more than any longing you could have for the things of earth that really will never satisfy.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalm 107

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 5

Regrets

Opponents must be gently instructed, in the hope...that they will come to their senses and escape from the trap of the devil, who has taken them captive to do his will.

2 Timothy 2:25–26

When Sergeant Jenkins was arrested, he was almost immediately overcome by remorse. The illusion that had deceived his heart—about a better life, more freedom, and escape from the military—came crashing down around him. The same thing happened to the Prodigal Son. He spent all his fortune and had nothing to show for it—nothing. Money and so-called freedom did not make his life better. When the money ran out, his friends left him, and all the fun stopped.

Things eventually got so bad that he found himself longing to eat slop with the pigs.

Scripture says the prodigal “came to his senses” (Luke 15:17).

Finally, the blinders came off, and he realized he blew it.

This is the point at which most deserters have a chance to turn around, as the Prodigal Son did. Unfortunately, turning around is not always instantaneous. Once Sergeant Jenkins realized that he’d made the worst decision of his life, there was no easy way out. It would take him almost forty years to return to US custody.

Jenkins thought getting arrested was bad, but his situation continued to get worse. He was kept in prison and forced to recite communist mantras in Korean, even though he didn’t know that language. If he made a mistake or failed to memorize the specified amount, his captors beat him.

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Sergeant Jenkins tried to make a life for himself in prison.

He married a woman who had been abducted from her native country, Japan, and they had two children. Though their marriage was arranged by the North Korean government, Jenkins and his wife tried to make a pseudo-life, yet during the almost four decades in North Korea, he found little peace.⁷

Sin always takes its toll. Scripture says in Galatians 6:8, “Whoever sows to please their flesh, from the flesh will reap destruction.” No matter how promising the other side looks or how the Enemy dresses it up, life eventually gets worse for deserters.

This happens so often. When we desert, we rationalize our actions and try making the best of the earthly hell we've found ourselves in. Sin becomes a substitute for real joy. We end up making ourselves a life in the pigpen while saying, "Oh, the slop is not so bad!" The whole time, we are in slavery.

But even if we've been deserters, we don't have to go through forty years of hell on earth like Jenkins did. We can respond the way the Prodigal Son did and come back to the Father, who always restores.

Action Steps

Describe a time you came to your senses after you'd been acting foolishly.

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How did the devil try to deceive you and dress it up so that you thought your sin would be a good idea?

Describe how God's ways you're living in now are better than all the lies the devil tried to deceive you with.

Take a moment to spend some time worshiping the Lord and thanking him for the ways he has rescued you from the Enemy and set you free to be who you were created to be.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 108

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 6

More False Promises

As a dog returns to its vomit, so fools repeat their folly.

Proverbs 26:11

Even when you take the Enemy's bait and agree to become a deserter, he continues to deceive you. The devil tries to make you think something is good or true when it is not and will most definitely hurt you. Once he has you where he wants you, he will do almost anything to keep you there. He'll tell you all kinds of lies that, too often, seem really believable. That's what deception does. But once you realize what you've done, you repent and get out of the prison you've made for yourself.

But just as a dog returns to its vomit (Proverbs 26:11), many of us start to think, It wasn't that bad. It worked out okay. We forget the horror and the brokenness we found ourselves in and open ourselves to more of it. Too often, we find ourselves going back again and again to the thing that destroyed us in the first place. This ought not to be.

Our verse today is pretty graphic, describing the way a fool returns to his folly. We don't really use that word anymore, but folly means "lack of good sense, understanding, or foresight" or "an instance of foolishness."⁸

When we ignore the Word and listen to Satan's lies and our flesh, we don't think about the future or the consequences of our foolish actions. We just act rashly and go back to the very things that we need to get rid of in our lives.

But when we stay close to Jesus, listening to his voice, reading his Word, and allowing his Spirit to lead us, we can do unbelievable things that we never thought possible, as in this story of Christians from North Korea.

The prospects for Christians living in North Korea are anything but good. If their faith is discovered, they are sentenced to life in one of the nation's prison camps (among the most brutal in the world) or executed outright. There is no doubt that for North Korean Christians, life looks greener on the other side of the demilitarized zone.

Amazingly, some Christians who escaped the tyrannical nation have felt a strong calling from God to return to North Korea to spread the gospel. They are willing to risk everything because they know how desperately the people of North Korea need the light of Jesus.

The following is part of a prayer by a believer about to return to North Korea: "Please provide me with Your power and wisdom, so that I can preach Your love to the people in my country and help them to live according to Your words. Please help us to accept Your words and guide our lives without any fear or worries....I will return back to North Korea without any fear and worry. It is because God is with me."⁹

Action Steps

Have you ever returned to a habit or something you should have gotten rid of in your life a long time ago? Describe what happened. What was it that caused you to repeat this habit, even though you knew it was a foolish thing to do?

What wisdom have you learned to avoid going back to that same trap in your life? What does the Word say about it?

What are the benefits you will enjoy by avoiding that same pitfall in your life?

How do you think North Korean Christians can find the courage to risk everything to go right back into their persecuted nation?

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 109

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 7

There Is Always Hope

Godly sorrow brings repentance that leads to salvation and leaves no regret, but worldly sorrow brings death. See what this godly sorrow has produced in you: what earnestness, what eagerness to clear yourselves, what indignation, what alarm, what longing, what concern, what readiness to see justice done.

2 Corinthians 7:10–11

On September 11, 2004, Sergeant Jenkins turned himself in to the United States Army at Camp Zama in Japan. He knew he would face consequences for his desertion, but he no longer saw the grass on the North Korean side as being greener. After his release, he made peace with the US Army, and he felt they treated him fairly.

By this time, Jenkins' selfish concerns had disappeared, and he had instead become concerned for his children. When asked about his daughters, he said that because he had spent twenty-five days in jail, he hadn't gotten a chance to talk to them much,

but he believed they'd be all right. As he reflected on the whole ordeal, he began to sob, saying that though he had made the biggest mistake of his life by defecting, getting his daughters out of there was one right thing he had done.

Jenkins knew that, technically speaking, he could have been sentenced to death. He was not, and the sentence he received was minimal. He did not object to incarceration. He accepted the punishment as a fair price for the peace of finally making the right choices for his family.¹⁰ His attitude was similar to that of the Prodigal Son, who said, "I am no longer worthy to be called your son; make me like one of your hired servants" (Luke 15:19).

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When we've done wrong, we need to take responsibility for our actions and be willing to pay whatever price we must pay to come clean and make them right. When you really love Jesus, you can't stand to have anything between you and God, such as a lie or any kind of deception. The Holy Spirit will continue to bring it up in your conscience. He won't give you any wiggle room because he loves you. You will feel the conviction of the Holy Spirit saying, Tell the truth! or Stop hiding your sin. You will get to a place where you would rather face the consequences, no matter what they are, and be right with God than continue to live in a lie.

Second Corinthians 7:10–11 talks about godly sorrow.

Imagine that someone in authority corrects you or that you know you've done something you shouldn't have. Godly sorrow

in that situation means that your heart will be sorrowful that you grieved the Lord with your sin. Verse 11 says godly sorrow produces earnestness, eagerness to clear your name, indignation and alarm over your sin, longing for God's love, concern for the people you have hurt, and the desire to see real justice done. Even though these emotions aren't particularly fun, honesty always brings a sense of peace and relief because your spirit longs for truth.

When we give our lives to the Lord, we can trust that, whatever consequence we face, he will take care of us, and it'll be so much better than living a lie or trying to cover up what we've done. We can actually say with the Prodigal Son, I don't care what it takes; I'm coming back to the Father. I'm not expecting to get any special privileges. He can do with me what he thinks best. I just want to be in his house.

When you have that attitude, then you know that your heart is truly repentant.

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Action Steps

Take a moment to ask the Lord to show you if there's anything that's keeping you from being close to him and write it down.

If you discover that you have a deserting heart or if you are already living a full-on deserted lifestyle, ask yourself, How long will I linger in the pigpen before I make up my mind to leave it? Will it take forty years, the time it took Sergeant Jenkins? Or will I leave now? Am I so afraid of the repercussions that await me that I'd rather stay in the slop? Or do I believe that renewing my

relationship with the Father is the most important and worthy choice I could ever make? Take a moment to evaluate your own heart. Describe where you are today with God. Be honest and answer these questions here.

None of us are entirely innocent in this area. Every one of us eventually experiences a situation in which deserting seems like the easiest solution. Thank God we have a high priest, Jesus, who will graciously rescue us if we ask him to. Let the following prayer open the door to your heart and his help: Lord, forgive me for sometimes longing for the other side. Forgive me for being deceived by the Enemy and for thinking that life without you and outside your will is a more attractive option than serving you. Lord, guard my wandering heart so that it might be solely yours. Forgive my deserting lifestyle. I repent! I come running back to you. May my heart always be true. In Jesus' name. Amen.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalms 110–112

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

What are some of the ways that we can be deserters, even when we love the Lord? Take some time to share something the Lord did in your heart this week after reading about the Prodigal Son and Sergeant Jenkins. Discuss ways you can keep your heart close to the Father and stay away from living a deserting lifestyle. Pray for each other for whatever needs you may have.

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Week 10

The Roar of a Lion

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Day 1

When the Devil Attacks

Be alert and of sober mind. Your enemy the devil prowls around like a roaring lion looking for someone to devour.

Resist him, standing firm in the faith, because you know that the family of believers throughout the world is undergoing the same kind of sufferings.

1 Peter 5:8–9

Several years ago, my family and I took a mission trip to Africa. We spent time in Kenya in Maasai territory, where many great safaris are held. Of the forty-two tribes in Kenya, the Maasai have managed to hold on to their culture the most. Their distinctive dress and their abilities as hunter-warriors are legendary. They are a nomadic people who live in constant danger of being attacked by wild beasts. Maasai warriors are trained to fight these animals, including the most feared—the lion.

Some Maasai people have come to Christ! Pastor David, our tour guide in Kenya, is a former Maasai warrior. What I learned from him about the tribe's warrior training was both shocking and illuminating.

When Maasai boys are young, they are trained to resist pain. Their baby teeth are intentionally cut out by adults who tell them they cannot cry or whine over the discomfort. If they

do, the children will be punished. When they get older, some of their adult teeth are cut out. Again, they must not cry or flinch, or they'll be punished. The young boys also have their ears pierced with red-hot rods. If they cry or scream, they will be punished. When some of their other skin is ritually burned with red-hot metal, the same rules apply. No flinching or crying is allowed. When the young men are thirteen or fourteen years of

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age, they are circumcised in front of the tribe. As always, if they scream or complain, they will be subject to severe punishment. All these rituals are designed to prepare young warriors to endure pain, struggle, and challenges. The goal is to equip each one to prevail over the feared lion. They must be ready to endure whatever is necessary to protect the village from the king of the beasts.

One of the final steps in becoming a Maasai warrior comes when the young men and tribal elders leave the tribe for a three-month period in the woods. There, they eat cows and herbs and are taught to kill lions with nothing more than their bare hands, a stick, a spear, and a sword.

You might wonder, as we did, How in the world can you kill a lion with a stick, a spear, and a sword? Pastor David explained that as part of the three-month training, each potential warrior is required to face a lion and either kill or maim it or be killed or maimed. Every Maasai warrior has done this.

The young trainees must listen at night to locate and surround a lion in the jungle. One trainee is selected to face

down the beast. The young warrior-in-training typically holds his spear in his left hand and the stick in the right. The stick is about a foot long and has a point on each end. The beast has learned to fear the spear, so he lunges at the hand with the spear. In that moment, the fighter must switch hands. Now the stick is in his left hand, and the spear is in his right.

As the lion moves to clamp down on the left hand, the boy jams the stick in the lion's mouth. Now the lion's mouth is lodged open with a sharp point on the top and the bottom. Meanwhile, the young warrior-in-training uses his right hand to spear the lion in the neck or heart. Injured, the lion will hesitate and fall back for a minute. Then the would-be warrior grabs his sword and slices the animal's loins until it bleeds out. To the Western mind, the ritual might seem brutal, but for the Maasai, it is essential to survival. Lion hunting is an amazing feat of hand-eye coordination. Once he has defeated

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the lion, the young man has reached the status of Maasai warrior and is allowed to go back to the village and choose any young, single woman as his wife.

What courage. What strength. What resilience.

We have a powerful enemy who, like the lion, also wants to devour us. His name is Satan. First Peter 5:8–9 tells us what to do when he attacks.

First, be sober minded. That means not to think you're above trials or temptation. Be on the alert. The Enemy wants to ruin you and your faith. But God tells us to resist Satan. Stand

firm in your faith. How do you do that? By reminding yourself who you are in Christ and keeping the Word always in your heart. Faith comes by hearing the Word of God (Romans 10:17). You are strong, just like the Maasai warrior. You have the Spirit of God on the inside, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the Word of God, to fight with. You are an overcomer.

Action Steps

First Peter 5:9 tells us that an attack from the devil is not uncommon. The family of believers all over the world is experiencing similar challenges. You are not alone if you are going through trials or temptation of any kind. What kind of trials are you facing right now?

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If you are facing an attack from the Enemy, write down what God says to do about it according to 1 Peter 5:8–9. Write out your specific plans for how you will overcome the Enemy.

Now spend some time and seal your plans in prayer. Be sure to pray 1 Peter 5:8–9 over your life.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 113–115

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 2

Fighting the Impostor Lion

Submit yourselves, then, to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you.

James 4:7

God wants to develop that warrior spirit in every follower of Christ. Whether you think you're naturally a brave person or not, you have what it takes to defeat the Enemy just because you belong to Jesus. Scripture tells us that Jesus is "the Lion of the tribe of Judah" (Revelation 5:5). He is tough. He is fierce. And he is looking for us to grow a backbone and hate the devil. And remember, the devil is only an impostor. First Peter 5:8 says, "Your enemy the devil prowls around like a roaring lion looking for someone to devour." The devil impersonates Christ by putting on a lion persona. Scripture says he's only like a lion. He's not a lion. He's the original copycat. But unless we are trained to have a warrior backbone like the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the impostor could easily intimidate us. We might hear his roar and forget whose we are.

But this impostor doesn't have to intimidate us. We belong to the Lord Jesus Christ, and we are called to confront this impostor lion. But how do we defeat him? How do we prepare ourselves to face the "lions" of temptation and intimidation?

The only way is to be trained by the Lion of Judah, Jesus. We have to learn to take pain, to grow strong, to be strategic, and to think. We must prepare to protect ourselves and those we love from this world's deceptions. We must take back everything the devil has stolen.

We cannot do this by accident. We must be trained. James 4:7 says to first submit your life to God, then resist the devil and

he will flee from you. Don't try to resist him when you're not submitted to the Lord. If you do, the Enemy will be able to deceive and overcome you. But when you're submitted to the Lion of the tribe of Judah, you have his power and authority. You are strong and courageous. Develop a spine. Hate sin. Love what is true.

It is interesting to note that in the Maasai culture, every boy is required to be a warrior. It is not voluntary. It's mandatory. Somehow, in our Christian faith, we think it's optional to learn to resist the Enemy and be strong in the Lord. Sometimes we believe that only a few elite Christians are required to do the fighting and be resilient, but we all must train to face down the impostor lion that stalks and tries to devour all of us. Unless we learn to fight, we will be devoured.

Action Steps

Think over the past week. How has the impostor lion tried to deceive you lately?

Have you forgotten who you are and whose you are? It's time to take back the ground that you've lost, get a backbone, and stand up to the Enemy. What does God say about who you are and this situation where you've been deceived?

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Spend a moment submitting your heart to the Lord in this area. Pray about it and get God's perspective. If a verse comes to mind, write it down here. If not, write out our verse for today,

James 4:7.

Now pray the verse you wrote over yourself and resist the

impostor. When you do, he has to flee.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 116–118

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 3

Who Is This Impostor Lion?

The seventy-two returned with joy and said, “Lord, even the demons submit to us in your name.” He replied, “I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven. I have given you authority to trample on snakes and scorpions and to overcome all the power of the enemy; nothing will harm you. However, do not rejoice that the spirits submit to you, but rejoice that your names are written in heaven.”

Luke 10:17–20

Some people think that Jesus and the devil are like two superheroes with equal power, but that couldn’t be further from the truth. Of course, we know the real truth. Even though the Enemy may be strong and intimidating, he has nothing on Jesus, the Lion of the tribe of Judah.

So if you’re going to win in battle, it’s important to know who your Enemy really is. We’re going to dive right in today and talk about where this impostor lion came from and how to defeat him.

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Satan did not start out as the devil. Surprisingly, he was actually a beautiful guardian angel in heaven named Lucifer. He

was created by God.

So Satan is the created, but God is the creator. Big difference.

Lucifer was the original narcissist. He was so enamored by his own beauty that he began to desire for himself the honor and glory that only belonged to God. Read his story in

Ezekiel 28:12–17:

This is what the Sovereign Lord says:...

“You were in Eden,
the garden of God;
every precious stone adorned you:
carnelian, chrysolite and emerald,
topaz, onyx and jasper,
lapis lazuli, turquoise and beryl.

Your settings and mountings were made of gold;
on the day you were created they were prepared.

You were anointed as a guardian cherub,
for so I ordained you.

You were on the holy mount of God;
you walked among the fiery stones.

You were blameless in your ways
from the day you were created
till wickedness was found in you.

Through your widespread trade
you were filled with violence,
and you sinned.

So I drove you in disgrace from the mount of God,
and I expelled you, guardian cherub,

from among the fiery stones.

Your heart became proud
on account of your beauty,
and you corrupted your wisdom
because of your splendor.

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So I threw you to the earth;
I made a spectacle of you before kings.”
In his own pride, Lucifer tried to rise up against God.
How you have fallen from heaven,
morning star, son of the dawn!
You have been cast down to the earth,
you who once laid low the nations!
You said in your heart,
“I will ascend to the heavens;
I will raise my throne
above the stars of God;
I will sit enthroned on the mount of assembly,
on the utmost heights of Mount Zaphon.
I will ascend above the tops of the clouds
I will make myself like the Most High.”

But you are brought down to the realm of the dead,
to the depths of the pit. (Isaiah 14:12–15)

Lucifer began to boast that he would make himself like the
Most High God. But in the blink of an eye, he was cast out of
heaven and down to earth. There was no battle, no fight, no
argument, no negotiation. He was banished from heaven

forever. Why was there no scuffle in heaven? Because Satan is no match for God Almighty.

In Luke 10:18–19, Jesus said to his followers, “I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven. I have given you authority to trample on snakes and scorpions and to overcome all the power of the enemy; nothing will harm you.” Jesus saw it all happen. He was there when the most beautiful guardian angel rose up, corrupted with pride and arrogance in his heart and wielding his power in front of the Most High God. And just like lightning, Satan fell out of heaven, losing his place and heavenly position. We need to understand that Jesus is the king of the universe and that Satan’s power is severely limited. Jesus gave his disciples, including us, his own authority to overcome all

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the power of the Enemy. We can rest assured that, as long as we stay submitted to God and use his authority, we’ll be safe, protected, and unharmed.

Action Steps

Take a few minutes to write out and memorize Luke 10:18–19, starting with, “I saw Satan fall...”

Snakes and scorpions were and still are some of the most dangerous creatures on the earth. When Jesus spoke these truths to the disciples, he was speaking of the dangers, the evils, the powers of darkness, and the demonic forces in the world.

What “snakes and scorpions” do you have in your life?

Jesus has given you authority over these dark forces. Take our verses today and make them personal. Pray this passage out

loud and insert your own battles: Lord Jesus, you saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven. I know now that he is no match for you. Thank you for giving me all authority to trample on [replace “snakes and scorpions” with something you’re battling with] and to overcome all the power of the Enemy. With you by my side, nothing can harm me. In Jesus’ name. Amen.

Pray this several times with authority until it comes alive in your heart.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalm 119:1–40

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 4

He Has No Hold over You

“You heard me say, ‘I am going away and I am coming back to you.’ If you loved me, you would be glad that I am going to the Father, for the Father is greater than I. I have told you now before it happens, so that when it does happen you will believe. I will not say much more to you, for the prince of this world is coming. He has no hold over me.”

John 14:28–30

As Jesus and his disciples were sharing the Last Supper together before Jesus would be crucified, he began to prepare them for the life-altering events that would take place. Then he added, “The prince of this world is coming. He has no hold over me.” Who did he mean by “the prince of this world”? Jesus was

talking about the devil. Remember when Lucifer was kicked out of heaven as fast as a lightning bolt strikes? God threw him onto the earth. But how in the world could he become a prince? The answer might surprise you. Read the following verses carefully and picture in your mind what actually took place. When you understand the story and history of your archenemy, you can gain the full authority that Jesus wants to give you. In the very beginning when God created Adam and Eve, he also gave them authority over the earth: God said, “Let us make mankind in our image, in our likeness, so that they may rule over the fish in the sea and the birds in the sky, over the livestock and all the wild animals, and over all the creatures that move along the ground.” So God created mankind in his own image, in the image of God he created them; male and female he created them.

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God blessed them and said to them, “Be fruitful and increase in number; fill the earth and subdue it.” (Genesis 1:26–28)

Then God instructed them of the ground rules. He had only one restriction: “The Lord God took the man and put him in the Garden of Eden to work it and take care of it. And the Lord God commanded the man, ‘You are free to eat from any tree in the garden; but you must not eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, for when you eat from it you will certainly die’” (2:15–17).

God gave Adam and Eve this beautiful garden called Eden to work and take care of. Every single tree in the garden was available to them for food to eat except one: the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil.

The serpent was more crafty than any of the wild animals the Lord God had made. He said to the woman, “Did God really say, ‘You must not eat from any tree in the garden’?”

The woman said to the serpent, “We may eat fruit from the trees in the garden, but God did say, ‘You must not eat fruit from the tree that is in the middle of the garden, and you must not touch it, or you will die.’”

“You will not certainly die,” the serpent said to the woman. “For God knows that when you eat from it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil.” (3:1–5)

What a wonderful place to live! Everything was going just fine—until a sinister being in the form of a serpent entered the garden and began to woo Eve with his deceptive words. Her mind reeled with new thoughts she had never considered before: Why would God tell us not to eat of this fruit? We won’t really die! He just doesn’t want us to be like him.

The confusing voice of the serpent convinced Eve that God might not be as good as she thought he was. She thought he was holding out on her. Eating from this tree would give her

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something she was missing. So she ate the forbidden fruit. Then she gave some to her husband, who was with her the whole time

and was also deceived, and he, too, ate from the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil. The one thing that God had warned them not to do, they did! At that moment, Adam and Eve gave away their authority and dominion over the earth. They gave their allegiance to the one they had obeyed—the serpent.

Romans 6:16 says that you become a slave to the one you

obey. Adam and Eve, representing all humanity, had become slaves to the serpent. And who was this sly serpent? You guessed it! Lucifer, the fallen angel who became Satan, the deceiver, the manipulator, the narcissist who wanted God's position, and the one who was thrown out of heaven. Sin and evil had entered the earth, and a new prince took over. God originally intended humankind to rule and reign on the earth, but as soon as they obeyed Lucifer, they handed over their God-given authority to him and he became "the prince of this world." Jesus recognized that Satan was, in fact, a prince (John 14:30). But Satan does not intimidate Jesus one bit. Jesus knows Satan's history, and he knows Satan's future. He saw Satan fall out of heaven and come to earth to deceive people. But Jesus came to earth to do something about it. God had a plan to get back the authority that we had lost through our disobedience, and he would use his Son to do it. Satan had no hold over Jesus, and Jesus would win back what was lost in the garden.

Action Steps

What was the picture of God that the serpent was trying to paint when he deceived Eve?

What lies has he tried to tell you about God?

Now write out the truth about God that exposes these lies.

If you're not sure, find a verse to back up what you believe is the truth.

If Satan has no hold over Jesus and you are in Christ Jesus, what does that say about you? (For a hint, read the title of today's devotion.) Write it out in capital letters and then say it out loud like you mean it. Declare the truth over all the lies you've been believing.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 119:41–80

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

The Lion's Authority

Jesus came to them and said, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age."

Matthew 28:18–20

Have you ever wondered why there are so many tragedies and chaos on this earth? If God is so good and so powerful, why does he allow so many bad things to happen? To answer those questions, we need to go back to the origin of why the world is

like it is and what we followers of Christ can do about it.

We know that God gave Adam and Eve the authority to build kingdoms and subdue and dominate the earth. But when they obeyed the serpent instead of God, they gave their authority away to Satan, and he became the prince of this world. Second Corinthians 4:4 calls him “the god of this age” (little-god). This impostor lion has been wreaking havoc for humanity ever since and has brought all kinds of calamity to the world—sin, poverty, destruction, disease, death, confusion, and strife. Wickedness and sin originated with Satan. As Ezekiel 28:15 says, “You were blameless in your ways from the day you were created till wickedness was found in you.” When he was exiled to the earth, the first thing Satan did was influence God’s sinless humans, Adam and Eve. Satan deceived them, and they disobeyed God’s command that was meant to protect them. They fell hard, giving the rest of humanity a fallen, sinful

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nature. From then on, people would have the tendency to be selfish and prideful.

Since human beings gave the authority over the world away to Satan, for justice’s sake a human had to get it back. Jesus, the Lion of Judah, was the only human qualified to do it. First John 3:8 says, “The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the devil’s work.” God sent Jesus to save us from Satan and all his works and get the authority back for us all. Jesus became a man, was born of a virgin, and experienced all the temptation that we experience. But he never sinned. He never obeyed the

serpent, so the serpent never had power or authority over Jesus. Jesus continually showed his authority over the prince of this world. He forgave sins, cast out demons, raised the dead, healed the sick, calmed the storms, set the captives free. He taught his disciples that because they belonged to him, they could use his authority, too, so they learned to do the same. At the end of his life on the earth, Jesus wielded the final blow over the devil's power. He was falsely accused and sentenced to die on a criminal's cross, even though he hadn't sinned. Although he had the power to resist the soldiers, the Sanhedrin, and all the accusations, he willingly gave up his life, took upon his body my sins and your sins, and took the punishment that we all deserved. The power of God raised him from the dead, and the devil could not stop him. He conquered the power of sin and death for all who would follow him (Hebrews 2:14; Romans 6:10–11).

When he came back from the dead, as he promised he would, he gave one final command to his disciples called the Great Commission. He said, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age" (Matthew 28:18–20, emphasis added).

Jesus not only conquered the devil's authority on the earth

but also gave his authority to us so we can overcome the devil and continue the work that Jesus started, making disciples and teaching them to obey his Word.

So the devil has no power over your life unless you give it to him. You have the authority of Jesus. You have his power to overcome sin and do the same works he did. He has given you assignments to do. So when you look at all the chaos and destruction in this world and you see places where people ignore God's rule, it's time to get to work.

Using his authority starts first with prayer. Jesus told us to pray to the Father, "Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven" (Matthew 6:10). In other words, pray, Father, I want you to rule in this situation. Let your kingdom come in this person's life. May it be like it is in heaven in this home, in my school, in my family, in my life.

Even though the devil is the prince of this world and he's trying to wreak havoc here on earth, we are God's representatives, and we can use Jesus' power and authority, which he has given us, to bring heaven to earth!

Action Steps

In what situations do you see the Enemy wreaking havoc?

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Take a minute to pray Matthew 6:10 (a portion of the Lord's Prayer) over these people and situations. Write your prayer.

Think of some ways you could fulfill the Great Commission by making disciples now while you're young. Maybe you could go on a short-term mission trip. Maybe you could begin

discipling a friend or become a connect group leader. Ask the Lord to show you some assignments he has for you to do right now in your life. Write them down and then commit them to the Lord.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 119:81–120

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 6

When the Devil Tempts You

The devil led him up to a high place and showed him in an instant all the kingdoms of the world. And he said to him, “I will give you all their authority and splendor; it has been given to me, and I can give it to anyone I want to. If you worship me, it will all be yours.” Jesus answered, “It is written: ‘Worship the Lord your God and serve him only.’”

Luke 4:5–8

This week we’ve been talking about this impostor lion called the devil—where he came from and the fact that even though he has power on this earth, he is no match for King Jesus. The devil might be a prince, but Jesus is the King of kings and the Lord of lords!

Let’s look at how Jesus responded to the devil when he was tempted so we can know what to do when we face temptations.

In Luke 4, Jesus had been fasting for forty days, and he was very hungry. In his weakened condition, the devil began tempting him. Satan said, “If you are the Son of God, tell this

stone to become bread” (v. 3).

Jesus answered him, “It is written: ‘Man shall not live on bread alone’” (v. 4). The devil often looks for opportunities when we are weak or tired or hungry to make his move.

Then the devil took Jesus to a high place and showed him all the kingdoms of the world. He said, “I will give you all their authority and splendor; it has been given to me, and I can give it to anyone I want to. If you worship me, it will all be yours” (vv. 5–7).

Jesus answered him, “It is written: ‘Worship the Lord your God and serve him only’” (v. 8).

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Notice that Jesus didn’t correct Satan when he said all the kingdoms of the world were his. Why not? Because they were his! Like we’ve already discussed, Satan is the prince of this world. He tries to get our attention with the splendor of the world—“the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life” (1 John 2:16). But Jesus wasn’t buying it.

Last, the devil had Jesus stand on the highest point of the temple in Jerusalem and said,

If you are the Son of God,...throw yourself down from here. For it is written:

“He will command his angels concerning you to guard you carefully; they will lift you up in their hands, so that you will not strike your foot against a stone.”

(Luke 4:9–11)

Jesus answered the devil, “It is said: ‘Do not put the Lord your God to the test’” (v. 12).

Satan challenged Jesus twice with “If you’re the Son of God...” He was saying, “If you’re really who you say you are...”

This is often his strategy—to question our identity or make us doubt that we have everything we need in Christ. Notice how the devil also used Scripture to try to deceive Jesus: “He will command his angels concerning you to guard you.” This is taken from Psalm 91:11–12. Again, Jesus saw right through his foolishness and didn’t take the bait.

When Satan comes to us, whether he tries to accuse us, deceive us, or tempt us to sin, there is one weapon we have that is so powerful it will send him reeling every time; it’s the same weapon Jesus used on the devil: the sword of the Spirit, which is the Word of God.

Jesus never argued with the devil or tried to outsmart him, and neither should we. We can just say what Jesus said—“It is written”—and then fight with Scripture.

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Ephesians 6:10–11 says, “Be strong in the Lord and in his

mighty power. Put on the full armor of God, so that you can take your stand against the devil’s schemes.” So what is this armor that God gives us? It’s the belt of truth, the breastplate of righteousness, the gospel of peace, the shield of faith, the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the Word of God (vv. 14–17).

All these pieces of armor except one are defensive, meaning

that they protect us when we're under attack. We can defend ourselves with truth, righteousness, peace, faith, and salvation. But one piece of the armor is offensive, and that is our sword. With this sword, which is the Word of God, we make the attack on the Enemy. We can slice and dice all the lies and foolishness that come to our mind by renewing our soul in the Word of God (Romans 12:2). We've been given only one offensive weapon because one is all we need. The Word of God is enough.

Action Steps

Review the three temptations of Jesus and list the strategies the devil uses to tempt us.

Which of these strategies has he used to try to tempt you lately?

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How have you handled this temptation so far?

What verses could you use to remind yourself of the truth and resist him? Write them out here and pray them with the authority that the Lord has given you.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 119:121–160

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 7

The Lion and the Lamb

The next day John saw Jesus coming toward him and said, "Look, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!"

John 1:29

Jesus is both the Lion of Judah and the Lamb of God, who takes

away the sin of the world. How is it possible to be both a lion and a lamb? Lambs are tenderhearted and humble in demeanor. Lions are nothing like lambs. Yet Jesus as the Lamb of God was just as powerful as Jesus, the Lion of the tribe of Judah.

Jesus was moved with compassion when he saw his people scattered “like sheep without a shepherd” (Matthew 9:36). He was gentle, humble in heart, and caring toward the least of these. But he also roared like a lion. You can see the fierceness of his convictions all through the Gospels. He accused the Jews of making his Father’s house a den of thieves (John 2:16;

Matthew 21:13). He told the scribes and Pharisees, “You are like whitewashed tombs...full of the bones of the dead” (Matthew 23:27). Jesus did not hide his contempt for the two-faced hypocrisy of religious-looking people.

This Lamb of God also displayed the greatest power in the universe through his suffering. Isaiah 53:7 says, “He was oppressed and afflicted, yet he did not open his mouth; he was led like a lamb to the slaughter, and as a sheep before its shearers is silent, so he did not open his mouth.”

He “endured the cross, scorning its shame” (Hebrews 12:2). On our behalf, he suffered whipping, mockery, and pain and revealed his quiet dignity in the process. He could have easily fought back or called on an army of angels, but he was on a

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mission. Jesus hung on the cross for six hours but barely spoke for a total of sixty seconds during that span of time.

Consider the statements Jesus made as he suffered:

1. “Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing” (Luke 23:34).
2. “Truly I tell you, today you will be with me in paradise” (Luke 23:43).
3. “‘Woman, here is your son,’ and to the disciple, ‘Here is your mother’” (John 19:26–27).
4. “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” (Matthew 27:46).
5. “I am thirsty” (John 19:28).
6. “It is finished” (John 19:30).
7. “Father, into your hands I commit my spirit” (Luke 23:46).

God used the quiet dignity of the Lamb of God and his death on the cross to ultimately annihilate the power of our archenemy, the devil. It was the only way to defeat Satan. This is how we endure. This is how we are resilient: with quiet dignity and confidence in our God. Scripture says that we have not resisted sin to the point of shedding our blood like Jesus did (Hebrews 12:4). We think we are fighting fiercely against sin, but we have not fought to the death. We must endure as soldiers. Hebrews 12:7 says, “Endure hardship as discipline; God is treating you as his children. For what children are not disciplined by their father?”

Maasai warriors-in-training understand and endure strong discipline. It prepares them to face down lions in hand-to-hand combat! When we face challenging times in our lives, we are doing the same. We are learning to defeat the one who stalks us, the one trying to destroy us.

Being resilient is not about how great we are but how mighty he is.

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I love what Paul said in 2 Corinthians 4:7–11:

We have this treasure in jars of clay to show that this all-surpassing power is from God and not from us. We are hard pressed on every side, but not crushed; perplexed, but not in despair; persecuted, but not abandoned; struck down, but not destroyed. We always carry around in our body the death of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our body. For we who are alive are always being given over to death for Jesus' sake, so that his life may also be revealed in our mortal body.

You may be in a season of suffering. Maybe you're being persecuted, or the Lord is disciplining you. Maybe your heart is sorrowful over the sin around you, or family or friends mock you. Paul basically said, "I'm pressed, but I'm not crushed. I'm enduring some tough times, but they have not ruined me. I have the fire and the life of God burning inside me!" With quiet dignity, you can endure like the Lamb of God. You have his power; you have his authority. You have his Word. You are an overcomer!

Action Steps

What have you been facing lately for which you need the power of the Lamb of God?

Take a moment to meditate on 2 Corinthians 4:7–11. Read the passage slowly out loud. As you do, relate it to what you're

going through by making it a prayer.

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Now ask the Lord how you can be like him through this suffering. How can you endure with quiet dignity as he did?

Take a moment to pray this prayer: Lord Jesus, thank you for enduring the cross for me. Help me be resilient and endure these tough times with your quiet confidence in God. Help me keep my eyes on you. I am grateful that I overcome by the power of your Spirit and not my own strength. In every way that I must die to myself, may my life reveal Jesus to those around me. Thank you for making me an overcomer. In Jesus' name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 119:161–176

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Talk about why Jesus and Satan are not like two superheroes of equal power. Discuss how Lucifer lost his place in heaven and then how people lost their authority on earth. How did Jesus get it back for us? Why is knowing who you are and whose you are important when dealing with the devil? Share with the group some things you overcame this week. Pray for each other to use the authority Jesus has given you.

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Week 11

Relentless Pursuit

Day 1

The Pursuit of Stuff

“Seek first his kingdom and his righteousness, and all these things will be given to you as well.”

Matthew 6:33

Think about the one thing you desire more than anything else in life. You may have wanted it when you were young. Perhaps you couldn't wait until Christmas to get it. Maybe you saved up for it and finally bought it a year later. What things do you crave? Is it fame? Clothes? Money? A boyfriend or girlfriend? A degree? Marriage? More stuff?

In this world, there is always a carrot dangling ahead of us.

It is human nature; we always seem to be chasing something.

And once we get it, we want the next cool thing. It never ends.

We think if we had that car or those clothes or that job, our lives would be bliss, and we'll never want anything else. We may have waited in great anticipation until Christmas or our next

birthday to get what we've been begging to have, but then two days later, we don't remember where we put the thing. We are never satisfied. It seems we have an insatiable desire to pursue earthly things, and those things just leave us empty.

Most of us are pretty relentless in our desires. That means we unyieldingly, steadily, and persistently pursue what we want. Everyone wants something. Jesus addressed our wants and our needs in his Sermon on the Mount (Matthew 5–7):

I tell you, do not worry about your life, what you will eat or drink; or about your body, what you will wear. Is not life more than food, and the body more than clothes? Look at the birds of the air; they do not sow or reap or store away in barns, and yet your heavenly Father feeds them. Are you not much more valuable than they? Can any one of you by worrying add a single hour to your life?

And why do you worry about clothes? See how the flowers of the field grow. They do not labor or spin. Yet I tell you that not even Solomon in all his splendor was dressed like one of these. If that is how God clothes the grass of the field, which is here today and tomorrow is thrown into the fire, will he not much more clothe you—you of little faith? So do not worry, saying, “What shall we eat?” or “What shall we drink?” or “What shall we wear?” For the pagans run after all these things, and your heavenly Father knows that you need them. But seek first his kingdom and his righteousness, and all these things will be given to you as well. (Matthew 6:25–33)

In this passage, Jesus was essentially saying, “I don’t mind you having stuff, but I want you to seek me first. I want to be the all-encompassing love of your life.”

A man once won hundreds of millions of dollars in the lottery and pledged to give a portion of the winnings to his church. He and his wife did give generously to churches and other causes, but their lives soon fell apart.

People constantly asked the man for money for things as trivial as new carpeting and entertainment systems. Their true friends seemed to have disappeared. But what was worse was what happened to their family. They had started giving their teenage granddaughter \$2,000 a week and bought her several new cars. But then they saw her less and less as she began to hang out with a rough crowd who introduced her to illegal drugs. She'd be gone for days at a time until finally she left and never came back. After a two-week search, her body was discovered wrapped in a sheet and dumped behind a van.¹¹ I remember seeing this man's tear-filled eyes in a TV news report. He was so broken. The granddaughter he loved so dearly was gone. The things the world said were important only left him empty. The man said, "I wish I'd torn that ticket up."¹² The very thing so many people dream of having—hundreds of millions of dollars—can destroy lives.

Jesus is not trying to take away our fun. He knows that our pursuit of stuff will only disappoint us and leave us feeling empty. True joy and life only come from seeking him and his kingdom first, above everything else. Jesus promised to provide everything we need when we seek him first.

Have you gotten caught up in the "I want" trap and been consumed by the world's allure, so much so that it's distracted you from God? Maybe your heart has been restless, and you wonder why you don't have peace like you used to. Could it be that stuff or something else you crave is taking the place of Jesus in your heart?

If so, make a fresh decision to make Jesus the all-encompassing love of your life. Let him provide the things you need and quit making them your sole pursuit. Let him, not all the things you wish you had, take up your thoughts. He knows your needs, and he's a good Father. Psalm 37:4 says, "Take delight in the Lord, and he will give you the desires of your heart." It's time to be relentless in your pursuit of God.

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Action Steps

What's taking up your attention or your desires more than Jesus? Describe that something here.

How has it distracted you from God?

Memorize Matthew 6:33 and write it down.

Write out from your heart a prayer of fresh commitment to the Lord.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 120–121

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 2

Pursued by God

"The kingdom of heaven is like a merchant looking for fine pearls. When he found one of great value, he went away and sold everything he had and bought it."

Matthew 13:45–46

When we anticipate getting the things we have longed for, we experience a kind of euphoria. This comes from the hope that

getting these things will make our lives better. We are tantalized, even intoxicated by the idea. The payoff always seems like it will be bigger and better than what we imagine—until we get the thing we desired. Then there is a letdown. Everything feels good for a moment, but before we know it, we're pursuing the next thing.

In Matthew 6, Jesus talked about seeking first the kingdom of God. He knew that we humans would always be seeking something. But instead of seeking things we think will make us happy, he told us to seek his kingdom first.

The way we often pursue material things is the way God pursues us. Matthew 13:45–46 describes a passionate pursuit: “The kingdom of heaven is like a merchant looking for fine pearls. When he found one of great value, he went away and sold everything he had and bought it.” The kingdom is like the person who finds the treasure in the field. We are that treasure, and God relentlessly pursues us.

In fact, he's pursuing every single human being everywhere in the world. He has pursued us from the very beginning, in the book of Genesis. He knew Adam and Eve had sinned, but he returned to the garden of Eden and asked, “[Adam,] where are

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you?” (Genesis 3:9). Instead of being angry at Adam, instead of striking him with lightning, God pursued Adam and cried out, “Where are you?”

God is in hot pursuit of you and of me. He pursues what he values. Because he values you and me, he sent his Son, Jesus, to

pursue us. If we really knew how much God values us, we would never again try to earn our value with how we dress, how much money we make, how good we are at sports, or how popular we are or by bragging about what we can do. If we really knew our value, we wouldn't perform to get other people's approval. God loves us as we are; his approval is all we ever need.

The Maker gives value to the things he makes. Just as a manufacturer sets the prices on its goods, God set his price on us. We are his treasure.

You are the treasure he pursues. That is why he sent Christ—for you.

Action Steps

How have you been trying to earn your value or win approval from other people? Perhaps you brag about your clothing, your funny or witty personality, your athletic ability, your popularity, your talents, or something else?

No matter how much we try to win others' approval, we will never feel "good enough" or satisfied by this pursuit.

Paul said in Galatians 1:10, "Am I now trying to win the approval of human beings, or of God? Or am I trying to please

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people? If I were still trying to please people, I would not be a servant of Christ." Take a moment to memorize this verse and write it down here.

It's time to remind yourself that you are a follower of Christ and that your goal is to please God, not people. And you don't

have to be perfect to please him. You are the apple of his eye, the treasure and joy of his heart. He is pursuing you, so let go of your striving for others' approval and listen to his heart and what he says about you. Ask him to show you how he sees you today and write down your thoughts.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 122–125

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 3

Make Room for Jesus

“Here I am! I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in and eat with that person, and they with me.”

Revelation 3:20

Not only is God relentlessly pursuing all people, but he is pursuing every part of each of us. He doesn't want a quick prayer or just sections of our hearts. He wants every piece of every life. For the rest of our lives, he will show us those areas that we have not fully surrendered to him. He persists so that we can surrender and make more room in ourselves for him. Imagine your life is like a house. You invite Jesus into your house, but without realizing it, you treat him like the pushy, uninvited vacuum cleaner salesperson who just rang your doorbell. You don't want to let the salesperson in at all, but if you are feeling really generous, you might let them into the foyer. You give them a few moments to give their spiel, and you

send them away.

Is that what you do when friends come to your house? No!

You give your friends whatever they want whenever they want it. You empty out your fridge for them. You hang out with them, whether it is convenient or not. You make them feel welcome. You want them to feel at home.

If only we did that with Jesus! Instead, we act as if he is trying to sell us something. If we let him in at all, we confine him to the part of our house that is prim and proper, dressed up for guests. We sit up straight and mind our manners. We don't want to show him how messy the rest of our lives are.

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That is not what Jesus is pursuing at all. He wants to come in and be familiar with us. He wants to know our hearts, our homes, and our lives. He is not looking just to visit. He wants us to give him the keys. After all, he is in charge. He wants to go through the whole house and clean it up.

So what do so many of us do? We tell Jesus, "You can come into my life, but don't go into that closet over there. It's too private. I'll talk to you about it later."

There are some areas of our lives that we're ashamed of. We have suffered pain because of things that have happened to us or things that we have done to ourselves or others. But he is not ashamed. He wants to come into those areas as well. He relentlessly pursues every part of us. He is not a stuffy Sunday-morning God. He is looking for us to open the whole place. He wants to come in, rearrange the furniture, knock down some

walls, and redesign the whole house so it's to his satisfaction.

He is not content with a quick visit in the foyer.

He's an expert at redesigning our lives and putting them back together. We can trust every change he wants to make. So how should we respond? We need to stop pursuing whatever it is we are pursuing above him. Anything that serves as a substitute for him must go. Anything that we run to in order to run from him, we have to let go. We must be relentless about our love for Jesus.

The resilient are the relentless. They don't try to build themselves up so they can brag about their own strength. They are the ones who surrender to him. They let him capture them. They trust him enough to be honest and surrender every part of their "house," their hearts, their lives, their everything to him.

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Action Steps

When you think about this metaphor of your life being a house, where would Jesus be in your house? Is he still in the foyer?

If you're really being honest, would you say you're hiding any rooms from him? Perhaps you've told him, No, you can't go into my friendship closet. I keep my friends to myself. I don't want you telling me what to do in the media area of my life. I'll make those decisions. And when it comes to whom I'm dating, that area of my life is all mine. What parts of your life have you kept Jesus out of?

It's time to surrender your whole house to him. It takes humility to do this. Let him have your whole heart, your whole life—even the parts you have been hiding from him. Ask him if

there's anything you're holding back from him and take some time to pray through those parts of your life, surrendering them to Jesus:

Lord Jesus, today I release all the things I have pursued that are outside your will. Whatever things are of this world, I choose to stop chasing. Instead, I focus on you. I desire to seek you first. I surrender all the parts of my heart and life that I have kept locked away. I open the closets that I have not allowed you to enter. I choose to trust you with these areas of my life. Today, Lord, I ask you for a miracle, a change in my heart. I ask you for the yearning to relentlessly pursue you because in you is the only real fulfillment. In Jesus' name. Amen.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalms 126–130

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 4

The Reality of Pain

Dear friends, do not be surprised at the fiery ordeal that has come on you to test you, as though something strange were happening to you. But rejoice inasmuch as you participate in the sufferings of Christ, so that you may be overjoyed when his glory is revealed. If you are insulted because of the name of Christ, you are blessed, for the Spirit of glory and of God rests on you.

1 Peter 4:12–14

What are some of the things that keep us from relentlessly

pursuing and running after the Lord? One is pain, the reality of which I learned after my second marathon. Seventeen miles into my first marathon, I started to feel excruciating pain and struggled with every single step after that. I was hoping to be in such great shape that there would be no pain at all, so I pushed all the harder in my training for my second marathon. Yet in talking with other marathoners who had much more experience than I had, I realized that even the most energetic marathon runners endure pain.

You cannot complete a race without pain. Any professional or Olympic athlete has to deal with it. You can never eliminate pain; you must learn to manage it. You have to figure out how to handle your mind and heart when your body is in pain.

It's the same way in life. You cannot complete your race on this earth without pain. Pain comes to all of us at one point or another. How will you prepare yourself so that when pain and other challenges come, you can face them down?

Preparing for pain is hard because we've become consumed with avoiding anything and everything that is uncomfortable.

We have become pain-avoidance experts. We think that

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avoiding pain is a sign of strength. But the real strength is found in being resilient. That kind of strength is not loud, obnoxious, or arrogant. It is a controlled strength that Scripture refers to as meekness.

Jesus had to face the pain of rejection just as we do, but he did it with meekness. Luke 9 tells the story of how a whole

village of Samaritans wouldn't welcome Jesus and his disciples.

His disciples were offended by this and wanted to retaliate:

"When the disciples James and John saw this, they asked, 'Lord, do you want us to call fire down from heaven to destroy them?'

But Jesus turned and rebuked them. Then he and his disciples went to another village" (vv. 54–56). Jesus stayed focused on his mission and didn't even respond to the rejection.

Jesus could have avoided or resisted pain, but he chose not to. When Jesus was arrested, his disciple Peter cut off a man's ear to protect him. But Jesus was not looking for human protection. He asked, "Do you think I cannot call on my Father, and he will at once put at my disposal more than twelve legions of angels?" (Matthew 26:53). He was saying, "Look, I have the power, but I'm not exercising it. I know who I am and why I'm here, and I don't need to defend myself." In John's gospel, Jesus

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made it very clear: "No one takes my life; I lay it down. I have the power to lay it down and to take it up again" (John 10:17–18, author's paraphrase).

Jesus was strong; Jesus had a backbone. He showed us how to be resilient, even when the whole world comes against us.

We need to think about how committed we are to avoiding pain. How have we navigated around painful situations or complained our way through unpleasant issues? As a result, how have we failed to develop the strength those challenging times would have produced in us?

Read how the Lion of Judah dealt with pain and rejection.

He could have easily retaliated, rebuked, or resisted. But instead, he stayed resilient in his pursuit of the Father. He kept his cool and was not defensive, intimidated, angry, or hurt. He knew his purpose and didn't get distracted by the pettiness of humans. He stayed prayerful, meek, humble, and servant hearted.

Instead of trying to eliminate or avoid pain, we can pour out our hearts to God and let him strengthen us through each painful situation we face. He knows what we're going through because he suffered plenty of pain when he walked the earth.

As his followers, we are called to share in his sufferings. First

Peter 4:12–14 says we can even rejoice when we face trials and

tests because the Spirit of glory and of God rests on us.

Action Steps

How have you dealt with painful situations in your life?

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Go back and read for yourself the Scripture passages referred to in today's lesson (Luke 9 and Matthew 26). List the ways that Jesus handled his pain.

Now take a minute to pray over your pain and write out a plan of how you will begin handling it the way Jesus did.

Pray this prayer: Lord, create in me the heart of a warrior.

Let me not shrink back when the Enemy attacks. Let me not fall into the trap of intimidation. Teach me to embrace discipline and manage the pain that is sure to come. I want to represent you well, as a good soldier who is willing to endure hardship. Teach me to walk with quiet dignity and confidence in you, the Lion of the tribe of Judah. Thank you that your Spirit rests on me. In

Jesus' name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 131–133

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 5

Focus on the Finish Line

Fight the good fight of the faith. Take hold of the eternal life to which you were called when you made your good confession in the presence of many witnesses....I charge you to keep this command without spot or blame until the appearing of our Lord Jesus Christ.

1 Timothy 6:12–14

I have fought the good fight,
I have finished the race,
I have kept the faith.

2 Timothy 4:7

To be resilient, you must also train your mind to focus on the finish line. One of the things I learned while preparing to run a marathon is that you can train your muscles well, you can have great nutrition, you can be disciplined in your cardio, but if you do not determine that you will finish, you most likely won't. Even if there's no physical reason for you not to cross the finish line, if you don't see yourself completing the race before you run it, you just won't finish. You must be intentional about your state of mind. We don't become resilient and stand strong during crisis by accident.

Many times during a race, you won't feel like running at all. All you'll want to do is quit. Physically, you will be spent, done, empty, but you must focus on finishing the race.

In this life it's also easy to want to quit at times. You may be a teenager, but your race is far from over. To finish well, it's so important to keep your eyes on the goal and the finish line. See yourself serving the Lord for the rest of your life! Think about

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the impact you want to make in this world for Jesus as his faithful follower.

Paul told Timothy, a very young person, the same thing.

Paul was one of the greatest teachers of the gospel and wrote more books of the New Testament than any other follower of Jesus. Timothy was a young man who was like a son to Paul. Some think he was between sixteen and twenty-four years old when he started with Paul and in his thirties when he received the letters from Paul in 1 and 2 Timothy. In 1 Timothy 6:12–14, Paul said to him, “Fight the good fight of the faith. Take hold of the eternal life to which you were called when you made your good confession in the presence of many witnesses....I charge you to keep this command without spot or blame until the appearing of our Lord Jesus Christ.”

Timothy publicly confessed that he was going to be a follower of Jesus, maybe like many of you. In this passage, Paul told him to stay in the race—to keep fighting to keep his faith strong for the rest of his life until the return of Jesus.

It's not easy to stay strong. You have to keep your eyes on

Jesus and your goal of spending time with him every day and staying in the Word of God. This was not easy back then either. But Paul finished his race. He told Timothy this: “I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith” (2

Timothy 4:7).

Paul was Timothy’s example of how to stay faithful until the end. We, too, have countless historical and present-day examples of faithful men and women who have fought the good fight, finished their course, and kept the faith. You can read about them. You can listen to podcasts by them or about them. You can find them in your church and spend time with them, asking them good questions about how they have been resilient in their pursuit of Jesus.

But you also must make daily decisions for yourself to stay strong in the Lord. If you cannot picture this in your mind, it probably won’t become your reality. You have to train to be

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resilient. That is how you make sure you are prepared to be resilient when times are hard and the world seems to be crashing in around you. A resilient pursuit of Jesus does not just happen. You become resilient because, by the grace of God, you prepare to finish the race.

Action Steps

Take a moment right now to imagine yourself serving God fervently when you’re twenty, forty, and sixty. Describe what you see yourself doing and what your faith will be like.

Now spend a few minutes memorizing 2 Timothy 4:7 and

write it here.

Do you know someone who has been walking strong with Jesus for a long time whom you could meet with and ask questions? Name them here.

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What older person whom you admire for their faith could you listen to on a regular basis to help encourage your own faith? (Maybe you don't even know them personally, but you can get their podcast or books.)

Make plans to meet with some older, wiser followers of Christ whom you can learn from and who can help you stay the course in your faith.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 134–136

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 6

Where's Your Mind Set?

Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things.

Colossians 3:2

With so many distractions pulling at our attention from every direction, it is easy to lose our focus. Unless we pull our minds back into the race, finishing it will be impossible. That's why Paul said, "Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things" (Colossians 3:2).

In this life, we have races to run every day. Even if we want to finish strong, pour our lives out for God, and walk with him

all day, with so many distractions pulling at us, it is easy to be misled. For example, think about how many hours of movies and television you might watch per week compared to the one hour of church you attend. In addition to television and movies, most young people either play video games, surf the internet, interact on social media, or engage in other electronic distractions. So what's potentially impacting a young person's mind more: the world or the Word?

Whether you are young or old, you are swamped by distractions. With so many options screaming for your attention, it is easy to wander off course. But you don't have to. You can and must run your own race. No one can run it for you. Only you can train yourself to do this.

How do we do it? Hebrews 12:1–2 says we must “run with perseverance the race marked out for us, fixing our eyes on Jesus.” Each of us has a race to run. It's already planned. We can't compare ourselves with anyone else or our race with anyone else's race. Just because your friend is called to

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something, that doesn't mean you are. You must find out what your race is all about and run it.

But that's not all. You can't run it in your own strength. You have to fix your eyes on Jesus. If your eyes are fixed on social media and culture, that's where your life will go. But if your eyes are fixed on Jesus, he will show you how to run your personal race and give you the faith and courage to do it. He's the pioneer, which means he has gone before you, and he's the

perfecter of your faith.

So how did Jesus run his race? Hebrews 12:2 says, “For the joy set before him he endured the cross, scorning its shame.”

Jesus focused on his goal—the joy before him. We must do the same. We won’t reach the finish line by accident. We finish because we prepared to be resilient. In large part, that means avoiding chronic busyness and anything that might poison our minds. We wouldn’t eat poison or do something intentionally that would kill our bodies. So why would we poison our minds with things that directly oppose Scripture?

In our fast-paced culture, it’s so easy to be consumed by small and unimportant things. So put aside time wasters and things that don’t align with God’s will. Learn what your priorities are and eliminate activities that have no real or lasting importance; they cannot be a substitute for time with Jesus.

Focus on seeking him, listening to his voice every day, and following his leading through the Word of God and his Spirit. Spend time with friends who want the same thing—to pursue the Lord and make an impact on this earth for Jesus.

This is the way to run your race. Wherever your mind goes, you’ll go. So set your mind on things above, not on earthly things. Then you’ll be able to run the race marked out specifically for you and finish well.

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Action Steps

Spend a moment memorizing Colossians 3:2 and write it here.

How can you apply this verse to your life? What God-

opposing things do you need to put aside that you've been setting your mind on?

You may not see the whole picture yet, but what do you know so far about the race marked out specifically for you?

Take a minute to focus your mind and heart on Jesus.

Thank him for setting you free, giving you a new life, and bringing back hope and joy. Ask him to forgive you for setting your mind on anything that's opposed to him or his ways. Ask him to cleanse your heart and mind and give you new resolve to relentlessly pursue him every day.

Talk to your accountability partner about the things you've decided to put aside so you can seek the Lord more persistently.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalms 137–138

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 7

Willing to Pay the Price

What is more, I consider everything a loss because of the surpassing worth of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord, for whose sake I have lost all things. I consider them garbage, that I may gain Christ.

Philippians 3:8

Throughout this trimester, we have talked about the kind of people who are willing to pay whatever price is necessary to follow Christ. We've searched through Scripture and have seen

that this is what Jesus has always desired. It is the reason he was never too quick to take people when they said, “I’ll follow you, Lord!” Instead, he asked them to really think about the commitment they claimed to make. He made them count the cost. He used metaphors like having enough money to build the tower and enough soldiers to win the war (Luke 14:28–33). From the very beginning, these were the kind of followers Jesus wanted—the ones who were willing to count the cost, the ones who had decided that he was worth sacrificing everything for. Truly, they are the only followers he is worthy of. He gave his whole life for us. He is looking for the same kind of devotion he showed. He is our example.

Throughout history, we have seen this kind of devotion.

The apostles lived for Christ, and except for John, they all died as martyrs. Countless disciples were thrown in jail, whipped, or devoured by lions before tens of thousands of spectators. Some were burned alive, serving as human torches for the wicked Roman emperor Nero. These relentless believers refused to recant, even under threat of death. This is the kind of courage,

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the kind of backbone, believers have had since the beginning of the church.

We were born for this, and the church was born out of this.

In story after story, the Evil One tried to crush the church by martyring people. But those who gave their lives for Christ encouraged more people to believe! Secular onlookers wondered, Who are these people who would give their lives and

endure such torture and suffering for what they believe? I have never met anyone like them before. Maybe I should think about what they believe.

If others had not endured, we would never have known about Christ. Those with steel spines throughout the ages passed the faith down to the next generation, and the one after that. Without their stand, the faith could have been stamped out. The only reason we know about grace and forgiveness, the only reason we know what it means to have a new heart, is because of those who were resilient in their day.

Only one question remains: What will future generations say about us? Will they say, “They were faithful. They passed the faith on. When they could have been lulled to sleep by commercialism, capitalism, and pleasure, they endured. They prepared themselves to be resilient so that when challenges came, they were ready”?

It is the resilient who will carry on this legacy. It is the resilient who show God’s grace in action. It is the resilient who fall so in love with Christ that they cannot be controlled or stopped. It is the resilient like Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego who have determined how they will live, regardless of the circumstances they must endure.

Consider places in our world today such as Iraq, Iran, and China. Believers in these lands know that in choosing to follow Christ, they will probably go to jail, be kicked out of their homes,

be threatened, and maybe even be killed. They know it when

they choose to follow Jesus, but they choose to do so anyway.

If you knew for certain that would happen to you when you chose Christ, would you have chosen to follow him?

Let that question sink in.

Millions of brave men and women around the world know what to expect when they choose Christ. Therefore, they count the cost beforehand. They come to him knowing what they are getting themselves into. So when persecution comes, they are prepared. They are ready for the consequences.

The price is high, but it's not too high. Remember that Jesus is the greatest treasure of all. There is no one like him. He paid the highest possible price for us. As A. W. Tozer wrote, "We owe Him every honor that it is in our power to give Him."¹³

Let us be among the resilient. Let it be because we are in love with Jesus and prepared to face even the toughest challenges by God's grace and with his joy.

Let it be said that we endured...that we were resilient.

Action Steps

God has always had a remnant that is resilient. He will have one in this generation. The question we each have to ask ourselves is this: Will I be a part of it? By God's grace, we can, and we will.

How does it affect your faith to know that your forefathers and mothers in the faith paid such a high price so that generations to come would know Jesus?

Who in your life has paid a price for you to know Jesus?

Maybe they've prayed for you or spent time with you to

understand the Bible. Write out who they are to you and what they've done for you.

What do you want future generations to say about you, your faith, and how you lived for Jesus?

Pray this prayer:

Lord Jesus, by your grace, I'm going to pursue you with all that I am and all that I have. By reading your Word, praying to you, and listening to your voice, I will fill myself with your truth. Then I know you will fill me with yourself. Your joy will give me the strength to relentlessly pursue you every day of my life. May I be willing to pay whatever price that you ask me to pay in order to serve you. May the generations that come after me point to my generation and my life and gain courage. In Jesus' name. Amen.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalm 139

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

What kind of distractions in your life are keeping you from pursuing only Jesus? Discuss Galatians 1:10: "Am I now trying to win the approval of human beings, or of God?...If I were still trying to please people, I would not be a servant of Christ."

How does this verse affect your pursuits? What would life look like if you really didn't care about what other people thought of you, only what God thinks? Discuss practical ways to set your mind on things above when you're at school, around friends, or at home. How does it affect your faith to know the high price

believers have paid in the past and in the present for the Lord?
Pray for one another and make courageous commitments to be
a generation that is willing to pay whatever price it takes to be
disciples of Jesus.

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Week 12

Refresh Your Memory

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Day 1

Remind Yourself

I will always remind you of these things, even though you know them and are firmly established in the truth you now have. I think it is right to refresh your memory as long as I live in the tent of this body.

2 Peter 1:12–13

Peter wrote these words to the church right before he died on a cross, upside down. He told his captors that he was unworthy to die in the same way his Lord had been crucified. Peter was resilient and remained faithful to the end, even under severe persecution.

He wanted to remind the followers of Christ of the things Jesus taught them even though they were living faithfully. He felt it was so important to refresh their memory of the promises of God and remind them how to live by faith, goodness, the knowledge of God, self-control, perseverance, godliness,

mutual affection, and love (2 Peter 1:5–7).

As we remind ourselves of what we’ve learned this trimester, it will help us to stay resilient for the rest of our lives.

We need to refresh our memory because the world and the Enemy will constantly be trying to pull our focus away from the things of God. So this last week we want to reflect on what you’ve learned about resilience. Without looking back at your notes, what does resilience mean to you?

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When your faith is shaken, when situations are so uncomfortable or hurtful that you can’t even make sense of them, how do you develop a backbone of steel to remain faithful to Jesus?

Our culture is a feel-good culture, meaning people often make decisions based on their feelings and emotions. They say, “I’m just being true to myself” or “I’m following my heart,” when, in reality, they’re just being true to their feelings and how they feel about the situation.

We mistake our emotions for the real us. Instead of focusing on doing the right thing, we cave in to what the soul demands will make us feel good. If it feels good, we do it. But feelings are like a roller coaster—up and down and all around. As long as feelings are good, life is good, but when feelings plummet, life and relationships take a turn for the worse. When people live by feelings and emotions, they struggle to commit to anything—whether a person, a marriage, a job, even the Lord—because their feelings can sour and change.

So what can we rely on in this feel-good world that can help us stay authentic but remain steady and resilient?

Jesus gave us the answer:

Everyone who hears these words of mine and puts them into practice is like a wise man who built his house on the rock.

The rain came down, the streams rose, and the winds blew and beat against that house; yet it did not fall, because it had its foundation on the rock. But everyone who hears these words of mine and does not put them into practice is like a foolish man who built his house on sand. The rain came down, the streams rose, and the winds blew and beat against that house, and it fell with a great crash. (Matthew 7:24–27)

When we forget God’s Word and live by feelings, the winds and storms of life will beat against us, and we will certainly fall with a great crash. But when we focus on Jesus, hearing his Word every day and practicing his teaching, the winds and storms of life will not harm us because our foundation is on the Rock.

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Action Steps

Describe why being true to yourself or following your heart is a slippery slope.

Why doesn’t God want us to live by our feelings and emotions?

Describe a time when you made a decision led by your feelings that did not turn out well.

Looking back, how would you handle that decision now if you were first to hear Jesus’ words and put them into practice?

Take a moment to pray Matthew 7:24–27 over your life and the decisions you’re currently making: Lord, as the rains and winds come down and beat against the house of my life, I will listen to your words and put them into practice. Help me hear your voice and respond to your Spirit so that my life will remain strong and steady. In Jesus’ name. Amen.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 140–141

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

Follow Jesus

Jesus said to his disciples, “Whoever wants to be my disciple must deny themselves and take up their cross and follow me.”

Matthew 16:24

Everybody’s following somebody or something. It may be a certain band or a certain trend. It’s where our attention, our money, and our thoughts go. We usually follow things that capture our heart and grab our attention. What is currently grabbing your attention?

We can choose to follow ourselves, our flesh, our friends, the culture, whatever is popular and convenient, or whatever lifestyle we’ve learned. Or, when we are confronted with the opportunity to have a brand-new life in Jesus, we can decide to follow him and live the life we were designed to live.

Jesus said that whoever wants to be his disciple must deny

themselves, take up their cross, and follow him. In coming to Christ, we come to a fork in the road. Every day. Following is not just one decision we make when we are thirteen or fourteen years old at a youth event; it's a daily decision to take up our cross, die to ourselves, and follow him.

Following means you're a student of Jesus. You're a continual learner. You learn his "lyrics" and what he thinks about everything. You're listening for his voice and tuning in to

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his Spirit with every move you make. You want to act like him and be like him. Following him is not simply choosing to obey a bunch of rules. It is submitting yourself to his authority. When you're his disciple, you're hungry to know the One you follow. How hungry are you?

As A. W. Tozer wrote, "God discovers Himself to [us]."14 God shows himself to those who are hungry for him. Many passages of Scripture describe the hunger that draws this response from God. Psalm 42:1 says, "As the deer pants for streams of water, so my soul pants for you, my God." Matthew 6:21 says, "Where your treasure is, there your heart will be also." Matthew 13:44 says, "The kingdom of heaven is like treasure hidden in a field....In his joy [a man] went and sold all he had and bought that field."

This kind of followership creates a resilient faith that will sustain us for a lifetime! It doesn't change with the weather, with our feelings, or with good or hard times. It grows and strengthens us every day.

Action Steps

Describe what it means to you to be a true follower of Christ.

How are you currently learning from Jesus and following his teachings?

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Write out and refresh your memory of Matthew 16:24.

What is something that has captured your attention instead of Jesus, and how can you deny it to make room in your heart for more hunger for him?

Spend some time with the Lord, worshiping him and asking him to give you a fresh hunger for his presence. Write out your own prayer from your heart to him.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 142–143

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 3

Are You Fully Alive Today?

“I have come that they may have life,
and have it to the full.”

John 10:10

So often we believers talk about all the bad things we do and how to receive forgiveness. All that is important, but Jesus didn't come to make bad people good. He came to make dead people alive.

When we shut God out of our lives, we listen to what the world says is good or fun. The world tells us to eat this, watch

this, smoke this, drink this, snort this, sleep with him, sleep with her, promising over and over that these things will give us life and happiness. But always, they only give us death. These pursuits may be fun for a time, but in the end, they lead to sadness and confusion.

This is why God doesn't want us to sin. When our lives are free from sin and entanglement with the world, we're most fully alive. When we commit ourselves to Jesus, he breathes life into our dead hearts. Then in a world full of walking dead people, we are lit up like lights in the darkness. We ought to be the most alive thing that our friends, neighbors, classmates, and coworkers have ever seen. Jesus Christ is living through us! Everywhere we go, we bring his life to the people around us.

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Ask yourself, Am I fully alive in Christ? Am I doing the things that a truly alive person would do? Is my heart exploding with the life of God, or am I just pretending that I'm alive?

Answer these questions honestly.

So what does it really mean to be spiritually alive? God is trying to keep us from living as zombies on this earth. Even Christians can live like zombies in seasons of their lives when they're distracted and doing their own thing. They're just existing. They may be believers, but deep inside, they feel dead. If they're just going through the motions of faith, they are not living with joy and purpose like they did when they first came to know the Lord.

We are most fully alive when we are in communion with God. We are most alive when we are submitted, when we're dependent, and when we're connected. We lose that connection when we start tasting a bit of sin here and a bit there, and after a while, we become like light bulbs without electricity. We look the same on the outside, but there's no light coming through. We've allowed the light to go out and darkness to come in. Jesus invites us to enter into the abundant life he offers now rather than waiting till we die and go to heaven. He wants us to taste heaven on earth now. In Matthew 6:10, when he asks us to pray, "Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven," he wants us to ask heaven to come to earth and that our lives would be like heaven—with the same joy, peace, love, and blessing. That's what we experience when we stay connected to him.

The world offers all kinds of distractions to take our minds off our deadness, but if we daily are honest with God by

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pouring out our hearts and surrendering all our weakness to him and if we will seek his ways instead of our own, he will fill us with his life, his joy, and his power to stay on track so we can stay fully alive.

Action Steps

Describe a time when you were the most fully alive and connected to God that you've ever been.

What made the difference?

If you'd say that your heart is not really exploding with the

life of God right now and you're feeling a bit dead inside, what do you think is the cause?

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Take a moment right now to confess any distractions you have allowed in your life that have dimmed your light and passion for the Lord. Write them down here.

Jesus said, "I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full" (John 10:10). Ask the Lord what life he wants you to have and how you can live fully alive in him. Write down what he says and pray that heaven would come to earth.

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 144–145

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 4

Even-If Faith

"[Our God] will deliver us from Your Majesty's hand. But even if he does not, we want you to know, Your Majesty, that we will not serve your gods or worship the image of gold you have set up."

Daniel 3:17–18

The purpose of this trimester has been to equip you to have a rock-solid, persistent faith no matter what. We want you to recognize the Enemy's pitfalls and traps so that you'll be armed and ready when trials come your way.

A lot of Christians waver in their faith when hard times come because of how they believe life should always be. Many think that when you're a Christian, things will always be easy

and work out the way you think they should. Then when things are hard, they question, Does God even love me? or when someone they looked up to failed them, they decide to quit going to church altogether. They think, This Christian thing just didn't work out for me. But they're really thinking, God didn't give me the easy life I wanted. So they bail.

But Jesus is not a Santa Claus God. And our faith is not an "only-if" faith, a conditional faith where we put our own conditions on God. With this type of faith, we tell God, I'll believe in Jesus as long as things go my way. I'll follow you, God, only if you do what I ask.

- Only if my prayers are answered.
- Only if I feel good.
- Only if I don't face too many challenges.
- Only if everything is wonderful.

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The faith God invites us to live is more than a belief in mystical formulas that satisfy our every whim and smooth over every rough patch. He invites us on a journey that includes rough patches and difficult choices, but the difference is that he himself is right there with us in the middle of it all.

We all go through times in our lives when our faith is tested. When that happens, we have to lean in to the Lord more instead of pulling away in hurt or disillusion. We have to remind ourselves of the faithfulness of God by choosing to remember that he has already done so much for us and that he has a bigger picture in mind that we don't see yet.

Remember the “even-if” faith that Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego had? When they were about to be thrown into the fiery furnace because they would not bow down to the king’s idol, they said, “ [Our God] will deliver us from Your Majesty’s hand. But even if he does not, we want you to know, Your Majesty, that we will not serve your gods or worship the image of gold you have set up” (Daniel 3:17–18).

Even if everything comes apart at the seams or even if we don’t understand, we will trust the Lord. Our faith allows for the mystery of God. No human can understand everything about God, yet even-if faith allows us to admit that we don’t know everything. Yes, we’d like answers. Yes, we’d like a formula for everything that happens in life. We’d like every circumstance to come with an explanation, but those are conditions. Even-if faith takes the conditions off. With it, we can say, I’m going to follow Jesus no matter what—even if things don’t go my way, even if I don’t understand why things are the way they are, even if I don’t like what’s happening. I will follow you, Jesus. We need to get to the point where we decide we are okay with not having all the answers.

First Corinthians 13:12 says, “We see only a reflection as in a mirror; then we shall see face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known.” As we grow in faith, we can understand a lot more than we did at first, but

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we only know in part—we don’t understand everything. Our eyes have been opened to the reality of God, but we can’t see as

clearly as we will when we see him face-to-face.

One thing we do know, though, is that God is trustworthy.

God is gracious and forgiving and always loving. God never makes a mistake. God is for us. God wants us to place our confidence in his character, even when we don't understand our circumstances.

In the story of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, the young men were willing to lose their lives for the sake of their God. They trusted him no matter what. And he proved faithful: "Look! I see four men walking around in the fire, unbound and unharmed, and the fourth looks like a son of the gods" (Daniel 3:25).

We will not avoid the fiery trials of life, but Jesus himself will be with us right in the middle of it all. He will never leave us nor forsake us.

Action Steps

How has this trimester on resilience helped you to face tough times differently from before?

Describe a time recently when you've had even-if faith and describe how you had to trust God.

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What is a circumstance in your life where you only see in part, like 1 Corinthians 13:12 says?

You may not understand why everything is happening the way it is, but what do you know about God and his faithfulness that can help you stay strong through it?

Daily Bible reading: Psalms 146–147

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

Spiritual Habits

Train yourself to be godly.

1 Timothy 4:7

To be a disciple of the Lord Jesus is to be his student: to learn from him and to be trained in his ways. The word training is different from trying. We're not trying to be perfect all the time. Too many Christians try and try and try and then fail miserably because they're trying to be godly without connecting with Jesus every day. They're trying in their own strength.

Rather than trying so hard to be a good Christian, Jesus wants our focus to be on seeking him. He wants us to know him and to experience his presence. He says, "My yoke is easy and my burden is light" (Matthew 11:30). When we're connected to Jesus, he does the transforming. He does the changing. We renew our minds in his Word, but he changes our hearts. He gives us the power, the joy, the peace, the game plan, and the motivation. Our part is to seek him.

It's like we're in his boot camp. He trains us. And this training is a process that comes with a routine or habits that we incorporate into our lives. When we practice godly habits over and over, the Holy Spirit has something to work with. He can remind us of a verse we've memorized or give us understanding for how to handle a difficult relationship during our prayer time because we're making ourselves available to him rather than

filling ourselves up with the world's ideas. Just like an athlete's body is transformed by daily eating healthy foods and exercising, spiritual formation doesn't happen overnight. It's a process.

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Action Steps

Take a moment to look back at day 5 of week 7. In that lesson, we discussed ten spiritual disciplines to practice in your life: prayer, worship, Bible reading, silence, service, observing the Sabbath, fasting, solitude, reflection, and Scripture memorization. Read over the descriptions of those spiritual disciplines again.

Which spiritual disciplines have you been practicing on a regular basis?

How have these disciplines helped you grow in your relationship with the Lord?

What disciplines do you want or need to begin practicing to get closer to Jesus?

You may not focus on every single discipline at the same time, but you can grow stronger in your spiritual formation as you practice each one. Sometimes God highlights certain disciplines during specific times in our lives, like prayer for

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instance. Maybe he encourages you to study more about prayer from the spiritual giants in the faith. You might read about their prayer lives, and they inspire you to go deeper in prayer. Spend some time tuning in to the voice of the Lord. Ask him for a game plan for what disciplines he wants you to focus on

now. Write down your thoughts here.

Don't just try harder and harder to practice these disciplines. Let the Lord lead you and guide you so he can work these spiritual disciplines into your life. Then they will become a delight to you. As Zechariah 4:6 says, "'Not by might nor by power, but by my Spirit,' says the Lord Almighty."

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 148

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 6

Give No Place to the Devil

"In your anger do not sin": Do not let the sun go down while you are still angry, and do not give the devil a foothold.

Ephesians 4:26–27

What does it mean to "not give the devil a foothold"? Some translations say not to "give place to the devil." We can be going along just fine in our lives, and then we sin and open up a crack in the door for the devil to jam his slimy foot through and barge right in. Giving "place" to the devil means giving him an opportunity to influence us. Ephesians 4:26–27 says that anger is one of those ways we give the devil a foothold in our lives. Maybe you have an unresolved issue or a conflict with someone you care about. You may nurture an angry heart or hold a grudge. Maybe you're rehearsing a conversation over and over in your head, and you stir up feelings of bitterness, resentment, or even rage. Or you talk about what happened

with people to try to get them on your side (another way of saying that is gossip). Satan loves to twist situations with his lies and deception and magnify them in your heart so that they become all-consuming.

Resentment can lead to all kinds of chaos in our lives.

When we feel offended, we often build walls between us and the people we love, which can divide us from God's people, our parents, the church, or even God himself. Our hearts become cold and unresponsive to the things of God. Many followers of Christ have allowed the Enemy a place or a foothold and, in turn, have become bitter, angry people.

So if we don't want to become one of those people, how do we deal with anger when it comes? Ephesians 4:26 doesn't say,

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“Don't ever be angry.” God knows that we humans will have conflict with other people and get angry from time to time. He doesn't want us to either ignore anger or nurture it. He wants us to deal with it, or the devil will. God's saying, Okay, you're angry. I get it. But in your anger, don't sin. Don't go to sleep angry so that the Enemy can come in and wreak havoc in your life. Deal with it today before it starts putting bitter roots down in your heart.

Ephesians 4:31–32 says, “Get rid of all bitterness, rage and anger, brawling and slander, along with every form of malice. Be kind and compassionate to one another, forgiving each other, just as in Christ God forgave you.” How do you just get rid of anger? Use the principles we've learned about resisting the devil. “Submit yourselves, then, to God. Resist the devil,

and he will flee from you. Come near to God and he will come near to you” (James 4:7–8).

When you’ve been offended, hurt, and left with an angry heart, go to God with it. Don’t run away from him and nurse your wounds. He wants to heal you, comfort you, and restore you. So always be honest with him. Pour out your heart to him. Cry if you have to. Submit it all to him. He already knows what happened, what was said, and how you feel. Let him minister to your heart. Then ask him to take your anger and help you forgive the person who hurt you. You can’t forgive by yourself. He’ll give you understanding and new eyes to see them. He’ll melt away the feelings of anger, and you’ll be free.

Once you’ve submitted your heart and whole situation to God, you’re ready to resist the devil. Luke 10:18–19 says you’ve been given Jesus’ “authority to trample on snakes and scorpions and to overcome all the power of the enemy.” Use your authority in Jesus’ name to command Satan to get out and stay out! He’ll turn tail and run as fast as he can. You’ve slammed the door in his face and bolted it so he can’t get back in. First

John 4:4 says that “the one who is in you [Jesus] is greater than the one who is in the world [the devil].”

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Action Steps

On a scale of one to ten (one being the least and ten being the most), how tender is your heart for the Lord today?

If you’re feeling cold or numb toward the Lord, what might you have allowed into your life that would open the door to the

Enemy's influence? There are other ways besides unforgiveness or an angry heart that we can give place to the devil, such as willful sin or rebellion against authority. Ask the Lord what may be blocking your receptivity to his Spirit.

Now that you've realized what's going on in your heart, practice James 4:7–8. Submit yourself to the Lord. Come near to him, and he'll come near to you. Pour out your heart to him in prayer and write your thoughts down here.

Repent and let the Lord change your thinking to the way he thinks about the situation. Then you can resist the devil, and he will flee from you, run away, vanish!

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If you have an offended heart, practice Ephesians 4:32: "Be kind and compassionate to one another, forgiving each other, just as in Christ God forgave you."

Whatever your situation is today, ask the Lord what he wants you to do to practice his Word. Write down what he reveals to you.

As followers of Christ, we must learn to keep a close watch on our hearts. We shouldn't just deal with these things that separate us from God and each other once in a while, but we must daily allow the Holy Spirit to bring up the issues of our heart so we can stay on fire for the Lord and keep the Enemy out.

Daily Bible reading: Psalm 149

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

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Day 7

We Are the Resilient

“As long as it is day, we must do the works of him who sent me.”

John 9:4

Congratulations! You have successfully walked through twelve weeks of learning more about how to be resilient in your faith.

You have prayed, sought the Lord, memorized verses, listened to the Holy Spirit, and responded to his voice. You have done the hard thing at times. What was the most challenging thing the Holy Spirit directed you to do during this trimester?

What is your favorite Scripture verse or passage that you have meditated on or memorized this trimester?

You have been transformed to be more like Jesus than you were twelve weeks ago. What is the most significant thing Jesus has done in your heart these last three months?

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Being a disciple of the Lord is a continual process that you practice and live out individually and with the posse of Jesus seekers in your connect group. This group helps keep each member strong and steady through accountability, transparency, honesty, encouragement, and prayer. In what ways has your connect group this trimester helped you to stay resilient and strong in the Lord?

How have you encouraged others or helped them stay strong?

What do you hear when Jesus says to you, Follow me? How do these words affect your lifestyle?

You’ve learned a lot about spiritual formation, which is the

process of transforming a person to be more like Christ. You've established new spiritual habits and disciplines in your life to

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help you stay on target and keep growing. What habits will you continue after this trimester?

You've also learned some things to avoid, pitfalls that easily pull you away from the Lord and distract you from your purpose. Maybe other people can do some of those things, but when you do, the Holy Spirit makes it very clear to you through a check in your spirit or a sudden absence of peace that this activity doesn't please God. What are those things that you personally need to stay away from to stay close to Jesus?

In John 9:4, Jesus said to his disciples, "As long as it is day, we must do the works of him who sent me." Jesus used the words we must. It's not an option. He is strongly urging each of us to do what he tells us to do daily: to reach those around us with his light. Jesus had an assignment and a mission on this earth, and he has given each of us a specific assignment too. Ask the Lord what your task is for this season of your life and write it here.

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Each of us has a sphere of influence that Jesus has given us. He brings opportunities our way to influence others for his kingdom. Maybe you're good at sports, so people look up to you. Maybe you're really outgoing, so you're good at pulling people out of their shells. Maybe you're really smart, so you can help people understand their schoolwork. Perhaps you're musically

talented and can use your gift to lead people into the presence of the Lord. Maybe you have compassion for lonely or overlooked people. You can use what the Lord has given you as an open door to share his life with others. What are your opportunities?

We're so proud of you for completing another trimester. We are confident that God will continue the good work he has started in you because you were born to be resilient!

We want to end this trimester with a declaration. Say it out loud and with the authority of the Lord:

We are the resilient. We are fierce because we follow the Lion of the tribe of Judah. We are relentless not because we are high and mighty but because he is the Almighty. We learn the difference between the roar of heaven and the roar of the impostor, and we never put off our work to bring others to Christ. Individually and as a group, we leave a legacy of resilience.

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Daily Bible reading: Psalm 150

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Tell the group the most meaningful thing or significant transformation the Lord did in your heart this trimester. Share how this group has helped you grow in the Lord. Make sure that each person is affirmed and thanked for their contribution to the group—don't leave anybody out. Now put each person in the "hot seat," gather around them, and pray for their strength and resilience. End by reading the declaration in one accord

with the members of your group:

We are the resilient. We are fierce because we follow the Lion of the tribe of Judah. We are relentless not because we are high and mighty but because he is the Almighty. We learn the difference between the roar of heaven and the roar of the impostor, and we never put off our work to bring others to Christ. Individually and as a group, we leave a legacy of resilience.

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Conclusion

Congratulations! You have finished the sixth trimester of the Pathway to Freedom series. Don't forget all the ways God has spoken in your heart over the last twelve weeks and keep pursuing him every day of your life. Your journey with God doesn't stop here.

To help you become a more resilient follower of Christ, now you can get your copy of Pathway to Freedom (Trimester Five): Breaking the Addiction to Distraction and gather with your connect group. Together you will learn to determine what distracts you, discern Satan's deceit, hold fast to God and his truth, form authentic relationships, use media intentionally, and become alive in Christ.

Remember that our goal is to become lifelong followers of Jesus and make disciples of others. As you progress through the next trimesters, you will find yourself becoming more like Jesus because you are following him more closely, and you will be more equipped to bring others along with you on the journey.

Let the adventure begin!

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Endnotes

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Authors' Note

As you continue your adventure with Christ, we encourage you to pray this over yourself each day as you begin a fresh pursuit of his reality every morning.

Disciple's prayer:

I am a follower of Jesus Christ, the Savior of the world, and today I will be seeking his kingdom. May it intervene in every activity I have. I am renewing the way I think in every dimension of life so that I can be transformed to live more like Christ today. I am connecting with other disciples to help propel me in my quest, and today I will engage the Father, the creator of the universe, because I know he cares about every hair on my head.

After you complete this book, please email us at ronluce100@gmail.com and describe what the Lord has done in your life and with your connect group.

About the Authors

Ron and Katie Luce have spent their lives helping younger generations genuinely connect with Jesus and thrive in their faith.

They have hosted millions of young people

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reaching and discipling the next
generation. See www.generationnext.me for
more information.

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